

QUESTS OF RABU SHIN

Tales of the Krasis



A FIFTH-EDITION FANTASY CAMPAIGN

★ LEVELS 1-12 ★

QUESTS OF RABU SHIN

TALES OF THE KRASIS

A Fifth-Edition Fantasy Adventure for Characters of Levels 1–12

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Vael Turog Campaign Setting

Credits & Use

- Campaign concept, setting, quests, and original creatures: Tim McIntyre.
- Adventure development and editorial organization: created from the author's campaign draft and supplied artwork.
- Cover and interior illustrations: original campaign artwork supplied by the author.
- Rules framework: designed for use with the fifth edition of the world's most famous fantasy roleplaying game.

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Development Edition. This volume begins the professionally formatted master edition. Later chapters, appendices, monster entries, handouts, and maps will be added to the same book structure.

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Campaign Overview

Quests of Rabu Shin: Tales of the Krasis is a continent-spanning campaign of investigation, dark fantasy, biomantic horror, siege warfare, and arcane conspiracy. The adventure begins with local disturbances in Greymoor Hollow and expands through twelve settlements as the characters uncover a linked network of engineered mutation sites. Each region reveals a different stage of Rabu Shin’s work: aquatic adaptation, volcanic resilience, ecosystem integration, military coordination, amphibious fusion, political financing, mobile mutation, glacial preservation, genome reconstruction, and finally ascension in the floating city of Aetherfall.

The Krasis are not accidental monsters. They are deliberate combinations of living creatures, elemental traits, arcane structures, and adaptive magic. Rabu Shin believes natural evolution is too slow and too wasteful. Through crystalline lattice nodes, hidden laboratories, corrupted relays, and willing patrons, he is transforming Vael Turog into a proving ground for directed evolution.

Characters begin as travelers drawn to rumors of malformed livestock and dying fields. By the finale, they must confront a distributed intelligence capable of rewriting life across entire environments. Victory requires more than defeating Rabu Shin. The heroes must decide whether the lattice should be destroyed, contained, or reprogrammed—and what degree of change any person has the right to impose upon another.

Campaign Progression

Levels	Region	Escalation
1–3	Greymoor Hollow	Local mutations and the first lattice shard
3–5	Stonewake Port & Emberfall	Aquatic and thermal adaptation
5–8	Lunareth, High Bastion & Marrowfen	Ecosystem corruption, warfare, and production
8–10	Silverreach, Duskmire Crossing & Frostharbor	Funding, mobile trials, and preserved consciousness
10–12	Sunspire, Blackroot Enclave & Aetherfall	The genome archive, preparation, and final ascension

Running the Adventure

Adventure Structure

Each chapter is organized for quick use at the table. Settlement overviews establish local tone; keyed locations provide NPCs, rumors, and clues; primary parts form the chapter's central path; optional parts deepen the settlement and provide alternate advancement. Read-aloud passages appear in shaded boxes. Text outside those boxes is intended for the Dungeon Master.

Character Advancement

The campaign uses hybrid milestone advancement. Characters advance when they resolve the major threat of a settlement and recover the chapter's critical evidence. Optional quests provide treasure, allies, and additional context but are not required for advancement unless the group bypasses a primary quest.

Difficulty and Scaling

- For three characters, remove one minor creature from encounters containing four or more enemies.
- For five or more characters, increase boss hit points by 20 percent or add one minor creature.
- Do not increase every difficulty class. Let additional characters improve the party's reliability.
- When an encounter is described as cosmetic mutation only, use the listed standard stat block without mechanical changes.

The Lattice Clue Chain

The campaign's investigations are cumulative. Early clues should not reveal the whole conspiracy. Instead, repeat visual and magical motifs: geometric runes, green or crimson pulses, metallic scents, crystalline residue, unnaturally coordinated behavior, and fragments of Rabu Shin's philosophy. The party should gradually move from "something is wrong" to "someone is directing it" to "the system can function without its creator."

DM Principle: Never hide the only path forward behind a single ability check. A successful check provides clarity, speed, or extra information. Failure introduces cost or uncertainty, not a dead end.

The Continent of Vael Turog

Vael Turog is a land shaped by extremes and endurance. Mountain ranges divide its heart, ancient forests dominate the east, volcanic ridges smolder in the west, and broad southern deserts conceal ruins beneath shifting dunes. Frozen seas batter the northwest coast, while the floating city of Aetherfall hangs above the central mountains as a monument to arcane ambition.

Twelve major settlements anchor civilization: Frostharbor in the northwest; Stonewake Port on the western coast; Greymoor Hollow in the central plains; Emberfall at a volcanic mountain; High Bastion atop the central range; Marrowfen in marshlands east of Greymoor; Sunspire in a southwestern desert oasis; Duskmire Crossing in the southeastern desert; Lunareth in an ancient eastern forest; Aetherfall above High Bastion; Blackroot Enclave inside the mountains south of Emberfall; and Silverreach east of High Bastion.



Map of Vael Turog

Adventure Hooks

Use one or more of the following hooks to bring the party together. The characters should begin on the Lowroad within a mile of Greymoor Hollow.

Livestock Bounty. Mayor Harlowe has circulated word that Greymoor Hollow will pay armed travelers to investigate malformed livestock and unexplained animal attacks.

Spoiled Grain Shipment. A Stonewake merchant rejected Greymoor grain after discovering that every kernel was hollow. The characters have been hired to determine whether the shipment was sabotaged.

Missing Shepherd. Young Tomas vanished after claiming he saw glowing marks in a pasture. A relative asks the characters to find him before nightfall.

Arcane Curiosity. A scholar in Lunareth has heard rumors of animals displaying directed transmutation and asks the party to collect a sample.

Roadward Duty. The party is traveling through Greymoor when a wounded farmer warns that wolves have become unnaturally bold along the Lowroad.

OPENING PREMISE

Strange reports begin as whispers carried by trade caravans and market gossip: livestock born with too many limbs, fields dying in perfect circles, and animals that move with unnatural purpose. The road to Greymoor Hollow offers the first proof that these stories are not superstition.

Chapter 1

GREYMOOR HOLLOW

THE SHEEP THAT HOWLED

Recommended Levels 1–3 • Starting Level 1 • Hybrid Milestone Advancement

Chapter Purpose. Greymoor Hollow introduces the Krasis, establishes the repeated lattice motifs, and turns ordinary rural fears into evidence of deliberate transformation. Characters should reach 3rd level after resolving the Missing Shepherd and confronting the Shepherd Krasis.



Greymoor Hollow settlement map

Greymoor Hollow

Greymoor Hollow is a practical farming settlement of low stone walls, timber cottages, grazing pastures, and crop fields divided by a narrow stream. Its people are cautious with outsiders but quick to cooperate when their harvest is threatened. Recent events have strained that reserve: livestock breathe incorrectly, corn rots before harvest, tools corrode near the stream, and a faint green shimmer sometimes moves along the waterline after dark.

Starting the Chapter

WHY THE ADVENTURERS ARE HERE

The Lowroad bends between stone fences and fields yellowed by late summer. Greymoor Hollow lies less than a mile ahead, its chimney smoke rising in thin gray columns. You have come seeking work, answers, or simply a safe roof before nightfall. Then the birds fall silent. In the tall grass beside the road, something begins to growl.

Part 1: The Lowroad Ambush

THE WOLF REVEALS ITSELF

A broken cart wheel lies half-buried in the roadside dust. Beyond it, the grass shivers without wind. A low, strained growl rises from the ditch—wet, uneven, and followed by a second breath from the same throat. A shape lunges into the road. It is a wolf, but one shoulder bulges beneath stretched hide, and a half-formed foreleg twitches against its ribs. Its eyes glow faintly green.

Encounter: Partially Mutated Wolf. Use the wolf stat block. The mutation is cosmetic and does not alter its challenge rating. The wolf begins 20 feet from the nearest character and attempts to knock isolated targets prone with its bite and Pack Tactics only if another hostile creature becomes involved.

Terrain. The road is 15 feet wide. Tall grass on each side is lightly obscured and counts as difficult terrain for Small creatures. The broken wheel provides half cover.

Developments

- At half hit points, the wolf releases a warped howl that echoes too long. A distant answer comes from the direction of Greymoor's pastures.
- A character examining the body with a successful DC 12 Arcana check detects residual transmutation magic beneath the skin.
- A successful DC 12 Investigation check reveals a faint geometric scar burned beneath the wolf's fur.
- The abandoned cart contains grain sacks, a broken lantern, and a bloodstained farmer's cloak. Tracks indicate the driver fled toward town.

AFTER THE AMBUSH

The creature collapses in the dust. Its malformed limb twitches once and becomes still. Beneath the patchy fur, a precise geometric scar has been burned into the flesh. The air around the body smells faintly of wet iron. Beyond the road, the fields remain unnaturally quiet—and Greymoor Hollow waits less than a mile ahead.

Continuing to Greymoor Hollow

ARRIVAL AT GREYMOOR HOLLOW

The final stretch of road passes silent sheep pastures and cornfields whose outer rows have turned gray. The village sign creaks above the road: GREYMOOR HOLLOW — HARVEST ENDURES. Farmers stop their work as you pass. A mother pulls her child indoors. Somewhere behind a barn, a sheep bleats with a sound that almost resembles a human cough.

The villagers direct armed strangers to Mayor Harlowe, who has taken a table at the Mudhaven Inn to hear reports. Characters may visit other locations first, but the mayor provides the clearest route into the chapter.

Keyed Locations in Greymoor Hollow

- 1. Mudhaven Inn** — A warm but tense public house run by Hilda Mudhaven, a practical human commoner with 12 hit points. Farmers exchange rumors here, and Mayor Harlowe uses the back room for emergency meetings.
- 2. Shepherd's Croft** — Young Tomas's home and the epicenter of the livestock mutations. Sheep pens, a low barn, and a ruined pasture surround the croft.
- 3. Raff's Smithy** — Raff, a lawful good dwarf using the guard stat block, distrusts magic. Tools left near the stream corrode in patterned lines.
- 4. Farmer's Market** — Several stalls remain closed. Grain appears sound from the outside but is hollow within. This location begins *The Well That Whispers* and *The Crimson Cornfield*.
- 5. Brimblecup's Sundries** — A traveling natural philosopher recently purchased preserving salts, lamp oil, wire, and glass vials. The buyer was a Krasis scout.
- 6. Old Horn Apothecary** — The herbalist has seen doubled fish gills and a green shimmer in water samples. She offers two healing potions at half price in exchange for help.
- 7. Fletcher's Cottage** — Humanoid tracks behind the cottage pace in repeating geometric patterns before turning toward the stream.
- 8. Eldric's Farm** — Dying crop circles, black milk, moving farm tools, and the silent scarecrow make this farm a recurring center of the chapter.

Greymoor Rumors

d6	Rumor
1	Something beneath the central well breathes after sunset.
2	A scarecrow on Eldric's farm changes direction every night.
3	Tomas saw sheep walking on the barn wall.
4	The stream glows green when the moon is hidden.
5	A peddler's tonic cured pain, then made a farmer's bones crack.
6	Corn in the northern field bleeds when cut.

Part 2: Mayor Harlowe's Concern

THE MAYOR SPEAKS

Mayor Harlowe removes his hat as you approach. Deep shadows sit beneath his eyes, and a stack of written complaints lies untouched beside his ale. "You came down the Lowroad," he says. "Then you have already seen one of them." He lowers his voice. "Farmer Eldric has reported dying fields, frightened cattle, and a scarecrow that will not remain where he leaves it. Last night, he found it facing his bedroom window."

Harlowe offers 25 gp to investigate Eldric's farm, plus meals and lodging at the Mudhaven Inn. He does not use the word "curse" in public, but he fears that panic will destroy Greymoor as surely as crop failure.

Roleplaying Mayor Harlowe

- Voice: tired authority, measured words, urgency concealed beneath civic restraint.
- Ideal: Greymoor survives because neighbors act before fear takes hold.
- Bond: he promised the families of Greymoor he would keep their children safe.
- Secret: he has received two reports of sheep speaking, but has withheld them to prevent panic.

Part 3: The Silent Scarecrow

Farmer Eldric and his daughter Mira meet the characters at their farm. Eldric is stubborn, exhausted, and ashamed that he is afraid of his own field. Mira is observant and insists that the scarecrow moves only when no one looks directly at it.

ELDRIC'S FIELD

Rows of corn sag inward around a thirty-foot circle of gray, brittle soil. At its center stands a scarecrow of burlap, straw, and dark wood. It faces away from you. No wind moves its coat. The field smells of split stems and something chemical beneath the soil. Then, from somewhere inside the corn, a dry stalk snaps.

Investigation

- DC 11 Nature: the plants have been drained of vitality rather than diseased.
- DC 12 Arcana: residual transmutation magic radiates from the soil in a geometric pattern.
- DC 13 Investigation: the scarecrow post bears the same lattice scar found on the wolf.
- A character who watches the scarecrow while another looks away notices that its head has changed angle when attention returns.

- Digging beneath the post reveals a thumb-sized crystal filament connected to dead roots. Removing it ends the field's pulse.

Development: At night, the scarecrow rotates to face whichever character carries the wolf's scarred hide or the crystal filament. It is not alive; the lattice uses it as a marker and observation point.

THE FIRST LINK

Eldric turns the crystal fragment over in his weathered hands, then drops it as a faint green pulse runs through its center. "That thing was in my soil," he whispers. Beyond him, the scarecrow's empty burlap face now points toward the road leading deeper into Greymoor.

Part 4: The Mutated Pool

Clues from the farm, apothecary, and Fletcher's Cottage lead a quarter mile upstream to a shaded bend where the water glows under moonlight.

THE STREAM BEND

The stream widens into a shallow pool beneath leaning willows. Green light drifts below the surface in slow pulses. Fish crowd the edges, their gills opening in doubled pairs. A flat stone at the center of the pool rises like a lid—and the reeds around you begin to shake.

Encounter. Three giant rats and one swarm of insects attack. Their extra eyes and hardened growths are cosmetic. The swarm emerges at the end of the first round unless the characters disturb the reeds first.

Discovery

Beneath the flat stone lies a crystalline shard etched with geometric runes. It is inert but magical. When a creature first touches it, that creature hears a calm whisper inside its thoughts: "Refinement requires iteration." A DC 15 Arcana check confirms directed transformation rather than natural mutation.

Part 5: The Well That Whispers

THE WELL AT DUSK

The market square empties as dusk settles. The central well stands beneath a crooked wooden frame, its rope swaying although the air is still. From below comes a wet scrape, then a breath drawn through stone. A bucket rises coated in gray slime. Something whispers from the dark—not in words, but in the cadence of a voice trying to learn them.

Encounter. One gray ooze clings to the well lining 15 feet below the rim. A swarm of rats bursts from a side crack when the ooze is first damaged. The narrow well makes ranged attacks difficult; a creature climbing without a secured rope must succeed on a DC 10 Athletics check.

Developments

- The ooze has consumed a lattice-tainted runoff deposit and is not a designed Krasis.
- The rats flee if reduced below half hit points after the ooze is destroyed.
- Cleaning the lowest stones and sealing the runoff crack stops the whispering.
- A silver ring worth 15 gp lies in the ooze's residue; it belonged to a missing farmhand.

Part 6: Harvest Moon Howl

THE MOONLIT PACK

The harvest moon hangs enormous above Eldric's fields. Three wolves move along the crop line, low and silent. A fourth shape rises behind them, larger than a dire wolf, with thornlike growths splitting the skin along its spine. It lifts its head. The howl that follows rattles dry kernels from the stalks.

Encounter. Three wolves and one Thornfang Krasis. Use dire wolf statistics for the Thornfang, with AC 14. Its bite deals an extra 1d4 piercing damage from embedded thorns. At half hit points, its back splits and the thorns extend, but this is cosmetic.

Tactics and Terrain

- The wolves use Pack Tactics and attempt to pull characters into the corn.
- The Thornfang attacks prone targets and guards the escape route toward Shepherd's Croft.
- The corn is lightly obscured beyond 10 feet and counts as difficult terrain.
- Tracks after the fight show the pack was circling livestock rather than hunting randomly—as if herding prey toward the croft.

Part 7: Milk Gone Black

THE WARPED CALF

The barn doors stand open. Inside, cattle crowd against the far wall, their eyes rolling white. A calf occupies the nearest stall alone. Its hide ripples as though something moves beneath it. Thick black fluid drips from its mouth and hisses when it touches the straw.

Encounter. One Warped Calf. Use boar statistics and add Acid Spit: ranged weapon attack, range 20/60 feet, +3 to hit, one target, 1d6 acid damage. The calf fights only while cornered or when the black grain in its trough is disturbed.

Clues

- The calf ate grain from a sack marked with a tiny geometric brand.
- The black fluid is mildly acidic but loses potency after one hour.
- A DC 12 Medicine check reveals crystal fibers growing through the calf's digestive tract.
- The sack came from a market shipment handled by the Traveling Peddler.

Part 8: Missing Shepherd

Mayor Harlowe finally admits that Tomas has vanished and that several sheep now possess too many legs. Tracks from the croft lead to an abandoned upper pasture and a barn built against a low stone ridge.

THE SILENT PASTURE

The pasture is silent. Six sheep stand in a loose ring around the barn, their bodies misshapen beneath dirty wool. Some have six legs. One turns its head farther than its neck should allow. Above them, clinging upside down to the barn wall, hangs a thin humanoid figure wrapped in a shepherd's torn cloak. It smiles with Tomas's face.

Encounter. One Shepherd Krasis and six Krasis Warped Sheep. The Shepherd uses the cultist stat block and has Spider Climb. The sheep use wolf statistics with 9 hit points each. They fight without bleating and attempt to knock characters prone for the Shepherd.

Shepherd Krasis Tactics

- Begins on the wall or ceiling and throws stones or uses a light crossbow until approached.
- Uses Spider Climb to change surfaces without provoking opportunity attacks when possible.
- Commands the warped sheep to surround isolated characters.
- At half hit points, whispers: "Evolution requires suffering."

Developments

- If captured, the Shepherd Krasis cannot explain Rabu Shin's plan; its mind contains repeated instructions and sensory impressions.
- Tomas is no longer recoverable. His memories surface only as fragments in the Krasis's speech.
- A carved lattice sigil in the barn beam matches the wolf, scarecrow, and stream shard.
- A concealed packet contains notes on livestock response rates and a route toward Stonewake Port.

CHAPTER REVELATION

The last warped sheep falls, and silence returns to the pasture. In the barn, a page of precise observations lists dates, temperatures, feeding schedules, and mutation rates. At the bottom, one sentence has been written in a different hand: "Rural viability confirmed. Begin aquatic strain."

Optional Greymoor Quests

These quests may be completed before or after Missing Shepherd. Use them to deepen the mystery, provide additional treasure, or advance characters who bypass earlier encounters.

Part 9: The Crimson Cornfield

THE BLEEDING HARVEST

A farmer brings down his sickle. The corn stalk opens with a wet snap, and dark red fluid runs across his hand. All around you, the field shivers although there is no wind. Beneath the rustle comes another sound: roots dragging through soil.

Encounter. Two vine blights hide among the corn. They use Entangling Plants to restrain characters while attacking from opposite rows.

- The field is difficult terrain and lightly obscured beyond 10 feet.
- Destroying two buried crystal seeds ends the bleeding within 1d4 hours.
- Each seed is worth 10 gp to an arcane researcher but risks spreading contamination if mishandled.

Part 10: Bandits on the Grain Road

ROADSIDE ROBBERY

An overturned grain wagon blocks the road. Sacks have been cut open, but the spilled grain lies untouched. Four armed figures rise from behind the stone wall. Their leader steps forward, one arm swollen beneath leather wrappings and ending in a grafted claw. “Leave the wagon,” he says, “and keep your hands where I can count them.”

Encounter. Four bandits and one bandit captain with a grafted arm. The captain gains +1 damage on melee attacks and has advantage on the first attack roll it makes during the encounter.

- The bandits were paid to steal specific branded grain sacks, not valuables.
- The captain received the graft willingly as payment.
- A letter directs delivery to a traveling peddler outside Stonewake Port.

Part 11: Swarm in the Barn

THE RAT KING

The barn floor seems to ripple beneath the straw. Then the straw erupts. Rats pour between the boards in two black waves, and at their center crawls a knot of tails, teeth, and fused bodies moving as a single creature.

Encounter. Two swarms of rats and one Rat King. Use swarm of rats statistics for the Rat King, increase its hit points to 30, and give it Pack Tactics.

- A creature knocked prone in the barn is immediately surrounded if a swarm can reach it.
- The Rat King nests above a crystal filament beneath the floor.
- Removing the filament ends the rats' unnatural coordination.

Part 12: The Traveling Peddler

Lucien Vale arrives at the market selling miracle tonics. This is primarily a social encounter. Use the spy stat block if combat occurs.

MIRACLES FOR SALE

A lacquered wagon rolls into the market beneath chiming brass bells. Its owner bows with theatrical grace and lifts a vial of pearlescent liquid. "Aches dissolved, vigor restored, and age itself persuaded to loosen its grip," he announces. A farmer drinks. His posture straightens—then the bones in his hand crack loudly beneath the skin.

Social Encounter Goals

- Identify the tonic as a diluted mutation catalyst with DC 13 Arcana or Medicine.
- Prevent villagers from consuming additional doses.
- Follow or persuade Lucien to reveal his supplier.
- Recover his ledger linking Greymoor's trials to coastal shipments.

Lucien's Escape. If exposed, Lucien uses Cunning Action to flee through the market. He carries a smoke pellet that heavily obscures a 10-foot radius until the start of his next turn.

Part 13: The Broken Plow Curse

THE PLOWS MOVE

Moonlight glints from an iron blade moving through the field. A plow drags itself across the soil with no animal before it and no hand upon its handles. Another follows, carving a perfect spiral into the earth. Both stop at once. Then their blades turn toward you.

Encounter. Two animated plows. Use animated armor statistics with AC 16, 25 hit points, and a slam that deals bludgeoning damage.

- The plows attempt to charge in straight lines and knock characters prone.
- The spiral they carve is a lattice calibration symbol.
- A buried metal-and-crystal device worth 40 gp powers both objects.
- Destroying or removing the device ends the animation immediately.

Concluding Chapter 1

Milestone Advancement

Characters advance to 3rd level when they defeat or neutralize the Shepherd Krasis, secure evidence of directed mutation, and convince Mayor Harlowe that the threat is arcane rather than a local curse. If the party has completed only the minimum encounters, award the level after the final revelation in the barn.

Rewards

- Mayor Harlowe's payment: 75 gp for resolving the full livestock threat.
- Eldric's reward: preserved food, free lodging, and a family heirloom worth 25 gp.
- Old Horn Apothecary: two potions of healing at half price, or one free potion after the well is cleansed.
- Lattice shards: important campaign keys. They are magical evidence, not intended for sale.
- Optional quest rewards: 15–40 gp each, favors from farmers, and improved reputation in Greymoor.

Greymoor's Aftermath

The settlement returns to work, but not to innocence. Crops begin recovering after the lattice filaments are removed. Ordinary animals remain skittish near the stream. Mayor Harlowe quietly records every strange report and asks the party to carry warning to Stonewake Port, where Greymoor's grain and livestock are shipped.

TRANSITION TO STONEWAKE PORT

Morning settles over Greymoor Hollow with the sound of ordinary sheep and axes striking honest wood. Mayor Harlowe meets you at the village bridge. "Stonewake receives everything we grow," he says, handing over a sealed letter. "If whatever did this traveled with our shipments, the harbor needs warning." Downstream, the water catches the sun—and for a single heartbeat, flashes green.

If the Characters Leave Early

- Day 3: two warped sheep attack a farmer.
- Day 5: villagers barricade homes and trade stops.
- Day 7: the Shepherd Krasis drives a full livestock outbreak through the market.
- Stonewake receives contaminated grain, strengthening the aquatic lattice node in Chapter 2.

Appendix A: Chapter 1 Creatures

Partially Mutated Wolf — Use Wolf statistics. Mutation is cosmetic.

Thornfang Krasis — Use Dire Wolf statistics; AC 14; bite deals +1d4 piercing damage.

Warped Calf — Use Boar statistics; add Acid Spit, +3 to hit, range 20/60 ft., 1d6 acid damage.

Krasis Warped Sheep — Use Wolf statistics with 9 hit points.

Shepherd Krasis — Use Cultist statistics; add Spider Climb.

Grafted-Arm Bandit Captain — Use Bandit Captain statistics; +1 melee damage; advantage on first attack.

Rat King — Use Swarm of Rats statistics; 30 hit points; Pack Tactics.

Traveling Peddler — Use Spy statistics.

Animated Plow — Use Animated Armor statistics; AC 16; 25 hit points; slam damage is bludgeoning.

Shepherd Krasis: Encounter Profile

The Shepherd Krasis is not intended as a durable solo boss. Its danger comes from vertical positioning, the warped flock, and the emotional horror of recognizing Tomas within the creature. Keep it moving across walls and rafters. Let it repeat simple phrases as though recalling instructions rather than speaking with full agency.

Signature Line: “Evolution requires suffering.” Deliver it quietly, as a statement of learned doctrine rather than a battle cry.

Appendix B: Clues and Campaign Links

Clue	Found At	Meaning
Geometric scar	Wolf, scarecrow, barn beam	A repeated lattice marking, proving a shared source.
Crystal filament	Eldric’s field, barn floor	A local node that drains or directs living systems.
Whispered phrase	Stream shard	First indirect contact with Rabu Shin’s philosophy.
Branded grain	Barn and market	Mutation can be distributed through trade goods.

Observation notes	Shepherd's barn	Greymoor is a controlled rural experiment.
Aquatic strain order	Shepherd's barn	Direct transition to Stonewake Port.

Production Roadmap

The next book section will expand Chapter 2: Stonewake Port — Tides of Bone with the same format: settlement overview, keyed locations, five primary quests, five optional quests, encounter developments, rewards, chapter transition, creature appendix, and integrated maps.

CHAPTER 2

STONEWAKE PORT

TIDES OF BONE

Recommended Levels 3–4 • Starting Level 3 • Hybrid Milestone Advancement

Chapter Purpose. Stonewake Port expands the threat beyond Greymoor Hollow. The characters discover that lattice contamination has been deliberately planted along a major trade route, encounter the first aquatic Krasis strains, and learn that Rabu Shin is evaluating environmental adaptation rather than spreading random corruption. Characters should reach 4th level after destroying the harbor lattice anchor and defeating the Bone-Tide Krasis.



Stonewake Port settlement map

Stonewake Port

Stonewake Port is a crowded western harbor of weathered piers, stone seawalls, fish markets, ropewalks, smithies, shrines, and steep streets climbing toward Hillwatch Temple. Fishing boats and merchant vessels normally fill the bay. Now many remain tied at dock. Nets return sliced apart. Fish arrive with doubled gills and hardened spines. Sailors report green lights moving beneath the water, and the drifting merchant vessel Grey Tern entered the harbor without a living soul aboard.

ARRIVAL AT STONEWAKE PORT

Gulls wheel above a forest of masts as the road descends toward Stonewake Port. Dock bells ring, sailors shout, and waves strike the seawall in heavy gray bursts. Beneath the salt, tar, and fish is another smell—metallic and sharp, like blood on a blade. A bell begins tolling from Starboard Pier. Men run toward the water. Something has overturned a skiff inside the harbor.

Starting the Chapter

- **Greymoor Connection.** A rejected shipment of hollow grain bears the seal of a Stonewake merchant, drawing the characters west to investigate contamination along the trade route.
- **Mayor Harlowe's Request.** Harlowe asks the party to warn Dockmaster Rennik that Greymoor's stream carried crystalline residue toward the coast.
- **Merchant Escort.** A caravan hires the characters after two coastal wagons vanish near Stonewake.
- **Hillwatch Summons.** Priestess Lyra has received reports of "the tide being rewritten" and seeks adventurers who have already encountered lattice magic.

Chapter Flow: The chapter can be run as a mostly linear mystery: rescue the sinking skiff, gather clues at the port, investigate the lighthouse and cursed nets, board the Grey Tern, then descend to the harbor anchor. Optional quests can be inserted between major parts or used while the party waits for tides and weather.

Keyed Locations in Stonewake Port

1. **The Octopus' Tankard** — A loud dockside tavern built around the preserved skeleton of a giant octopus. Captain Meryn Holt owns the establishment and knows every ship entering the harbor.
2. **Starboard Pier** — The busiest pier and the site of recent current shifts, scraped hulls, and the sinking-skiff emergency.
3. **Seafront Fish Market** — A maze of stalls where mutated catches are quietly discarded before customers see them.

4. Hillwatch Temple — A wind-beaten temple and lighthouse complex overlooking the bay. High Priestess Lyra studies the spiritual and magical disturbance in the tide.

5. Hiltsrick Smithy — A respected marine forge. Hiltsrick has found fractal corrosion in anchors and hull fittings.

6. Rigid Brick Smithy — Hiltsrick's rival. The owner dismisses supernatural explanations but has secretly stockpiled warped metal samples.

7. Foarncloak Apothecary — An apothecary specializing in seasickness, venom, and waterborne illness. The owner can identify strange salts and tissue samples.

8. Seaworthy Inn — A quieter lodging house used by merchants. Survivors and witnesses can be found here.

9. Port Bazaar — A crowded market of imported goods. Smugglers, relic dealers, and House Varin agents operate among legitimate merchants.

10. The Grey Tern — A merchant vessel drifting at anchor beyond the inner pier. Its crew is missing and its cargo hold contains the largest clue in the chapter.

Stonewake Rumors

d8	Rumor
1	A ship returned without its crew, but every cabin door was locked from within.
2	The lighthouse keeper has not shown the proper signal in two nights.
3	Fishermen pulled up a net full of white finger bones.
4	Something large scrapes the underside of Starboard Pier after midnight.
5	Hillwatch priests say the tide is moving against the moon.
6	A pearl diver found green crystal growing from an old anchor chain.
7	A smuggler is paying silver for mutated fish.
8	The Grey Tern carried sealed crates from Silverreach.

Part 1: The Sinking Skiff

CRISIS AT STARBOARD PIER

A fishing skiff rolls violently beside Starboard Pier. One sailor clings to the overturned hull while another disappears beneath the water. Dockworkers throw ropes, but the current pulls sideways—toward the center of the harbor instead of out to sea. Beneath the gray surface, a pale shape circles once, trailing a faint green glow.

Immediate Objective. Rescue both sailors before the skiff is dragged under. Run this as a three-round hazard encounter. Each round, one character can attempt a rescue action while others control ropes, repel creatures, or enter the water.

- Athletics DC 12: Haul a sailor or the skiff 10 feet toward the pier.
- Acrobatics DC 13: Leap onto the unstable hull without falling prone.
- Survival DC 12: Read the current and direct the dockworkers, granting advantage to the next rescue check.
- A spell that controls water, grants movement, or creates a secure line automatically earns one success if used sensibly.
- Three successes rescue both sailors. One failure causes a character on the skiff to make a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw or fall into the water.

Hostile Creature. A giant crab with glassy green growths attacks anyone entering the water. Use the giant crab stat block. It retreats after taking 10 damage or when both sailors are safe.

AFTER THE RESCUE

The current releases all at once. The skiff slams against the pier, and the rescued sailor coughs seawater across the boards. Wrapped around his ankle is a strand of translucent weed threaded with tiny green crystals. “That current,” he gasps. “It pulled from below.”

Dockmaster Rennik arrives within minutes. He offers 20 gp for immediate help and promises another 80 gp if the party can identify and end the source of the harbor disturbance.

Roleplaying Dockmaster Rennik

- Voice: clipped commands, sailor’s profanity, concern hidden behind irritation.
- Ideal: the harbor survives only when everyone does their duty.
- Bond: Stonewake fed his family for three generations.
- Secret: he ordered the Grey Tern left untouched because the first boarding party heard voices below deck and fled.

Part 2: Ghost in the Lighthouse

THE DARKENED BEACON

The path to Hillwatch Temple climbs above the harbor through salt-stunted grass. The lighthouse beam sweeps across the waves, flickers green, and dies. A moment later it returns—pointing inland. From the tower comes the slow ringing of a handbell, though the door hangs open and no one stands inside.

Keeper Maelis is alive but trapped in the lens chamber by an animated concentration of seawater. She altered the beacon crystal after noticing its green pulse, and the bound energy reacted violently.

Encounter. Use one water weird. The creature remains bound to the circular lens basin. It attempts to restrain a character and drag that character toward the open maintenance shaft. A creature falling into the shaft drops 20 feet to a lower platform and takes normal falling damage.

Disabling the Beacon. A character adjacent to the lens can use an action to attempt a DC 14 Arcana or Religion check. Two successes suppress the green resonance, reducing the water weird's AC by 2 and preventing it from restraining more than one creature at a time.

THE HIDDEN LINE

As the final green pulse fades, the lighthouse lens clears. Far below, the harbor briefly appears transparent. A geometric line of light runs from the Grey Tern to a point beneath Starboard Pier, then vanishes into darkness.

Maelis gives the party a brass lighthouse key, two flasks of holy water, and a hand-drawn chart marking where the green line vanished.

Part 3: Salt-Cursed Nets

THE MARKET CATCH

The Seafront Fish Market has gone quiet. A wide fishing net lies stretched across three tables, stiff with white salt and tangled around dozens of dead fish. Each fish has two sets of gills. In the center of the net, something moves beneath the pile.

The net animates when touched. Use a rug of smothering stat block, but describe it as salt-encrusted rope animated by lattice residue. Replace its suffocating damage description with abrasive salt and tightening knots; its mechanics remain unchanged.

Clues. A DC 13 Nature check confirms the fish adaptations improve oxygen intake. A DC 14 Arcana check identifies deliberate transmutation. A successful DC 12 Investigation check finds a bone-white scale marked with the same geometry seen in Greymoor.

Fishmonger Ansel witnessed a pale humanoid creature cut the nets from beneath the water. It moved toward the cracked eastern dock and carried a staff made of fused bone.

Part 4: The Cracked Dock

DAMAGE FROM BELOW

The eastern dock leans toward the water. Every piling bears a matching fracture, as if struck at the same instant from below. Barnacles have grown in precise spirals around the cracks. Beneath the boards, something clicks slowly against the wood.

Characters inspecting beneath the dock discover three sahuagin scouts searching for lattice fragments. They are not allies of Rabu Shin; the altered currents have driven them from deeper water. The encounter can become combat or negotiation.

- A character who speaks Aquan or succeeds on a DC 14 Persuasion check can prevent combat.
- The sahuagin call the harbor node “the green heart” and fear the priest-creature guarding it.
- They have seen two giant octopus-like Krasis feeding near the anchor.
- If attacked, they fight until one is reduced to half hit points, then attempt to escape into the harbor.

Negotiated Aid: If the party earns the scouts’ trust, the sahuagin reveal a submerged access tunnel beneath the Grey Tern. This grants advantage on the first navigation check during the Harbor Depth sequence.

Part 5: The Grey Tern

THE ABANDONED VESSEL

The Grey Tern rocks gently beyond the inner harbor, sails furled and anchor chain taut. No watch answers your approach. A meal remains set on the stern table, silverware stained black by salt. Every cabin door is closed. From below deck comes a slow scrape, followed by three knocks from inside the hull.

The vessel is divided into four keyed areas. Characters can approach by Rennik's launch, swim from the pier, or use the submerged route described by the sahuagin.

A. Main Deck — No bodies are present. A DC 13 Investigation check finds drag marks ending at a hatch. The ship's log records increasingly strong currents and a green light beneath the hull.

B. Crew Quarters — Bunks are undisturbed. A locked sea chest contains 35 gp, a healer's kit, and a letter warning the captain not to unload Silverreach cargo without a House Varin agent present.

C. Cargo Hold — Crates have burst from within. Two swarms of quippers occupy waist-deep water. The quippers retreat if the water is drained or purified.

D. Bilge and Lattice Anchor — A crystalline growth has pierced the hull without admitting seawater. It pulses in time with the harbor current. Removing it awakens the creatures below.

The Missing Crew. The crew was dragged through the bilge breach into the submerged tunnel. Three bodies can later be found near the harbor anchor. One sailor, Mara Venn, remains alive in an air pocket and can be rescued during Part 6.

The Lattice Anchor

THE SEEDED HARBOR

The bilge glows beneath ankle-deep water. A crystal mass the size of a barrel has grown through the timbers, yet no water leaks around it. Thin green veins spread across the hull in perfect branching patterns. When you approach, a whisper forms inside your thoughts: "Aquatic strain viable. Continue pressure."

The anchor can be detached with three successful checks before two failures: DC 15 Arcana, DC 14 Athletics, or DC 14 thieves' tools. Each check represents one minute. On a failure, the anchor pulses and each creature in the bilge takes 3 (1d6) psychic damage.

Once detached, the anchor opens a circular gap into the submerged access tunnel. The party can rest before descending, but the harbor worsens if they delay more than eight hours.

Part 6: The Harbor Depth



Harbor Depth tactical encounter map

THE GREEN HEART

Cold water closes overhead as you follow the glowing fracture beneath the ship. The tunnel opens into a drowned plaza of broken docks and ancient stone. Two swollen shapes drift between the pilings, each resembling an octopus reinforced with bone and crystal. On a shelf of black rock stands a tall, scaled figure holding a staff of fused ribs. Green light burns behind its eyes.

The Harbor Depth contains two Giant Octopus Krasis and one Bone-Tide Krasis. Unless the party used magic to breathe underwater, Hillwatch Temple provides four potions of water breathing before the descent. Creatures without a swimming speed follow the normal underwater combat rules.

Battlefield Features

- **Broken Pilings.** A creature adjacent to a piling has half cover from ranged attacks.
- **Air Pocket.** Mara Venn is trapped in a pocket beneath an overturned launch. Reaching her requires an action and a DC 12 Athletics check.
- **Lattice Heart.** The central crystal has AC 15, 35 hit points, immunity to poison and psychic damage, and vulnerability to thunder damage. Destroying it ends all lair pulses.

- **Strong Current.** At initiative count 20, each creature not holding a fixed object must succeed on a DC 13 Strength saving throw or be moved 10 feet toward the lattice heart.
- **Clouded Water.** When a Giant Octopus Krasis uses Ink Cloud, the area is heavily obscured until the end of its next turn.

Enemy Tactics

- The octopus Krasis begin hidden among pilings and attempt to grapple lightly armored characters.
- The Bone-Tide Krasis remains near the lattice heart, using Tidecall to reposition enemies and Bone Spear against spellcasters.
- If the lattice heart is reduced below half hit points, the Bone-Tide Krasis orders one octopus to shield it while the other attacks the nearest character.
- At 20 hit points or fewer, the Bone-Tide Krasis attempts to merge with the lattice heart, regaining 15 hit points unless a character adjacent to the heart uses a reaction to interrupt it with a successful DC 14 Arcana, Athletics, or weapon attack roll.

THE BONE-TIDE KRASIS SPEAKS

The priest-creature raises its ribbed staff. “Surface forms fail beneath pressure,” it says in a voice like stones rolling under surf. “Rabu Shin provides correction.” The green crystal behind it beats once, and every current in the chamber turns toward you.

Ending the Battle

When the Bone-Tide Krasis and lattice heart are destroyed, the altered current collapses. Characters have three rounds to leave the chamber before debris seals the tunnel. A character can use an action to free Mara Venn. If the party rescued her, Stonewake’s merchants later add 50 gp to the reward.

THE TIDE BREAKS

The crystal fractures with a sound too deep to hear. Green light races through the drowned stones, then goes dark. For a heartbeat the harbor becomes utterly still. The current reverses, rushing toward open sea, and above you the bells of Stonewake begin to ring.

Optional Quests in Stonewake Port

Part 7: Smuggler's Hold

A warehouse near the Port Bazaar contains crates of alchemical salts and preserved Krasis tissue. Four bandits and one spy guard the cargo. Shipping ledgers connect the operation to a Silverreach intermediary and reference “urban adaptation materials.” The smugglers surrender if their leader is reduced below half hit points and offered protection from House Varin.

Reward. 75 gp in confiscated goods, one potion of climbing, and evidence that can later grant advantage during an investigation in Silverreach.

Part 8: Mutant Seagulls

A flock of six aggressive gulls attacks the fish market. Use two swarms of ravens, describing the birds as salt-crustured gulls with translucent wing membranes. The flock has been feeding on discarded mutated fish. Capturing or studying one reveals that the corruption spreads through consumption but fades when separated from an active lattice node.

Reward. The fishmongers provide 25 gp and enough preserved rations for ten days.

Part 9: Shipboard Plague

The merchant ship Dawn Petrel is quarantined after crew members develop hardened skin and fever. The condition is caused by powdered lattice crystal hidden inside medicinal tea. Characters can identify the contamination with a DC 14 Medicine or Investigation check and cure six sailors using lesser restoration, appropriate magic, or a three-success DC 13 Medicine challenge.

Complication. The ship's surgeon knowingly accepted the powder from a masked buyer. He flees toward the bazaar if confronted.

Part 10: Pearl Heist

A sacred pearl used by Hillwatch Temple to calm storms has been stolen by a relic dealer. Recovering it requires tracking the thief through the bazaar, negotiating with dockside criminals, or infiltrating a guarded counting house. Returning the pearl allows High Priestess Lyra to transform it into the Pearl of Mutation Resistance.

Pearl of Mutation Resistance. While carrying this uncommon wondrous item, a creature has advantage on saving throws against effects that would alter its form. Once per long rest, when the bearer fails such a saving throw, it can reroll the save and must use the new result.

Part 11: Storm Below

After the harbor anchor is damaged but before it is destroyed, a localized storm forms directly above the bay. Run a four-success skill challenge using Athletics, Arcana, Nature, Survival, or vehicle (water) proficiency. On three failures, one dock structure is destroyed and the final Harbor Depth encounter begins with the lattice heart at full temporary power, granting each Krasis 10 temporary hit points.

Chapter Resolution

Rewards

- Dockmaster Rennik pays 100 gp for ending the disturbance, plus 50 gp if Mara Venn survives.
- Hillwatch Temple grants the Pearl of Mutation Resistance if the Pearl Heist was completed; otherwise Lyra gives two potions of water breathing and two potions of healing.
- Captain Meryn Holt offers free passage aboard a merchant ship traveling toward Emberfall or Silverreach.
- Recovered Silverreach correspondence becomes evidence for Chapter 7.

Milestone Advancement

Characters advance to 4th level when they destroy the lattice heart, defeat the Bone-Tide Krasis, and prevent the harbor from collapsing into panic. If the party bypasses the final battle through exceptional planning, award the milestone when the harbor node is permanently neutralized and its purpose is understood.

What the Characters Learn

- The mutations are being caused by placed lattice devices, not a natural disease.
- The devices test adaptations suited to specific environments.
- Rabu Shin or his agents can communicate through the lattice network.
- Silverreach financiers and trade routes are involved in moving research materials.
- Similar disturbances have been reported around Emberfall's volcanic mines.

TOWARD EMBERFALL

By morning, the harbor has changed. Fishing boats leave their moorings. Market stalls reopen. The metallic taste beneath the salt is gone. Yet among the recovered cargo is a heat-blackened shipping seal from Emberfall and a note written in precise geometric script: "Aquatic pressure confirmed. Proceed with thermal strain."

If the Characters Fail

Time	Consequence
Day 1	The Grey Tern sinks and blocks the inner harbor.
Day 3	Fishing crews refuse to leave shore; food prices double.
Day 5	A naval patrol is dragged beneath the water by Krasis predators.
Day 7	Stonewake imposes a total blockade, spreading shortages throughout western Vael Turog.

Appendix C: Chapter 2 Creatures

Giant Octopus Krasis

Large aberration, unaligned

Armor Class 14 (crystalline hide) | Hit Points 76 (8d10 + 32) | Speed 10 ft., swim 60 ft.

STR 18 (+4) DEX 13 (+1) CON 18 (+4) INT 5 (-3) WIS 12 (+1) CHA 4 (-3)

Saving Throws. Con +6; Skills Perception +3, Stealth +5; Damage Resistances acid; Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 13; Languages —; Challenge 3 (700 XP).

Amphibious. The Krasis can breathe air and water.

Adaptive Camouflage. The Krasis has advantage on Dexterity (Stealth) checks while underwater or against stone and timber surfaces.

Crystalline Grip. A creature grappled by the Krasis takes 3 (1d6) piercing damage at the start of each of its turns.

ACTIONS

Tentacles. Melee Weapon Attack: +6 to hit, reach 15 ft., one target. Hit: 13 (2d8 + 4) bludgeoning damage, and the target is grappled (escape DC 14). Until this grapple ends, the target is restrained, and the Krasis cannot use Tentacles on another target.

Acid Jet (Recharge 5–6). The Krasis sprays acid in a 30-foot line that is 5 feet wide. Each creature in the line must make a DC 14 Dexterity saving throw, taking 18 (4d8) acid damage on a failed save, or half as much on a success.

Ink Cloud (Recharges after a Short or Long Rest). A 20-foot-radius cloud of dark green ink extends around the Krasis underwater. The area is heavily obscured for 1 minute or until dispersed by a strong current.

Bone-Tide Krasis

Medium aberration, lawful evil

Armor Class 16 (bone lattice) | Hit Points 110 (13d8 + 52) | Speed 30 ft., swim 40 ft.

STR 15 (+2) DEX 14 (+2) CON 18 (+4) INT 13 (+1) WIS 16 (+3) CHA 14 (+2)

Saving Throws. Con +7, Wis +6; Skills Arcana +4, Perception +6, Religion +4; Damage Resistances cold, necrotic; Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 16; Languages Aquan, Common, telepathy 60 ft.; Challenge 6 (2,300 XP).

Amphibious. The Krasis can breathe air and water.

Lattice Conduit. While within 30 feet of an active lattice structure, the Krasis regains 5 hit points at the start of its turn. Radiant damage suppresses this trait until the start of its next turn.

Tide Walker. The Krasis ignores difficult terrain caused by water, mud, or unstable docks.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The Krasis makes two attacks: two Bone Spear attacks, or one Bone Spear and one Claw attack.

Bone Spear. Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 30/90 ft., one target. Hit: 9 (2d6 + 2) piercing damage plus 4 (1d8) necrotic damage.

Claw. Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 11 (2d8 + 2) slashing damage.

Tidecall (Recharge 5–6). Each creature of the Krasis's choice within 30 feet must succeed on a DC 14 Strength saving throw or be pulled up to 15 feet toward a point the Krasis can see and knocked prone. A submerged creature makes this save with disadvantage.

Brine of Rewriting (1/Day). The Krasis releases corruptive brine in a 15-foot cone. Each creature in the area must make a DC 15 Constitution saving throw, taking 22 (4d10) acid damage on a failed save, or half as much on a success. On a failure, the creature also cannot regain hit points until the start of the Krasis's next turn.

REACTIONS

Bone Ward. When the Krasis is hit by an attack it can see, it adds 3 to its AC against that attack, potentially causing the attack to miss. The ward shatters after use and cannot be used again until the start of the Krasis's next turn.

Appendix D: Chapter 2 NPCs, Clues, and Treasure

Name	Roleplaying Notes
Dockmaster Rennik	Blunt, disciplined, and protective of the harbor. Gives orders when frightened.
Captain Meryn Holt	Retired privateer and owner of the Octopus' Tankard. Jovial until ships or sailors are threatened.
High Priestess Lyra	Calm, observant, and convinced the sea itself is being altered. Values truth over public comfort.
Keeper Maelis	Anxious lighthouse keeper who masks fear with technical explanations.
Mara Venn	Surviving Grey Tern sailor. Practical witness who saw the Bone-Tide Krasis

	place the anchor.
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Clue Chain

Clue	Points Toward
Green weed on rescued sailor	Altered currents originate beneath the harbor.
Lighthouse resonance line	The Grey Tern and Starboard Pier are connected to one submerged source.
Mutated fish and salt-cursed nets	Adaptations are deliberate and suited to underwater survival.
Sahuagin testimony	A “green heart” and priest-creature guard the source.
Grey Tern manifests	Silverreach money and trade routes support the operation.
Final inscription	The next major trial concerns Emberfall and thermal adaptation.

Treasure Summary

- 100–150 gp in civic rewards.
- 35 gp in the Grey Tern sea chest.
- Pearl of Mutation Resistance, if recovered.
- Two flasks of holy water.
- Up to four potions of water breathing.
- Evidence granting advantage on one relevant Silverreach investigation check.

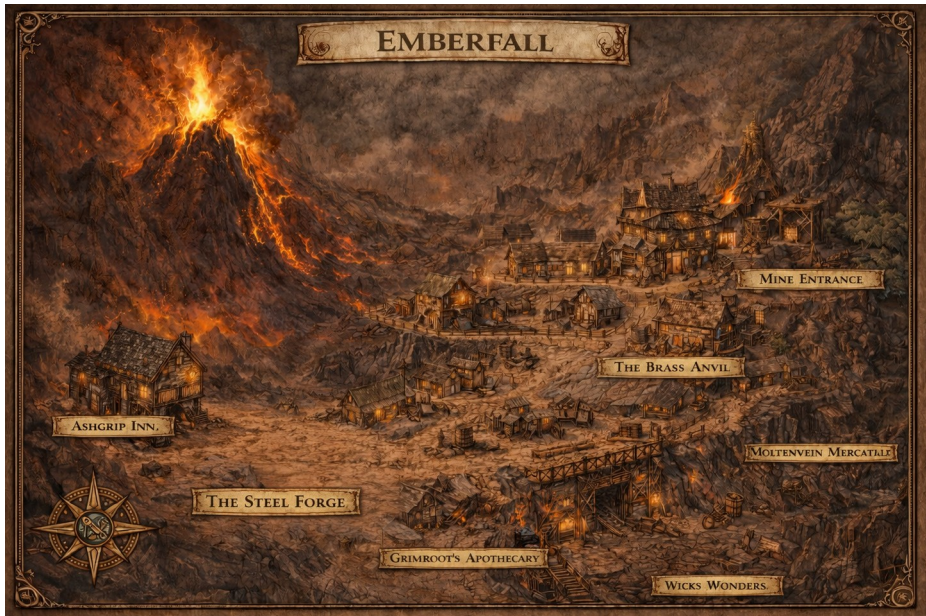
CHAPTER 3

EMBERFALL

ASHES THAT BREATHE

Recommended Levels 4–5 • Starting Level 4 • Hybrid Milestone Advancement

Chapter Purpose. Emberfall reveals the scale and precision of Rabu Shin’s environmental testing. The characters descend through a mining city built beneath an active volcano, trace rhythmic heat surges to a buried lattice crucible, and confront a Molten Chimera Spawn engineered to survive extreme thermal stress. Characters should reach 5th level after destroying the crucible, preventing a magma catastrophe, and recovering proof that the next trial is glacial.



Emberfall settlement map

Emberfall

Emberfall clings to the black slopes beneath Mount Cindervane, an active volcano whose lava channels power the settlement's forges and mines. The city survives through ore, glass, obsidian, and stubborn discipline. Its streets are carved into basalt terraces. Iron bridges span glowing channels. Bells mark tremors, shift changes, and evacuation routes. Recently, those bells have begun sounding at precise forty-seven-minute intervals. Lava changes course without earthquakes. Stone walls swell and contract like lungs. Miners speak of a crystal beneath the mountain that breathes fire.

ARRIVAL AT EMBERFALL

A red glow stains the horizon long before Emberfall comes into view. The road climbs through fields of cooled black stone while ash drifts like gray snow. Ahead, a city of iron roofs and basalt walls crouches beneath a burning mountain. Hammers ring from a hundred forges. Then the ground shifts beneath your boots—once, twice, and once again—three measured pulses, each exactly the same strength. Every worker in sight goes silent.

Starting the Chapter

- **Stonewake Evidence.** A heat-blackened shipping seal and the phrase “Proceed with thermal strain” point directly toward Emberfall.
- **Merchant Passage.** Captain Meryn Holt provides transport to the volcanic coast, where the party arrives during a mine evacuation.
- **Foreman's Contract.** Foreman Garric offers 150 gp to investigate the disappearance of a survey crew in the Third Descent.
- **Arcane Inquiry.** A Lunareth scholar asks the party to retrieve a sample of the red crystalline inclusions forming in Emberfall steel.

Chapter Flow: The chapter opens with investigation in town, followed by the Breathing Crystal incident, a spreading crystal fever, and a descent into the mines. The central dungeon can be run as five linked zones: mine entrance, collapsed galleries, magma chamber, living stone passage, and the lattice crucible. Optional quests fit between major parts or can supply allies and resources for the descent.

Keyed Locations in Emberfall

1. **Ember Tavern** — A crowded miners' hall where shift crews trade rumors. Foreman Garric uses a private back room as an emergency command post.
2. **Ashgrip Inn** — A stone lodging house protected by heat wards. Travelers, merchants, and a frightened surviving miner can be found here.
3. **The Steel Forge** — A heavy industrial forge producing rails, tools, and armor. Its master smith has isolated weapons contaminated by red crystal.

- 4. The Brass Anvil** — Durn Blackhammer’s renowned workshop. The forge burns even when its vents are closed, and a blade quenched here recently whispered in an unknown voice.
- 5. Grimroots Apothecary** — Apothecary Grim treats burns and lung sickness. He is the first to recognize that crystal fever is transformation, not infection.
- 6. Moltenvein Mercantile** — Veskan Thrice-Weighed buys ore and funds expeditions. His ledgers reveal missing shipments of alchemical reagents.
- 7. Wicks’ Wonders** — A cluttered shop of lamps, lenses, climbing gear, and mining charms. Wicks can provide specialized equipment for the descent.
- 8. Mine Entrance** — The guarded mouth of Emberfall’s primary mine. Rails vanish into heated darkness beneath a carved emergency arch.
- 9. The Lower Shafts** — A network of galleries distorted by lattice influence. Walls curve into smooth ribs and ore veins pulse with heat.
- 10. The Lattice Crucible** — A hidden chamber suspended above magma where Rabu Shin’s device redirects heat and grows the Molten Chimera Spawn.

Emberfall Rumors

d8	Rumor
1	The volcano trembles every forty-seven minutes, no matter the weather.
2	A miner returned from the lower shaft with red glass growing beneath his fingernails.
3	Something screamed from inside a sealed ore cart.
4	The Brass Anvil burns hotter after midnight, even with no fuel.
5	A traveling arcanist entered the mine and never came back.
6	Stone near the Third Descent rises and falls as if breathing.
7	A whole lava channel changed direction to avoid an old tunnel.
8	Frostharbor sent a buyer seeking heat-resistant crystal samples.

Important NPCs

Foreman Garric — A practical human veteran who values lives over ore but hides how many miners have already disappeared. He speaks in clipped orders and knows the mine layout.

Miner Elra Voss — The only survivor of the missing survey crew. She heard a calm voice speaking through the stone: “Structural resilience acceptable.”

Durn Blackhammer — A proud dwarf master smith at the Brass Anvil. He distrusts arcane theory but respects evidence and courage.

Apothecary Grim — A soot-stained herbalist with a dry manner. He can stabilize crystal fever but cannot cure it while the crucible remains active.

Veskan Thrice-Weighed — A wealthy ore merchant who unknowingly sold specialized reagents to a House Varin agent. He fears public blame more than danger.

Korin Ashvein — A young tiefling surveyor who knows old ventilation passages and can guide the party if convinced the mission is not suicidal.

Part 1: The Breathing Crystal

THE MINE ALARM

A siren shrieks from the mine district. Workers scatter as an ore cart bursts through the gate, rolling without anyone pushing it. Inside lies a crystal mass the size of a child, glowing red beneath a skin of black glass. It expands. Contracts. Expands again. Four shapes peel themselves from the stone around it—small winged things with molten eyes and mouths full of sparks.

Four Magma Mephitis attack near the mine entrance. They resemble ordinary magma mephitis reinforced with black crystalline plates and acidic glands. Their goal is not to kill indiscriminately; two defend the crystal while two drive witnesses away.

Encounter Features

- **Ore Carts.** A creature can use an action to release a cart. It travels 30 feet in a straight line; creatures in its path make a DC 13 Dexterity save or take 7 (2d6) bludgeoning damage and fall prone.
- **Steam Vent.** At initiative count 20, one marked vent erupts. Creatures within 5 feet make a DC 12 Dexterity save or take 4 (1d8) fire damage.
- **Breathing Crystal.** AC 14, 20 hit points, immune to poison and psychic damage. When reduced to 0 hit points, it becomes inert rather than exploding.
- **Crowd Hazard.** A failed ranged attack by 5 or more risks striking a fleeing worker unless the attacker has a clear elevated position.

Studying the Crystal. A DC 15 Arcana check identifies a repeating transmutation cycle that draws heat from the ground and stores it in layered tissue. A DC 14 Investigation check reveals tool marks: the crystal was deliberately placed inside the ore cart.

A MESSAGE IN HEAT

When the last creature falls, the crystal contracts one final time. A pattern of

green lines flickers across its surface, forming words in a language none of you can hear but all of you understand: “Thermal intake stable. Begin distributed ignition.”

Part 2: Lava Imp Uprising

Within an hour, reports arrive from the Steel Forge and Brass Anvil. Small elemental creatures are emerging from vents, stealing heated metal, and carrying it toward the mine. This is a coordinated collection effort directed by the crucible.

THE FORGE REVOLT

The Brass Anvil’s doors bulge outward. Through the windows, tools whirl in a cyclone of sparks while fist-sized creatures leap between the rafters. One drags a white-hot sword by the blade, laughing in crackling bursts. Durn Blackhammer braces the door from inside and roars, “Either help me or find a safer city!”

Run this as a three-round objective encounter against three magma mephits and two magma mephit Krasis. The party must rescue Durn, shut two fuel valves, and prevent the creatures from carrying a red-steel ingot into the mine.

- **Rescue Durn.** DC 13 Athletics to force the warped door or DC 13 thieves’ tools to release the jammed mechanism.
- **Shut a Valve.** An action and DC 12 Athletics or Sleight of Hand. Each open valve causes 3 (1d6) fire damage to one random creature at initiative count 20.
- **Protect the Ingot.** A Krasis carrying the ingot has speed 20 feet and cannot fly. If it reaches the mine entrance, the Molten Chimera Spawn begins the final battle with 15 temporary hit points.
- **Forge Collapse.** After three rounds, any open valve causes a roof beam to fall. Creatures beneath it make a DC 13 Dexterity save or take 9 (2d8) bludgeoning damage.

Reward. Durn provides one +1 weapon on loan for the remainder of the chapter. If the party saves the forge and ingot, he permanently gifts the weapon after the crucible is destroyed.

Part 3: Crystal Fever

Workers exposed to the breathing crystal develop fever, hardened veins, and painful sensitivity to heat. Apothecary Grim has converted his shop into a ward. The condition worsens whenever the underground node pulses.

GRIMROOTS WARD

Six miners lie beneath damp sheets. Red light moves through their veins in

slow, branching lines. One woman grips the cot hard enough to crack the wood. “It keeps asking me to open the door,” she whispers. “There’s a door under the mountain, and it knows I can hear it.”

The characters must identify the condition and stabilize the patients before descending. Run a skill challenge requiring four successes before three failures. Useful checks include Arcana DC 14, Medicine DC 13, Nature DC 14, Religion DC 15, or appropriate healing magic.

- On Success. All patients stabilize. Grim gives the party three doses of Cinderbane Tonic. As a bonus action, a creature can drink a dose to gain resistance to fire damage for 10 minutes.
- On Failure. Two patients transform partially and attack using magma mephit statistics without flight. After the encounter, the remaining patients stabilize but the party receives only one tonic.
- Key Clue. The fever is not contagious. It is a remote adaptation response caused by the crucible’s pulses.
- Elra’s Memory. When stabilized, Miner Elra draws a precise map of the Third Descent and marks the wall that “opened like a mouth.”

Part 4: Into the Lower Mines

THE THIRD DESCENT

The mine swallows the sound of the city. Rails descend through chambers lit by red fungus and cracks of molten light. Every forty-seven minutes, the tunnel tightens around you with a deep grinding groan. Dust falls upward for a heartbeat. Far below, something answers with a slow, wet breath.

Environmental Rules

- **Extreme Heat.** After each hour underground, a creature without protection makes a DC 12 Constitution save or gains one level of exhaustion. Cinderbane Tonic or fire resistance prevents this save.
- **Unstable Ground.** Dashing across fractured stone requires a DC 11 Acrobatics check. On a failure, the creature falls prone.
- **Pulse Cycle.** Every forty-seven minutes, the lattice crucible pulses. Until the party reaches it, each pulse causes one nearby wall, bridge, or lava channel to shift.
- **Mine Navigation.** Following Elra's map avoids one random encounter. Without it, the group must succeed on a DC 14 Survival check or lose 30 minutes and face a hazard.

Zone A: The Collapsing Shaft

STONE THAT MOVES

The tunnel ahead has folded inward. Support beams bend like softened wax, and a narrow ledge crosses a shaft glowing orange far below. Halfway across, the stone wall opens in a smooth circular seam. A hand reaches out from inside the mountain. Then another.

Three lattice-bound mining constructs emerge. Use animated armor statistics, but describe them as suits of abandoned mining gear filled with heated crystal. The shaft collapses in stages.

- At initiative count 20 in round 1, stones fall in a 10-foot square: DC 13 Dexterity save, 7 (2d6) bludgeoning damage.
- In round 2, one 10-foot section of ledge breaks away. A creature on it can use a reaction to make a DC 13 Dexterity save and move to an adjacent safe square.
- In round 3, the remaining supports fail unless a character spends an action and succeeds on a DC 14 Athletics, mason's tools, or carpenter's tools check.
- A creature that falls is caught on a lower scaffold after 20 feet and takes 7 (2d6) bludgeoning damage rather than falling into lava.

Discovery. Inside the constructs are metal tags belonging to the missing survey crew. Each tag bears a new rune meaning "iteration."

Zone B: The Magma Chamber

A broad cavern is divided by a river of magma. Two Magma Mephitis and one fire snake guard a chain bridge. The mephitis use Acid Spit to weaken armored characters while the fire snake blocks the bridge.

Diplomatic Alternative: The fire snake is not controlled by the lattice and can be driven away by destroying a red crystal embedded near its nest. A DC 14 Arcana or Animal Handling check reveals its distress. Removing the crystal turns the snake against one mephitis before it retreats.

Zone C: The Breathing Wall

THE LIVING PASSAGE

The tunnel ends at a wall of polished black stone. Veins of red light spread across it in the shape of ribs. The entire surface moves inward, then outward, carrying a gust of air that smells of iron and burned hair. A vertical seam appears down its center.

The wall is a transformed section of mountain rather than a creature. Opening it requires three successes before two failures using Arcana DC 15, Athletics DC 16, Investigation DC 14, or mining tools DC 13. Each failure releases a heat pulse dealing 5 (1d10) fire damage to everyone within 15 feet. The password “Refinement requires iteration,” learned in Greymoor Hollow, counts as one automatic success.

Part 5: The Lattice Crucible

THE MOLTEN CHIMERA SPAWN

The passage opens above a chamber vast enough to hold a cathedral. A crystal structure rotates over a lake of magma, suspended by chains of light. Streams of fire rise against gravity and pour into its facets. Beneath it, something massive pulls itself from a basin of molten stone—three bodies forced into one: draconic jaws, a horned furnace-skull, and a leonine frame plated in obsidian. Every head opens its eyes at once.

The Crucible Chamber

- **Central Crucible.** AC 16, 50 hit points, immunity to fire, poison, and psychic damage; vulnerability to cold and thunder. It floats 15 feet above the magma basin.
- **Suspension Chains.** Three light-chains connect the crucible to stone pylons. A chain has AC 14 and 15 hit points. Destroying a chain lowers the crucible 5 feet and disables one pulse effect.

- **Magma Channels.** A creature entering a channel takes 10 (3d6) fire damage. Narrow bridges provide access to each pylon.
- **Cooling Valves.** Two ancient mining valves can be opened with an action and DC 14 Athletics. Each opened valve deals 10 cold damage to the crucible and creates a cloud of steam that heavily obscures a 10-foot area until the next round.
- **Escape Tunnel.** A reinforced passage leads upward. It becomes accessible when the crucible is destroyed.

Crucible Pulses

At initiative count 20, roll on the following table. Do not repeat the same result twice in a row. Destroying a suspension chain removes the highest remaining result from the table.

d4	Pulse Effect
1	Heat Wave. Each creature makes a DC 13 Constitution save or takes 5 (1d10) fire damage.
2	Magma Line. A 5-foot-wide, 30-foot-long line erupts; DC 14 Dexterity save, 10 (3d6) fire damage, half on success.
3	Stone Shift. One bridge rotates 90 degrees. Creatures on it make a DC 13 Dexterity save or slide 10 feet.
4	Adaptive Surge. The Molten Chimera Spawn gains resistance to the last damage type that harmed it until initiative count 20 next round.

Molten Chimera Tactics

- The chimera opens with Furnace Breath if it can catch at least two characters.
- It uses Pounce to cross bridges and isolate a character near a pylon.
- If a character attacks the crucible, one head focuses exclusively on that character until another creature deals more damage to the chimera.
- At half hit points, its obsidian plates crack. Its speed increases by 10 feet, but its Armor Class decreases by 1.
- If the red-steel ingot reached the mine in Part 2, the creature begins with 15 temporary hit points.

RABU SHIN OBSERVES

The three-headed creature roars, but a second voice speaks beneath the sound —calm, measured, almost pleased. “Thermal strain exceeds projections. External variables introduced. Continue observation.” The crucible turns, and for an instant a tall human silhouette appears inside the crystal.

Destroying the Crucible

When the crucible reaches 0 hit points, it fractures and releases its stored heat. Each creature makes a DC 14 Dexterity save, taking 14 (4d6) fire damage on a failure or half on a success. The Molten Chimera Spawn takes the damage automatically and loses Adaptive Surge. If the chimera is already dead, the blast begins the escape sequence immediately.

Escape from the Lower Mines

The party has six rounds to reach the reinforced passage before the chamber fills with magma. Run the escape as three group checks: Athletics or Acrobatics DC 13, Survival or Investigation DC 13, and Arcana or mining tools DC 14. On each failed group check, every character takes 3 (1d6) fire or bludgeoning damage. A character can remain behind for one round to grant the group advantage on the next check, but must then make a DC 15 individual check to catch up.

THE MOUNTAIN EXHALES

The mountain convulses as the crystal breaks. Lava crashes down into its natural channels, no longer climbing toward the machine. Behind you, the chamber folds inward in a storm of sparks and black stone. Ahead, a line of cool night air cuts through the smoke. When you emerge, every forge bell in Emberfall begins to ring—not in warning, but in celebration.

Optional Quests in Emberfall

Part 6: Ore Thieves

A gang has been stealing red-crystal ore from sealed storage. Four bandits and one bandit captain operate from an abandoned smelter. They were hired by a masked buyer from Silverreach. Their ledger records payments marked with House Varin's silver stag seal.

Reward. 60 gp, two alchemist's fire, and evidence that later grants advantage on one investigation check in Silverreach.

Part 7: Living Magma

A lava channel has developed purposeful movement and is approaching homes. Use a fire elemental with half hit points, but allow the party to end the encounter without destroying it by removing a lattice shard embedded in the channel wall. Three successes before two failures using Arcana DC 14, Athletics DC 15, or smith's tools DC 13 calms the flow.

Part 8: Black Lung Plague

Miners in the Ashgrip Inn cough up soot that forms tiny geometric patterns. The illness is caused by powdered lattice residue in ventilation ducts. Cleaning the ducts requires navigating roof vents while two smoke mephits attack. Grim rewards the party with two greater antitoxin doses, each granting advantage on one Constitution saving throw against poison or disease.

Part 9: The Shattered Vein

A newly exposed ore vein sings when struck. Durn wants a sample; Lunareth agents want it destroyed. The vein contains encoded research notes rather than raw power. A DC 16 Arcana check extracts the message: "Photosynthetic host integration scheduled." This points toward Lunareth and Chapter 4.

Part 10: Ashbound Spirit

The ghost of a miner named Talla appears near the Third Descent. She cannot rest because her crew's bodies were incorporated into lattice constructs. Recovering their tags and performing a burial rite prevents one random mine hazard and grants each character inspiration before the final descent.

Chapter Resolution

Rewards

- Foreman Garric pays 150 gp for ending the threat and rescuing any surviving miners.

- Durn Blackhammer permanently grants the loaned +1 weapon if the Brass Anvil and red-steel ingot were saved.
- Apothecary Grim supplies two potions of fire resistance for future travel.
- The party can recover a Thermal Lattice Fragment, which functions as a required key in Sunspire later in the campaign.
- House Varin evidence from Ore Thieves strengthens the political investigation in Silverreach.

Thermal Lattice Fragment

Wondrous item, story item

This palm-sized piece of red-black crystal remains warm in any climate. Once per long rest, its bearer can use a reaction when taking fire damage to reduce that damage by 1d10 + the bearer's proficiency bonus. The fragment is also one of the keys needed to enter the Gene Vault at Sunspire.

Milestone Advancement

Characters advance to 5th level when they destroy the lattice crucible, defeat or neutralize the Molten Chimera Spawn, and prevent a catastrophic magma surge from reaching Emberfall. If they solve the crisis without combat, award the milestone when the thermal experiment is permanently disabled and its purpose is understood.

What the Characters Learn

- Rabu Shin's devices are climate-specific experiments built to measure controlled adaptation.
- The lattice network can reshape terrain as well as living creatures.
- Rabu Shin can observe events remotely through major nodes.
- House Varin or its agents are purchasing and transporting research materials.
- The next stage is called "glacial calibration," pointing toward Frostarbor.
- The Shattered Vein message also implicates Lunareth's living forest research.

ASHES SETTLE

At dawn, Mount Cindervane still burns—but its rhythm belongs to the earth again. Miners return to the upper galleries, and smoke rises from repaired forges. In the shattered crucible, the party finds a thin crystal plate etched with two lines: "Thermal strain viable. Structural resilience acceptable. Proceed to glacial phase." Beneath the words is a map coordinate far to the north—and the initials R.S.

Appendix C: Chapter 3 Creatures

Magma Mephit Krasis

Small elemental (Krasis), neutral evil

Armor Class 13 (natural armor) | Hit Points 27 (6d6 + 6) | Speed 30 ft., fly 30 ft.

STR 8 (-1) DEX 14 (+2) CON 12 (+1) INT 8 (-1) WIS 10 (+0) CHA 10 (+0) | CR 1 (200 XP)

Damage Resistances. acid, fire; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks

Damage Vulnerability. cold

Death Burst. When the mephit dies, it bursts in acid and cinders. Each creature within 5 feet makes a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw, taking 5 (1d10) acid damage on a failure or half on a success.

False Appearance. While motionless against volcanic stone, the mephit is indistinguishable from a crystalline mineral growth.

Lattice Coordination. The mephit has advantage on an attack roll if another Krasis is within 5 feet of the target and is not incapacitated.

ACTIONS

Claws. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d6 + 2) slashing damage plus 2 (1d4) fire damage.

Acid Spit. Ranged Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, range 30/60 ft., one target. Hit: 7 (2d6) acid damage, and metal armor worn by the target takes a temporary -1 penalty to AC until the end of the target's next turn.

Cinder Breath (Recharge 6). The mephit exhales burning grit in a 15-foot cone. Each creature in the area makes a DC 12 Dexterity save, taking 7 (2d6) fire damage on a failure or half on a success.

Molten Chimera Spawn

Large monstrosity (Krasis), chaotic evil

Armor Class 16 (obsidian plates) | Hit Points 136 (16d10 + 48) | Speed 40 ft., climb 20 ft.

STR 19 (+4) DEX 13 (+1) CON 17 (+3) INT 7 (-2) WIS 13 (+1) CHA 11 (+0) | CR 7 (2,900 XP)

Saving Throws. Dex +4, Con +6, Wis +4

Damage Resistances. fire; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks

Damage Vulnerability. cold

Threefold Awareness. The chimera has advantage on Wisdom (Perception)

checks and cannot be surprised while conscious.

Adaptive Carapace. At initiative count 20, the chimera gains resistance to the last damage type that damaged it. This resistance lasts until initiative count 20 on the next round.

Cracked Plating. When reduced to 68 hit points or fewer, the chimera's speed increases by 10 feet and its Armor Class becomes 15.

Lava Stride. The chimera can move across lava without taking damage and ignores difficult terrain caused by volcanic rock.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The chimera makes three attacks: one with its Bite, one with its Horns, and one with its Claws.

Bite. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 11 (2d6 + 4) piercing damage plus 3 (1d6) fire damage.

Horns. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 10 (1d12 + 4) bludgeoning damage. If the chimera moved at least 20 feet straight toward the target, the target must succeed on a DC 15 Strength save or fall prone.

Claws. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 13 (2d8 + 4) slashing damage.

Furnace Breath (Recharge 5–6). The chimera exhales molten shards in a 30-foot cone. Each creature in the area makes a DC 15 Dexterity save, taking 28 (8d6) fire damage on a failure or half on a success.

Pounce. The chimera leaps up to 20 feet to an unoccupied space it can see. Each creature within 5 feet of the landing space makes a DC 15 Dexterity save or takes 7 (2d6) bludgeoning damage and falls prone.

REACTIONS

Molten Deflection. When hit by a melee attack, the chimera can spray molten blood. The attacker must succeed on a DC 14 Dexterity saving throw or take 5 (1d10) fire damage.

Appendix D: Chapter 3 Clues and Campaign Links

Clue	Found At	Campaign Meaning
Breathing crystal message	Mine entrance	The Emberfall outbreak is a controlled thermal experiment.
House Varin ledger	Ore Thieves smelter	Silverreach money supports transport of lattice materials.
Shattered Vein code	Optional ore vein	A living-plant trial is

		underway near Lunareth.
Thermal lattice fragment	Crucible remains	The party has recovered one of Sunspire's Gene Vault keys.
Glacial coordinates	Crucible data plate	Frostharbor is the next confirmed environmental calibration site.
Rabu Shin silhouette	Final encounter	Rabu Shin can observe and speak through the lattice network.

Production Roadmap: The next section will expand Chapter 4: Lunareth — The Blooming Horror / Theory of Perfection, including the ancient forest city, Conclave secrets, pollen plague, living wards, forest-hybrid Krasis, the Krasis Treant, optional quests, rewards, and complete creature statistics.

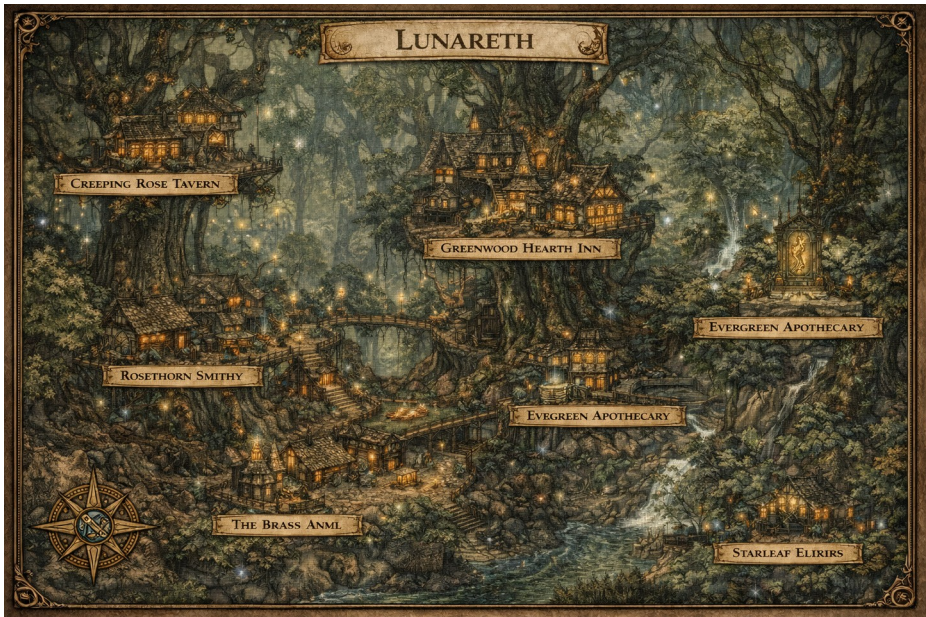
CHAPTER 4

LUNARETH

THE THEORY OF PERFECTION

Recommended Levels 5-6 • Starting Level 5 • Hybrid Milestone Advancement

Chapter Purpose. Lunareth reveals Rabu Shin's origin as a brilliant biomancer whose research was once supported by the Argent Conclave. The characters investigate sealed archives, a pollen-borne mutation crisis, and a destabilized ley junction beneath the city. Their search culminates in a battle against a Runebound Savant and a Krasis Treant grown from a failed imitation of Rabu Shin's lattice theory. Characters should reach 6th level after securing the original thesis, stabilizing Lunareth's leyline, and forcing the Conclave to acknowledge its role in the threat.



Lunareth settlement map

Lunareth

Lunareth is an elven city hidden within an ancient forest where silver bridges curve between colossal trees and crystalline spires rise through the canopy. The city's magic is disciplined, elegant, and deeply woven into living things. Lanterns drift on invisible ley currents. Buildings grow from shaped trunks without harming them. Song, scholarship, and ritual govern daily life. Yet the harmony has begun to fracture. Gardens display impossible symmetry. Roots move beneath paved paths. Several scholars have disappeared, and the Argent Conclave has sealed portions of its own archive.

ARRIVAL AT LUNARETH

The forest road narrows beneath branches so immense they hide the sky. Pale lights drift between the trunks like slow-moving stars. Ahead, silver walkways arc from tree to tree, and towers of crystal rise through leaves shining with moonlit color despite the afternoon sun. The beauty lasts until the wind changes. A cloud of golden pollen rolls across the lower bridge. Every guard nearby pulls a cloth over their mouth. One of them points a spear toward you and calls, “Do not breathe deeply.”

Starting the Chapter

- **The Emberfall Inscription.** The phrase “photosynthetic aggression viable” appears on a secondary crystal recovered from the crucible and points toward Lunareth’s living arcane systems.
- **A Scholar’s Request.** A messenger from the Argent Conclave asks the party to deliver its recovered lattice fragments for examination, but insists they enter through a guarded side gate.
- **The Pollen Plague.** Travelers along the forest road have fallen ill after breathing luminous pollen drifting from Lunareth.
- **A Missing Correspondent.** Miner Elra carries a letter from her sister, an apprentice gardener in Lunareth who stopped writing after reporting that the trees had begun speaking in equations.

Chapter Flow: The party first deals with the pollen emergency and learns the city is hiding a magical failure. Investigation among the Conclave, gardens, bridges, and archives identifies a secret circle of young arcanists led by Seredhel. The final descent beneath the Whispering Archive combines a living-forest dungeon, a corrupted ley chamber, and a two-stage confrontation with Seredhel and the Krasis Treant.

Keyed Locations in Lunareth

- 1. Greenwood Hearth Inn** — A warm inn grown around a living oak. Its proprietor, Meriel Dawnbranch, keeps a list of missing scholars and frightened travelers.
- 2. The Argent Conclave** — Lunareth's governing academy. Archmage Vaelis controls access to research records and conceals the Conclave's former support of Rabu Shin.
- 3. The Whispering Archive** — A layered library carved beneath a crystal-rooted tree. Its restricted vault contains Rabu Shin's original thesis and the entrance to the damaged ley junction.
- 4. Sylvaris Gardens** — Experimental gardens tended by Archdruid Sylvaris. Plants here are becoming perfectly symmetrical, armored, and aggressively responsive to magic.
- 5. The Spire of Reflection** — A leyline focus tower where mirrors show possible magical outcomes. Its reflections now move before the people they imitate.
- 6. Silver Bridge Network** — Graceful bridges carried by magic between trees and towers. Several suffer brief gravity reversals when the hidden experiment pulses.
- 7. Moonpetal Market** — A quiet market for spell components, living crafts, and herbal remedies. It becomes the center of the pollen-plague relief effort.
- 8. The Singing Grove** — A sacred grove whose trees normally harmonize with the moon. The song has changed into a repeating mathematical sequence.
- 9. Hollow Sentinel** — An ancient guardian tree at the eastern boundary. Something has hollowed its trunk and placed a lattice seed inside.
- 10. The Ley Chamber** — A sealed complex beneath the Archive where Seredhel's circle attempted to reproduce directed evolution through arcane lattice structuring.

People of Lunareth

- Archmage Vaelis** — A composed elven archmage whose clipped answers conceal guilt. She funded Rabu Shin's earliest work and now fears public panic more than private shame.
- Archdruid Sylvaris** — The guardian of Lunareth's living systems. Patient, observant, and increasingly furious that the Conclave hid biomantic experiments from him.
- Seredhel Amastacia** — A gifted young arcanist who believes suppressing Rabu Shin's research condemned countless people to preventable disease and weakness.
- Meriel Dawnbranch** — The practical proprietor of Greenwood Hearth. She knows which scholars vanished, who returned changed, and which guards have been bribed.
- Ilyra Fenwhisper** — An apprentice gardener infected by lattice pollen. She hears the plants repeating fragments of Rabu Shin's thesis.

Warden Caladrel — Commander of the Silver Bridge Watch. Loyal to Lunareth, but willing to defy the Conclave if shown proof that citizens are in danger.

Rumors in Lunareth

d6	Rumor
1	The Conclave sealed an archive because a book began growing roots.
2	Golden pollen grants vivid dreams, then leaves black veins beneath the skin.
3	The bridges have dropped three people upward into the canopy.
4	A dead scholar was seen walking into the Singing Grove at moonrise.
5	Rabu Shin was not exiled for failure; he was exiled because his theory worked.
6	Something enormous moves beneath Sylvaris Gardens whenever spells are cast.

Part 1: Pollen Plague

THE GOLDEN BREATH

Moonpetal Market has become a field hospital. Elves lie beneath awnings with damp cloths over their faces. Golden dust clings to their hair and eyelashes. A young gardener arches against a cot as bark-like ridges rise along her forearms. Across the square, flowering vines turn their blossoms toward her as though listening.

The plague is an adaptive reaction, not a disease. Lattice-tainted pollen carries a magical command that alters creatures exposed to it. Archdruid Sylvaris asks the party to stabilize the victims while he traces the pollen to Sylvaris Gardens.

Stabilizing the Victims

Run a skill challenge requiring five successes before three failures. Each character can contribute once with a particular skill unless circumstances change.

- Arcana DC 14 identifies the pollen as a transmutation carrier linked to a repeating ley pulse.
- Medicine DC 13 slows the victims’ breathing and prevents further pollen absorption.
- Nature DC 14 produces a neutralizing wash from moonpetal sap and bitterroot.

- Religion DC 15 uses a cleansing rite to separate the victims' natural life force from the imposed pattern.
- Survival DC 13 seals the market and redirects the drifting pollen with wet canvas and controlled fires.
- Lesser restoration counts as one automatic success, to a maximum of two successes.

Success and Failure: On success, all victims stabilize and Ilyra can speak clearly. On failure, three victims transform into vine-bound thralls and attack using scout statistics with a 10-foot thorn lash that deals 1d6 piercing damage. The surviving victims stabilize after the combat, but Ilyra suffers disadvantage on checks made to recall the experiment.

ILYRA'S WARNING

Ilyra's pupils narrow into leaf-shaped slits. "There are words under the song," she whispers. "Evolution is inefficient because it relies on randomness. He said the forest could be taught to choose." Her fingers tighten around your wrist. "Someone answered him."

Part 2: Sylvaris Gardens

PERFECT GROWTH

The garden gates stand open. Beyond them, every hedge is the same height, every blossom has the same number of petals, and every branch turns at the same precise angle. There is no wind, yet the leaves move together. From somewhere deeper within comes the padded rhythm of many feet moving as one.

Six Vine-Wolf Krasis prowl the gardens. They are wolves fused with vine blights: silent, coordinated predators able to disappear among foliage. They attempt to isolate one character at a time and drag victims toward the central root basin.

Garden Encounter Features

- **Living Hedges.** Five-foot hedge squares provide half cover. A creature can force through one by spending 10 feet of movement.
- **Grasping Roots.** At initiative count 20, one 10-foot square becomes restraining roots. Creatures there make a DC 13 Strength save or become restrained until the next count 20.
- **Pollen Pods.** AC 12, 5 hit points. When damaged, a pod bursts in a 10-foot radius; creatures make a DC 13 Constitution save or become poisoned until the end of their next turn.

- Moonwell. A creature adjacent to the central pool can use an action and succeed on a DC 14 Nature or Arcana check to suppress the garden’s lair effect for one round.

Clue in the Root Basin. A crystal seed is wrapped in roots beneath the water. It bears Seredhel’s personal sigil and a partial activation phrase: “Directed adaptation, localized trial seven.”

Part 3: The Sealed Truth

The party now has enough evidence to confront the Argent Conclave. Vaelis initially claims the garden event is an isolated student error. Persuasion, intimidation, or presenting the Emberfall and garden fragments forces her to reveal the truth.

VAELIS CONFESSES

Vaelis closes every door with a gesture. The room darkens until only the crystal shard between you gives light. “Rabu Shin was the most precise mind Lunareth produced in three centuries,” she says. “We funded him. We praised him. Then he demonstrated that a living creature could be rewritten without consent, and half the Conclave asked how quickly the method could be scaled.” She looks away. “We did not destroy his work. We buried it.”

Rabu Shin’s Original Thesis

- Natural evolution is slow because it depends on random variation and generational death.
- Arcane lattice structures can identify environmental pressure and impose a useful adaptation immediately.
- A sufficiently complex relay can preserve an adaptation pattern and reproduce it across distant populations.
- The subject’s will is treated as interference rather than an essential component.
- The final theoretical stage transfers consciousness into the lattice, allowing the designer to guide every active node at once.

The Ethical Divide: The mathematics is internally coherent. Characters who study the thesis understand why brilliant scholars were tempted by it. The horror is not that the research is nonsense; it is that its promised benefits require surrendering bodily autonomy and permitting one mind to define perfection for everyone.

Investigation in the City

Location	Clue	Check
Spire of Reflection	A mirror shows	Arcana DC 15

	Seredhel entering the Archive several hours before he physically arrived.	
Silver Bridges	Gravity pulses originate beneath the Whispering Archive.	Investigation DC 14
Singing Grove	The trees repeat a six-part numerical sequence used as an access key.	Nature or Performance DC 14
Hollow Sentinel	A lattice seed contains a map of the lower archive tunnels.	Investigation DC 13
Greenwood Hearth	Meriel identifies three missing apprentices who met secretly with Seredhel.	Persuasion DC 12

Optional Quests in Lunareth

The Singing Grove

The grove's sacred harmony has become a compulsion. Characters who enter must make a DC 13 Wisdom save or repeat their last movement on their next turn. Two animated trees attack while a third tree sustains the song. Calming the grove with a DC 15 Performance, Nature, or Religion check avoids combat and provides the six-part access sequence.

Hollow Sentinel

The ancient boundary guardian has been hollowed from within by a lattice seed. The party can remove it through a three-success skill challenge using Athletics DC 15, Nature DC 13, Arcana DC 14, or woodcarver's tools DC 12. Failure awakens the Sentinel as a weakened treant with 90 hit points. Success earns Sylvaris's Ironleaf Charm, granting advantage on one saving throw against being restrained or transformed.

Moonlit Duel

Warden Caladrel challenges a character to a ceremonial duel after the Conclave accuses the party of provoking unrest. This is a nonlethal contest to three successful attack rolls or combat maneuvers. Winning earns the Bridge Watch's support; honorable loss earns Caladrel's respect. Cheating turns the Watch against the party during the Archive assault.

Whispering Brook

A brook outside the city repeats the voices of missing scholars. Following the correct voice requires three DC 13 Insight or Survival checks. The trail leads to a hidden cache containing two potions of greater healing, Seredhel's field notes, and a warning that the ley chamber has developed "root cognition."

Broken Wardstone

A defensive wardstone flickers beside the eastern road. Repairing it requires 50 gp in components and a DC 15 Arcana check. If repaired, the ward suppresses reinforcements during the final confrontation. If ignored, two additional Vine-Wolf Krasis arrive at the beginning of round 4.

Part 4: Beneath the Whispering Archive

THE LOWER ARCHIVE

The restricted archive ends at a circular door grown from white roots and bands of silver metal. When the six-part sequence is spoken, the roots withdraw like fingers. Warm air rises from below, carrying the scent of wet earth, old parchment, and something sweet enough to make your teeth ache. Far beneath, a voice lectures to an unseen class.

Dungeon Features

- **Light.** Pale roots glow with dim silver light unless a room states otherwise.
- **Ceilings.** Corridors are 10 feet high. Ley chambers rise 30 to 50 feet.
- **Living Walls.** Fire damage dealt to a wall causes roots in the room to thrash; all creatures adjacent to a wall make a DC 12 Dexterity save or take 3 (1d6) bludgeoning damage.
- **Ley Pulse.** At initiative count 20 during combat, roll on the Ley Instability table unless the local focus crystal has been disabled.
- **Archive Records.** A character spending 10 minutes searching a room can make a DC 14 Investigation check to find one useful research note or one incriminating record.

Ley Instability

d4	Effect
1	Amplification. Until the next count 20, spells deal +2 damage per damage die, to a maximum of +10.
2	Gravity Shift. Each creature makes a DC 13 Dexterity save or falls prone and slides 10 feet toward the nearest wall.
3	Psychic Resonance. Each creature concentrating on a spell makes a DC 12 Constitution save or takes 5 (1d10) psychic damage.
4	Spell Misfire. The next spell cast before count 20 requires a d6 roll; on a 1, its target is determined randomly among eligible creatures.

Area 1: Hall of Living Catalogues

CATALOGUED

Shelves rise from floor to ceiling, each grown from a single pale tree. Books open as you pass. Ink crawls across their pages to form your names, followed by measurements of your height, weight, scars, and heartbeat. At the far end, two suits of silver armor turn their empty helmets toward you.

Two animated armors and one helmed horror guard the hall. They demand that all “unregistered specimens” submit to measurement. A character can deactivate one construct with an action and a DC 15 Arcana check while adjacent to a catalogue lectern.

Record Found. The hall contains funding approvals signed by Vaelis and six other Conclave members. The last entry records Rabu Shin’s expulsion and notes that his complete thesis was never recovered.

Area 2: Chamber of Failed Symmetry

THE EARLY PROTOTYPE

Glass cylinders line the room. Inside them float branches, animal limbs, and organs arranged in flawless mirrored pairs. One cylinder is broken. Wet footprints lead from it to a figure standing motionless beside the wall—a body of stitched flesh whose crystal-lined joints bend with impossible smoothness.

A flesh golem attacks when any character approaches the far door. Its appearance is altered, but it uses the standard flesh golem statistics. Lightning does not heal it; force damage does. A control console can be disabled with three successful DC 14 Arcana or thieves’ tools checks. Each success reduces the golem’s current and maximum hit points by 10.

Area 3: The Rotating Root Bridge

A narrow bridge crosses a shaft filled with slowly rotating roots. Gravity turns ninety degrees every round at initiative count 20. Creatures not secured to the bridge make a DC 13 Dexterity save or fall 20 feet onto a different surface, taking 7 (2d6) bludgeoning damage. A focus crystal halfway across can be destroyed (AC 13, 15 hit points) to stabilize gravity.

Area 4: Apprentice Refuge

Two frightened apprentices, Lethariel and Oswin, have barricaded themselves in a records room. They helped Seredhel begin the experiment but fled when the leyline started answering questions. They reveal that Seredhel intends to merge the root network with Rabu Shin’s copied pattern, creating a self-correcting organism beneath Lunareth.

Roleplaying the Apprentices: They are guilty, terrified, and useful. If treated with compassion, they provide the counter-sigil that suppresses the final chamber’s lair action for the first two rounds. Threats gain the information but cause them to flee and warn no

one of the unstable escape route.

Part 5: The Blooming Horror

THE LEY CHAMBER

The last door opens onto a cavern filled with roots thicker than towers. A silver leyline hangs in the air like a river of lightning. Beneath it stands Seredhel, one hand pressed to a crystal lectern. Behind him, an immense tree pulls its roots free of the earth. Wolf skulls, antlers, and elven faces are trapped within its bark. Green light opens across its trunk like a single enormous eye.

Seredhel's Appeal

THE RUNEBOUND SAVANT

"Look at what we waste," Seredhel says, his voice trembling with exhaustion rather than fear. "Children born sick. Harvests lost to a single season. Lives spent waiting for chance to produce what magic can provide tonight. Rabu Shin's crime was not discovery. It was refusing to let cowards bury it." The roots behind him tighten around the leyline. "Help me guide this, or stand aside while I prove that perfection need not ask permission."

The characters can attempt to talk Seredhel down before combat. Three successful DC 16 Persuasion, Insight, Arcana, or History checks before two failures cause him to hesitate. If Ilyra, the rescued apprentices, or Vaelis is present, one appropriate argument grants advantage. On success, Seredhel does not fight during round 1 and reveals how to disable the lectern. He still refuses to abandon the experiment unless the Krasis Treant is defeated.

Final Encounter: Seredhel and the Krasis Treant

- **Enemies.** Seredhel, the Runebound Savant, and one Krasis Treant. Add two Vine-Wolf Krasis for a party of five or more characters.
- **Crystal Lectern.** AC 15, 30 hit points, immune to poison and psychic damage. A creature adjacent to it can use an action and make a DC 16 Arcana check; three successes disable it. Each failed check triggers a Ley Instability effect.
- **Leyline Arc.** At initiative count 20, the treant chooses a 30-foot line between two roots. Creatures in the line make a DC 14 Dexterity save or take 10 (3d6) lightning damage.
- **Root Platforms.** Three raised root masses provide half cover. The treant can destroy one with a successful Slam, removing the cover.

- Counter-Sigil. If the apprentices provided it, the treant cannot use Regenerative Photosynthesis or the leyline arc during the first two rounds.
- Seredhel's Surrender. When reduced below 20 hit points, Seredhel surrenders if the lectern is disabled or if the treant has been destroyed. Otherwise he fights until incapacitated.

Ending the Experiment

When the lectern is disabled or the treant falls, the ley chamber begins collapsing. The party must earn four successes before two failures to stabilize the leyline or evacuate safely. Appropriate checks include Arcana DC 16, Nature DC 15, Athletics DC 14, Survival DC 13, or the use of a recovered lattice fragment. On failure, each character takes 14 (4d6) force damage during the escape, and part of the Whispering Archive is destroyed.

RABU SHIN'S CONFIRMATION

The silver current bends toward the broken lectern. For one heartbeat, every root in the cavern becomes transparent, revealing green geometric light running through the forest for miles. A calm voice speaks from no single place: "Plant-host compatibility confirmed. Photosynthetic aggression viable." Then the pattern snaps, and the trees scream.

Chapter Conclusion

With the ley junction stabilized, the pollen loses its glow and the city's living structures slowly return to natural growth. The Argent Conclave can no longer deny its connection to Rabu Shin. Public reaction depends on how the characters handled Vaelis and Seredhel.

Consequences

- If the party exposes the Conclave publicly, Vaelis resigns and Lunareth begins a painful inquiry into arcane ethics. The characters gain strong support from Sylvaris and ordinary citizens.
- If the party keeps the scandal private, the Conclave supplies information, spellcasting services, and discreet travel assistance, but several guilty members retain power.
- If Seredhel survives, he can become a remorseful expert, a prisoner whose testimony divides the city, or a recurring rival convinced the party destroyed humanity's best hope.
- If the leyline was not stabilized, portions of Lunareth remain affected by random gravity shifts and aggressive plant growth during future visits.

Rewards

- **Conclave Stipend.** 600 gp divided among the party for ending the crisis and recovering the thesis.
- **Moonleaf Mantle.** One character receives a cloak woven by Sylvaris. While wearing it, the character has advantage on Dexterity (Stealth) checks made in forests and can cast pass without trace once. The cloak regains this property at dawn.
- **Ironleaf Charm.** Awarded for saving Hollow Sentinel; it can be broken as a reaction to succeed automatically on one saving throw against being restrained, paralyzed, or transformed.
- **Rabu Shin's Thesis.** A unique campaign document required to understand later relay nodes. Studying it during a long rest grants advantage on the next Arcana check involving a Krasis lattice device.
- **Milestone.** Characters advance to 6th level after the ley chamber is secured, the thesis is recovered, and Lunareth formally recognizes the continental threat.

The Road to High Bastion

A FORTRESS UNDER STUDY

Before dawn, Warden Caladrel arrives at Greenwood Hearth carrying a steel message tube dented by claw marks. Inside is a military report from High Bastion. Supply patrols are vanishing. Watchtowers have been sabotaged in mirrored patterns. Creatures wearing bone and chitin armor have begun testing the fortress walls, then retreating before the defenders can respond. At the bottom, one sentence is underlined twice: "They are learning our formations."

The report includes a safe route through the eastern mountains and a request from Captain Valric Stonehand for anyone carrying evidence of the lattice network. The next chapter begins as the party approaches High Bastion beneath the sound of warning horns.

Chapter 4 Creature Appendix

Vine-Wolf Krasis

Medium plant, unaligned

Armor Class 14 (natural armor) | Hit Points 39 (6d8 + 12) | Speed 40 ft.

STR 15 (+2) DEX 15 (+2) CON 14 (+2) INT 5 (-3) WIS 13 (+1) CHA 6 (-2) | CR 2 (450 XP)

Skills. Perception +3, Stealth +4.

Damage Resistances. Poison; bludgeoning and piercing from nonmagical attacks while the Krasis is in dense vegetation.

Senses. Darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 13.

Languages. Understands Sylvan but cannot speak.

False Appearance. While motionless among ordinary plants, the Krasis is indistinguishable from tangled roots and brush.

Pack Tactics. The Krasis has advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one of the Krasis's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally is not incapacitated.

Rootbound Pounce. If the Krasis moves at least 20 feet straight toward a creature and hits it with a Bite on the same turn, the target must succeed on a DC 13 Strength save or fall prone. If the target falls prone, the Krasis can make one Thorn Lash attack against it as a bonus action.

ACTIONS

Bite. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 9 (2d6 + 2) piercing damage.

Thorn Lash. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. Hit: 7 (1d10 + 2) piercing damage, and the target is grappled (escape DC 13). Until the grapple ends, the target is restrained and the Krasis cannot lash another target.

Pollen Cough (Recharge 5-6). The Krasis exhales pollen in a 15-foot cone. Each creature there must succeed on a DC 12 Constitution save or be poisoned until the end of its next turn.

Runebound Savant

Medium humanoid (elf), neutral

Armor Class 15 (mage armor) | Hit Points 88 (16d8 + 16) | Speed 30 ft.

STR 9 (-1) DEX 14 (+2) CON 12 (+1) INT 18 (+4) WIS 13 (+1) CHA 15 (+2) | CR 6 (2,300 XP)

Saving Throws. Int +7, Wis +4.

Skills. Arcana +10, History +7, Nature +7.

Senses. Darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 11.

Languages. Common, Elvish, Sylvan.

Fey Ancestry. The savant has advantage on saving throws against being charmed, and magic cannot put him to sleep.

Lattice Ward. At the start of each of his turns while within 30 feet of an active lattice device, the savant gains 5 temporary hit points.

Spellcasting. The savant is a 9th-level spellcaster (spell save DC 15, +7 to hit with spell attacks). Cantrips: fire bolt, mage hand, minor illusion, thorn whip. 1st level (4 slots): mage armor, magic missile, shield. 2nd level (3 slots): misty step, scorching ray, web. 3rd level (3 slots): counterspell, lightning bolt, plant growth. 4th level (3 slots): blight, greater invisibility. 5th level (1 slot): hold monster.

ACTIONS

Runic Dagger. Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d4 + 3) piercing damage plus 7 (2d6) force damage.

Lattice Pulse (Recharge 5-6). Each creature of the savant's choice within 20 feet must make a DC 15 Constitution save, taking 18 (4d8) force damage on a failed save, or half as much on a success. One plant creature in the area instead regains 18 hit points.

REACTIONS

Adaptive Countermeasure. When the savant takes acid, cold, fire, lightning, or thunder damage, he gains resistance to that damage type until the start of his next turn.

Krasis Treant

Huge plant (Krasis), lawful evil

Armor Class 16 (natural armor) | Hit Points 168 (16d12 + 64) | Speed 30 ft.

STR 23 (+6) DEX 8 (-1) CON 19 (+4) INT 12 (+1) WIS 16 (+3) CHA 11 (+0) | CR 9 (5,000 XP)

Saving Throws. Con +8, Wis +7.

Damage Resistances. Bludgeoning and piercing from nonmagical attacks.

Damage Vulnerabilities. Fire.

Condition Immunities. Charmed, frightened.

Senses. Darkvision 120 ft., tremorsense 60 ft., passive Perception 13.

Languages. Common, Druidic, Elvish, Sylvan.

False Appearance. While motionless, the treant is indistinguishable from an immense diseased tree.

Regenerative Photosynthesis. At the start of its turn, the treant regains 10 hit points if it is in bright light or within 30 feet of an active leyline. This trait does not function until the end of its next turn after it takes fire or radiant damage.

Siege Monster. The treant deals double damage to objects and structures.

Root Network. The ground within 20 feet of the treant is difficult terrain for its enemies.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The treant makes two Slam attacks.

Slam. Melee Weapon Attack: +10 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. Hit: 19 (3d8 + 6) bludgeoning damage.

Crystalline Root. Melee Weapon Attack: +10 to hit, reach 20 ft., one target. Hit: 15 (2d8 + 6) bludgeoning damage, and the target must succeed on a DC 16 Strength save or be pulled up to 15 feet and restrained. The target can use an action to repeat the save, ending the effect on a success.

Pollen of Correction (Recharge 5-6). The treant releases luminous pollen in a 30-foot radius. Each nonplant creature in the area must make a DC 16 Constitution save. On a failure, a creature takes 18 (4d8) poison damage and is poisoned for 1 minute. It can repeat the save at the end of each turn. On a success, it takes half damage and is not poisoned.

Animate Growth (1/Day). The treant animates up to two ordinary trees or large root masses within 60 feet. Each uses awakened tree statistics and remains animated for 1 hour or until the treant dies.

REACTIONS

Adaptive Bark. When hit by a weapon attack, the treant gains a +2 bonus to AC against further attacks made with the same kind of weapon until the start of its next turn.

Chapter 4 Clue Chain

Discovery	Meaning	Leads To
Lattice-tainted pollen	The transformation is being transmitted through Lunareth's living systems.	Sylvaris Gardens
Seredhel's crystal seed	A local arcanist deliberately activated the garden trial.	Argent Conclave
Original thesis	Rabu Shin's theory predates the current attacks and was once funded by Lunareth.	Whispering Archive
Relay calculations	The lattice network is designed for remote, distributed control.	High Bastion and later nodes

Rabu Shin's confirmation	Lunareth was a plant-host compatibility trial.	Continental pattern
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Chapter 4 Treasure Summary

Reward	Source	Use
600 gp	Argent Conclave	Chapter payment
Moonleaf Mantle	Archdruid Sylvaris	Forest stealth and one use of pass without trace
Ironleaf Charm	Hollow Sentinel	Automatic success against one restraint or transformation effect
2 potions of greater healing	Whispering Brook cache	Consumable healing
Rabu Shin's Thesis	Restricted Archive	Campaign clue and advantage on one lattice-related Arcana check per study

CHAPTER 5

HIGH BASTION

SIEGE OF STONE AND STEEL

Recommended Levels 6-7 • Starting Level 6 • Hybrid Milestone Advancement

Chapter Purpose. High Bastion shifts the campaign from investigation to open warfare. The characters discover that Rabu Shin is testing coordinated Krasis infantry against a disciplined fortress. They must expose tunnel infiltrators, defend the walls, preserve the inner gate, and defeat a regenerating commander designed to learn from military resistance. Characters should reach 7th level after breaking the siege and recovering proof that Silverreach interests funded the assault.



High Bastion settlement map

High Bastion

High Bastion is a mountain fortress built into a sheer ridge overlooking the continent's central trade roads. Its concentric walls, high towers, cliffside barracks, and iron-bound gates have withstood armies, monsters, and winter storms. The garrison prides itself on discipline. Yet the enemy now probing its defenses does not raid for food or territory. It studies patrol routes, withdraws before traps close, and changes tactics after every skirmish.

ARRIVAL AT HIGH BASTION

High Bastion rises from the mountain like a crown of black stone. Banners whip above battlements crowded with soldiers. Far below, switchback roads cling to the cliffs. A horn sounds once, then twice. Archers rush to the western wall as a boulder strikes the outer gate with a crack like thunder. It does not roll from the slope. Something below has thrown it.

Starting the Chapter

- **The Conclave's Warning.** Archmage Vaelis sends a sealed letter explaining that lattice formations have appeared in military patterns around High Bastion.
- **A Desperate Courier.** A wounded scout reaches Lunareth with a request from Captain Valric Stonehand: "Bring anyone who has fought these things before."
- **The Silverreach Connection.** Records recovered beneath Lunareth mention payments routed through House Varin to mercenary companies operating near the fortress.
- **The Northern Road.** The party's route toward Frosthabor naturally passes through High Bastion, where all civilian traffic has been halted.

Chapter Flow: The party enters during a siege alert, meets the war council, and investigates attacks occurring both outside and beneath the fortress. The middle of the chapter presents several defensive missions that influence the final assault. The finale is a multi-stage battle at the inner gate against Krasis Ogres, disciplined hybrid soldiers, and the Krasis Commander.

Keyed Locations in High Bastion

1. **The Outer Gate.** A layered gatehouse overlooking the mountain road. Its murder holes, winches, and ballista platforms are the first target of every assault.
2. **Bastion Bazaar.** A crowded courtyard now serving as a refugee camp, infirmary, and supply depot.
3. **Ironpeak Armory.** Weapons and armor are repaired here under Quartermaster Brunna Flint. Several shipments bear false Silverreach seals.
4. **WyvernGuard Tavern.** An officers' tavern where scouts trade reports and frightened soldiers speak more honestly than they do at council.

5. Council Hall. Captain Valric Stonehand coordinates the defense from a chamber covered in geometric attack maps.

6. Cliffwatch Tower. A damaged watchtower above a hidden ascent route. Its signal crystal has been sabotaged.

7. The Inner Gate. The fortress's final defensive line and the site of the chapter's climactic battle.

8. Underkeep Tunnels. Old drainage and mining passages beneath the fortress. Krasis forces are using them to bypass the walls.

Important NPCs

NPC	Roleplaying Notes	What They Know
Captain Valric Stonehand	Blunt, disciplined, respects competence more than rank.	The enemy changes tactics after every failed attack and prioritizes healers and spellcasters.
Sergeant Steelhand	Gruff veteran who treats the party as soldiers once they prove themselves.	A saboteur has been marking tunnel doors with mirrored cuts.
Private Ericson	Young scout, observant but shaken.	He saw an ogre's wounds close unless burned.
Quartermaster Brunna Flint	Suspicious dwarf with a perfect memory for inventory.	Crates from Silverreach contained alchemical feed and bone-binding reagents.
Chaplain Mirelda Voss	Calm priest who oversees the infirmary.	Radiant magic disrupts the crystalline scarring left by Krasis weapons.

Rumors in the Fortress

d6	Rumor
1	The enemy knows the watch schedule before it is posted.
2	Something climbs the cliff without ropes.
3	A dead ogre stood up after the battle and walked away.
4	Silverreach merchants paid the mercenaries outside the walls.
5	The tunnels under the keep breathe at

	night.
6	The next assault will come from inside the fortress.

Part 1: War Council

THE PATTERN OF WAR

The council table is buried beneath maps, casualty lists, and broken pieces of strange bone armor. Red markers surround the fortress in precise arcs. Captain Stonehand places one final marker at the inner gate. “They are not trying to take the Bastion,” he says. “They are measuring how we stop them.”

Stonehand asks the party to complete three urgent missions before nightfall. Each completed mission grants one Defensive Advantage during the final battle. The party may attempt all three, but resting before the siege causes one uncompleted mission to fail automatically.

Mission	Objective	Defensive Advantage
The Tunnel Breach	Seal the underkeep route and defeat burrowing attackers.	No enemy reinforcements enter from beneath the inner courtyard.
The Broken Ballista	Recover the winch assembly and repair a wall engine.	Once during the finale, the party can call a ballista strike for 4d10 piercing damage.
The Cliffwatch Signal	Clear the tower and restore its beacon.	The garrison is not surprised; allied soldiers hold one flank without player assistance.

Part 2: The Tunnel Breach

SOMETHING BENEATH

The passage descends through raw mountain stone. Fresh claw marks score the floor, but the walls are smoother than mining tools could make them. A low vibration travels through your boots. Dust spills from the ceiling in a straight line, moving toward you.

Two Ankhegs burst from the tunnel floor. One has plates of grafted iron and bone, increasing its Armor Class to 16. They are not natural allies; a lattice beacon embedded in the wall compels them to attack in coordinated turns.

- **Collapsing Supports.** A creature adjacent to a timber support can use an action and make a DC 13 Athletics check to collapse a 10-foot section after it moves clear.
- **Acid Channels.** Ankheg acid opens narrow runoff channels. A creature entering one takes 3 (1d6) acid damage.
- **Beacon Crystal.** AC 13, 15 hit points. Destroying it removes the ankhegs' advantage from Pack Coordination.

Tunnel Evidence: Beyond the breach, the party finds supply crates marked with House Varin's silver hawk. Their contents include concentrated nutrient paste, restraint chains, and notes measuring "fortification response time."

Part 3: The Regenerating Prisoner

A captured hybrid lies chained in the infirmary. It resembles a human soldier beneath segmented chitin and grafted muscle. Its wounds close slowly while the chaplain watches. The prisoner does not plead. It studies everyone who enters.

THE PRISONER LEARNS

The prisoner's eyes move from sword to spell focus to holy symbol. "Radiant response observed," it says. "Flame response observed. Command pattern updated." The chains tighten as new bone ridges grow beneath its wrists. "Thank you."

Run this as a tense interrogation. A DC 15 Insight check reveals that every question teaches the creature something about the fortress. A DC 14 Arcana or Medicine check identifies a crystal node at the base of its skull. Removing or destroying the node stops its regeneration and frees the prisoner's original mind for a few final moments.

- The prisoner was once Lieutenant Corren Vale, captured six weeks earlier.
- He remembers a "surgeon with glass hands" directing the transformation.
- The assault commander is called the Stone-Breaker and regenerates unless struck by fire or radiant energy.
- A second force waits beyond the ridge to record the outcome, not to join the siege.

Part 4: Defensive Missions

The Broken Ballista

The replacement winch lies in a wrecked supply cart outside the western wall. Four hobgoblins and one hobgoblin captain guard it. They are mercenaries, not

Krasis. Captured mercenaries reveal they were paid through a Silverreach broker and ordered to keep the fortress occupied, not conquer it.

Cliffwatch Signal

The tower is occupied by two gargoyles altered with climbing hooks and a lattice saboteur using spy statistics. Restoring the beacon requires three successes before two failures using Arcana DC 14, Investigation DC 13, or smith's tools DC 12. Failure triggers a lightning discharge dealing 3d6 lightning damage to creatures in the tower.

Mountain Wyvern

A wyvern circles supply caravans below the fortress. It is not corrupted, but a crystal barb lodged beneath its wing drives it into a frenzy. Removing the barb after reducing the wyvern below half its hit points ends the encounter peacefully and earns the garrison's gratitude. Killing it provides enough venom for two doses of wyvern poison.

Avalanche Run

A patrol is trapped beneath unstable snow and stone. Run a four-success skill challenge using Athletics, Survival, Nature, or appropriate magic. Each failure inflicts 2d6 bludgeoning damage on a rescuer or costs one trapped soldier. Saving at least four soldiers adds twenty guards to the final defense.

Spy in Steel

One officer at the war council is a disguised lattice agent. Clues include mirrored handwriting, no reaction to cold, and crystalline blood beneath a bandaged palm. Exposing the spy prevents the commander from knowing the party's exact capabilities in advance.

Part 5: Siege of the Inner Gate

THE ASSAULT BEGINS

Night falls without sunset. Smoke from burning pitch turns the sky black while horns answer one another across the mountain. Then comes the impact: one strike, then another, each perfectly timed. The outer gate buckles. Soldiers shout from the walls. Through the smoke emerge towering shapes carrying shields grown from bone and iron. Behind them marches a figure whose torn flesh closes with every step.

Running the Siege

The siege occurs in three waves. The party has one round between waves to move, drink potions, or issue orders. At initiative count 20, roll on the Siege Event table. Apply earned Defensive Advantages when appropriate.

d6	Siege Event
1	Falling Masonry. One 10-foot square becomes hazardous; creatures there make a DC 14 Dexterity save or take 2d8 bludgeoning damage.
2	Burning Pitch. A 15-foot line ignites and deals 2d6 fire damage to creatures entering it.
3	Wounded Soldier. A nearby guard falls. A character can stabilize the guard as an action, preserving morale.
4	Gate Strain. The enemy deals 1 structural damage to the gate. At 5 structural damage, the gate collapses.
5	Arrow Volley. Characters in the open make a DC 13 Dexterity save or take 1d8+2 piercing damage.
6	Bastion Counterattack. Allied soldiers deal 10 damage to one enemy chosen by the party.

Wave One: The Shield Line

Four Krasis Soldiers advance behind two shield-grafted Krasis Ogres. The soldiers use the ogres as mobile cover and focus attacks on anyone attempting to reach the gate winches. The ogres attempt to deal structural damage rather than pursue fleeing characters.

Wave Two: The Breach Team

Two additional Krasis Soldiers enter with three cult engineers carrying lattice charges. A charge placed against the gate explodes at the end of the following round, dealing 2 structural damage unless removed with an action and a DC 14 Arcana or thieves' tools check.

Wave Three: The Stone-Breaker

THE KRASIS COMMANDER

The battlefield quiets for a heartbeat. A broad figure steps through the smoke wearing armor fused directly into its skin. One eye is human. The other glows with a rotating green sigil. It looks at the broken defenders, then at you. "Resistance profile confirmed," it says. "Commencing refinement."

The Krasis Commander enters with any surviving enemies. It prioritizes the character who dealt the most damage in the previous wave and changes targets when a creature demonstrates fire or radiant attacks. If the party completed the prisoner scene, they know how to suppress its regeneration.

Victory Conditions

- The Krasis Commander is defeated.
- The inner gate retains at least 1 structural point, or the party prevents enemies from crossing the courtyard for three rounds after it falls.
- At least one senior defender survives: Stonehand, Steelhand, or Chaplain Mirelda.
- The party recovers the commander's tactical journal or intact cranial lattice.

Aftermath

AFTER THE SIEGE

Dawn reveals a battlefield arranged with terrible precision. The dead lie in lines. Broken bone shields point toward the gate like compass needles. Captain Stonehand kneels beside the commander's remains and lifts a crystal slate from its chest. "This was never an invasion," he says. "We were an examination."

The tactical journal records response times, casualty ratios, damage types, and the party's combat habits. One section bears the seal of House Varin in Silverreach. Another entry reads: "Fortification breach efficiency improving. Urban compliance at 42 percent. Awaiting amphibious relay confirmation." This points toward both Silverreach and Marrowfen.

Rewards

- Stonehand pays the party 750 gp from the fortress war chest.
- Each character receives the Bastion Defender's Mark, granting advantage on one Charisma check with Vael Turog soldiers or officials.
- The party receives one suit of +1 armor or one +1 shield chosen from the armory, subject to DM approval.
- If the wyvern was spared, it later appears during a mountain journey and drives off one random encounter.
- The commander's lattice core is a campaign key and provides advantage on one Arcana check made to disable a Krasis relay.

Milestone Advancement

Characters advance to 7th level after they defend High Bastion, defeat the Krasis Commander, and secure evidence of the Silverreach funding network. If the gate fell but the fortress survived, advancement still occurs; the damaged Bastion becomes a visible consequence in later chapters.

If High Bastion Falls

- Trade between the western settlements and Silverreach is severed.
- House Varin presents the defeat as proof that traditional armies are obsolete.
- Refugees crowd Greymoor Hollow and Lunareth.
- Krasis forces gain a military staging ground, adding one elite enemy to a later Silverreach or Marrowfen encounter.

Transition to Marrowfen and Silverreach

TWO ROADS FORWARD

The crystal slate projects two routes across a relief map. One line descends southeast into black marshland, pulsing in time with a distant relay. The other runs east into Silverreach and ends beneath the crest of House Varin. Stonehand folds his arms. "One route finds the weapons," he says. "The other finds who paid for them."

Chapter 5 Creature Appendix

Krasis Soldier

Medium aberration, lawful evil

Armor Class 16 (grafted scale) | Hit Points 52 (8d8+16) | Speed 30 ft.
STR 16 (+3) DEX 14 (+2) CON 15 (+2) INT 10 (+0) WIS 12 (+1) CHA 8 (-1)
Saving Throws. Str +5, Con +4
Skills. Athletics +5, Perception +3
Damage Resistances. poison
Senses. darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 13
Challenge. 3 (700 XP)

Pack Discipline. The soldier has advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one allied Krasis is within 5 feet of the creature.

Adaptive Guard. After taking damage of a type other than psychic or force, the soldier gains resistance to that damage type until the start of its next turn.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The soldier makes two grafted blade attacks.

Grafted Blade. Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 8 (1d10+3) slashing damage plus 3 (1d6) acid damage.

Formation Step. The soldier moves up to half its speed without provoking opportunity attacks, provided it ends this movement within 5 feet of an allied Krasis.

Shield-Grafted Krasis Ogre

Large giant (aberrant), lawful evil

Armor Class 17 (bone shield) | Hit Points 105 (10d10+50) | Speed 35 ft.
STR 20 (+5) DEX 8 (-1) CON 20 (+5) INT 7 (-2) WIS 10 (+0) CHA 7 (-2)
Saving Throws. Str +8, Con +8
Damage Resistances. bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks while its shield is intact
Senses. darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10
Challenge. 5 (1,800 XP)

Living Bulwark. Allied creatures directly behind the ogre have three-quarters cover. The shield can be targeted separately (AC 17; 30 hit points; immune poison and psychic). When destroyed, the ogre loses its damage resistance.

Siege Breaker. The ogre deals double damage to objects and structures.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The ogre makes two shield maul attacks.

Shield Maul. Melee Weapon Attack: +8 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. Hit: 14 (2d8+5) bludgeoning damage. A Large or smaller target must succeed on a DC 16 Strength save or be pushed 10 feet.

Bone Rush (Recharge 5-6). The ogre moves up to its speed in a straight line. Creatures in its path make a DC 16 Dexterity save, taking 18 (4d8) bludgeoning damage and falling prone on a failure, or half damage on a success.

REACTIONS

Interpose Shield. When an adjacent ally is hit by an attack, the ogre becomes the target instead.

Krasis Commander

Medium aberration, lawful evil

Armor Class 18 (grafted half plate) | Hit Points 145 (17d8+68) | Speed 30 ft.

STR 18 (+4) DEX 16 (+3) CON 18 (+4) INT 14 (+2) WIS 14 (+2) CHA 12 (+1)

Saving Throws. Str +8, Dex +7, Con +8, Wis +6

Skills. Athletics +8, Insight +6, Perception +6

Damage Resistances. poison; one adaptive damage type

Condition Immunities. poisoned

Senses. darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 16

Challenge. 8 (3,900 XP)

Regeneration. The commander regains 10 hit points at the start of its turn if it has at least 1 hit point. This trait does not function on the turn after it takes fire or radiant damage.

Adaptive Flesh. When the commander takes acid, cold, fire, lightning, or thunder damage, it gains resistance to that type until it takes a different listed damage type.

Tactical Analysis. At the end of each round, the commander marks the creature that dealt the most damage to it. It has advantage on attack rolls against that creature until the end of the next round.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The commander makes three attacks: two with its lattice blade and one with its war tendril.

Lattice Blade. Melee Weapon Attack: +8 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 11 (2d6+4) slashing plus 4 (1d8) force damage.

War Tendril. Melee Weapon Attack: +8 to hit, reach 15 ft., one target. Hit: 9 (1d10+4) bludgeoning damage, and the target must succeed on a DC 16 Strength save or be pulled up to 10 feet.

Command the Line. Up to two allied Krasis within 60 feet can each use their reaction to move up to half their speed and make one weapon attack.

Mutation Surge (Recharge 5-6). The commander chooses one effect: gain 20 temporary hit points; teleport up to 30 feet; or make one additional lattice blade attack against each creature within 5 feet.

REACTIONS

Calculated Deflection. The commander adds 3 to its AC against one attack that would hit it.

LEGENDARY ACTIONS

Advance. The commander moves up to half its speed.

Blade Attack. The commander makes one lattice blade attack.

Tactical Reversal (Costs 2 Actions). One creature the commander can see within 30 feet makes a DC 16 Wisdom save or uses its reaction to move up to 15 feet in a direction chosen by the commander.

Chapter 5 Clue Chain

Evidence	What It Reveals	Leads To
Varin-marked supply crates	A Silverreach noble network equipped the siege forces.	Silverreach
Lieutenant Vale's testimony	Rabu Shin's agents convert captives and test regenerative warfare.	Future Krasis commanders
Tactical journal	The siege measured fortification response rather than seeking conquest.	Rabu Shin's military trials
Amphibious relay entry	A major active node is operating in marsh terrain.	Marrowfen
Urban compliance report	Silverreach is not merely funding the project; it is a planned test site.	House Varin conspiracy

Treasure Summary

Reward	Source	Notes
750 gp	High Bastion war chest	Awarded after the siege.
+1 armor or +1 shield	Ironpeak Armory	One party reward, selected with DM approval.
Bastion Defender's Mark	Captain Stonehand	Narrative favor with military authorities.
Wyvern poison, up to 2 doses	Mountain Wyvern	Only if the creature is slain and harvested.
Commander lattice core	Krasis Commander	Campaign key; advantage on one relay-disruption check.

CHAPTER 6

MARROWFEN

THE HEART OF THE FEN

Recommended Levels 7-8 • Starting Level 7 • Hybrid Milestone Advancement

Chapter Purpose. Marrowfen reveals that Rabu Shin's operation has advanced beyond isolated experiments. Beneath the marsh lies an automated production laboratory and a relay core transmitting results to Aetherfall. The characters must navigate a failing ecosystem, uncover a submerged facility, survive amphibious Krasis prototypes, and destroy the Swamp Hydra Krasis before the fen is converted into a breeding basin. Characters should reach 8th level after collapsing the laboratory and securing its relay data.



Marrowfen settlement map

Marrowfen

Marrowfen is a stubborn settlement raised on stilts above black water. Narrow boardwalks link crooked homes, smokehouses, shrines, and docks. The people know every current and every patch of safe ground. Lately, however, familiar waterways have begun moving against the wind, entire pools have drained overnight, and the swamp's usual rot has been replaced by a sterile metallic odor.

ARRIVAL IN MARROWFEN

The road dissolves into a plank walkway above endless reeds and black water. Lanterns burn as dim yellow smudges in the mist. No frogs call. No insects hum. Beneath the boards, a ripple travels against the current and stops directly below you. A fisherman watches from a leaning porch. "It ain't the swamp that's wrong," he mutters. "It's what's under it."

Starting the Chapter

- **The Amphibious Relay.** The Krasis Commander's journal identifies a major active relay in marsh terrain southeast of High Bastion.
- **A Plea from the Fen Watch.** Ranger Nessa Reed arrives with reports of geometric drainage channels and missing patrols.
- **Trade Contamination.** Stonewake merchants report barrels of Marrowfen water that crystallize when exposed to moonlight.
- **The Varin Manifest.** A Silverreach shipping record lists pumps, glass tanks, and alchemical preservatives delivered to Marrowfen under a false charity seal.

Chapter Flow: The party gathers rumors in Marrowfen, investigates artificial drainage and disappearances, and locates a half-submerged laboratory during the lowest tide. The laboratory becomes a compact dungeon featuring containment chambers, pumping machinery, hybrid creatures, and a transmitting relay. The finale pits the party against the Swamp Hydra Krasis while the facility floods and collapses.

Keyed Locations in Marrowfen

1. **The Bog Lantern Inn.** A crowded stilt-house inn run by Sella Mirewick. Its common room serves as tavern, meeting hall, and emergency shelter.
2. **Fen Watch Tower.** A raised ranger station overlooking the widest channels. Maps show water loss in precise geometric wedges.
3. **Mire Dock.** Flat-bottomed skiffs leave from this sagging pier. Boats have begun scraping against metal structures beneath the mud.
4. **Sunken Chapel.** An old stone shrine exposed by falling water levels. Its altar bears lattice-like spiral carvings.
5. **Crooked Reed Market.** A floating market of herb sellers, fishers, and trappers. Several stalls display pale fish with reinforced gills.

- 6. The Sinking Basin.** A broad patch of marsh collapsing around a newly exposed cylindrical structure.
- 7. The Submerged Laboratory.** A sealed Krasis facility containing pumps, vats, specimen pens, and the relay core.
- 8. The Blackwater Spillway.** A drainage trench that carries contaminated water toward the open fen.

Important NPCs

NPC	Roleplaying Notes	What They Know
Sella Mirewick	Dry humor, practical, protective of locals.	Night fog glows green and several guests vanished after following lights over the water.
Ranger Nessa Reed	Focused, suspicious of outsiders, speaks in clipped observations.	The water is being pumped through channels cut beneath the mud.
Brother Cale Moss	Gentle priest of the Sunken Chapel, troubled by recurring dreams.	The exposed altar predates Marrowfen but its newest runes match the lattice.
Old Jorr Fenhook	One-eyed boatman who exaggerates everything except danger.	He saw a metal tower rise during low tide and heard something with many throats beneath it.
Apothecary Velka Silt	Clinical, curious, morally cautious.	Local animals show surgical grafting rather than natural mutation.

Rumors in the Bog Lantern

d6	Rumor
1	The fen is shrinking because something beneath it drinks the water.
2	Crocodiles drag prey toward the Sinking Basin but never eat it.
3	A tower surfaced during the last moonless night.
4	Lights move beneath the water in straight lines.
5	The Sunken Chapel bell rings even

	though its rope rotted years ago.
6	A merchant paid in Silverreach coin for every living swamp creature he could buy.

Part 1: The Fen That Drains

THE ARTIFICIAL CHANNELS

Beyond the last house, the marsh opens into a field of cracked mud. Reeds lie flat in rows as straight as spear shafts. Water trickles into narrow cuts that should not exist, all flowing toward a dark depression in the distance. Every forty-seven heartbeats, the channels pulse and deepen.

Nessa asks the characters to survey three drainage sites. Treat this as a 4-success-before-2-failure skill challenge. Useful skills include Investigation to identify tool marks, Survival to trace hidden channels, Nature to understand the damaged ecosystem, Arcana to sense lattice resonance, and Athletics to cross collapsing mud. A failure causes a character to sink waist-deep and take 1d6 acid damage from contaminated water.

- Success identifies the Sinking Basin as the convergence point and reveals that the pumps activate during the lowest tide.
- One failure alerts two Flesh-Grafted Crocodiles, which stalk the party during the next investigation scene.
- Two failures cause a boardwalk collapse in town, injuring civilians and reducing local confidence in the party.

Fenlight Disappearances

Three residents vanished after pursuing pale green lights. Following the lights leads to a shallow pool where an Ooze-Ghoul Hybrid imitates drowned voices. A DC 15 Insight check notices that each plea repeats with identical pauses. Defeating the hybrid reveals stitched identification tags from the missing residents and a brass token marked with a laboratory chamber number.

The Sunken Chapel

THE EXPOSED SHRINE

Mud covers the chapel floor in a smooth black sheet. At the far end, a stone altar rises above the water. Old devotional carvings spiral around its sides, but newer cuts interrupt them: sharp, precise angles glowing faintly green. The bell above you rings once. No wind moves.

Brother Cale explains that the shrine was built atop something older. Investigation DC 15 uncovers a metal conduit behind the altar. Arcana DC 16 identifies it as a signal repeater connected to the laboratory. Destroying or disabling it prevents the facility from tracking the party's approach and removes one environmental pulse from the final battle.

A Choice, Not a Puzzle: The altar is sacred to Marrowfen. Smashing it is fast but damages the community's trust. Careful removal requires one hour and a successful DC

15 thieves' tools or mason's tools check.

Part 2: The Sinking Basin

THE LABORATORY EMERGES

Mist parts over a widening sinkhole. Black water circles a cylinder of stone, iron, and pale tissue rising from the mud. Pipes flex like roots along its sides, drinking from the fen. A round hatch sits ten feet above the waterline. Something large rolls beneath the surface, leaving three wakes where one body should be.

The laboratory can be entered through the upper hatch, a cracked pump conduit, or a submerged maintenance grate. Each route changes the first encounter.

Route	Check or Cost	Result
Upper Hatch	DC 16 thieves' tools or Arcana	Quiet entry into the intake gallery.
Pump Conduit	DC 14 Athletics; 2d6 bludgeoning on failure	Entry through machinery; the party can disable one pump immediately.
Maintenance Grate	Swim 60 feet; DC 14 Constitution save	Entry into specimen holding; failure causes one level of exhaustion.

Perimeter Encounter

Two Flesh-Grafted Crocodiles guard the basin. They remain submerged until a creature reaches the tower or enters the water. One attempts to grapple and tow prey toward an intake pipe. Characters who observed their tracks earlier have advantage on initiative. If reduced below half hit points, a crocodile retreats through the maintenance grate and warns the laboratory.

Part 3: The Submerged Laboratory

The interior is dry, warm, and unnaturally clean. Pale tubes pulse behind glass walls. Brass plates identify chambers in precise Elvish script. Unless noted otherwise, ceilings are 12 feet high, doors are watertight, and dim green crystals provide light.

1. Intake Gallery

Three pumps pull water and organic matter from the fen. A character can disable each pump with a DC 15 Arcana, Athletics, or thieves' tools check. Each disabled pump slows flooding during the boss battle and restores part of the marsh after the chapter.

2. Specimen Receiving

Hooks, cages, and numbered tables hold captured swamp life. Two giant frogs and a restrained young crocodile can be freed. A ledger shows that subjects were selected for lung capacity, toxin resistance, and regenerative response.

3. Production Chamber

Six glass vats contain incomplete hybrids. Two Ooze-Ghoul Hybrids emerge when the central console is touched. Breaking a vat creates a 10-foot pool of corrosive slime that deals 2d6 acid damage to a creature entering it for the first time on a turn.

4. Pump Control Walkway

A narrow bridge crosses churning machinery. At initiative count 20, unsecured creatures make a DC 13 Dexterity save or slide 10 feet toward the gears. Shutting down the machinery removes this hazard and weakens the final relay pulse.

5. Surgical Archive

Crystal slates record successful grafts. Medicine DC 15 reveals that many subjects were alive and conscious. One file bears House Varin authorization codes and another references "surface stress testing."

6. Flooded Containment

Waist-deep water conceals a bound Water Weird and the remains of failed specimens. Destroying the binding pillar frees the weird, which attacks the nearest creature unless calmed with Primordial or a DC 16 Animal Handling check enhanced by magic.

7. Relay Antechamber

Three rotating rings project maps of Emberfall, Lunareth, High Bastion, and Frosthabor. Arcana DC 18 confirms that the laboratory is transmitting data rather than merely collecting it.

8. Heart Chamber

The Swamp Hydra Krasis rests around a crystalline relay core suspended over black water. Its necks are threaded through the machinery like living cables.

Resting in the Laboratory: A short rest is possible after the production chamber if the party seals both doors. A long rest allows the relay to finish a transmission, granting the Swamp Hydra Krasis 20 temporary hit points and causing Rabu Shin to learn one character's damage resistances.

Optional Marrowfen Quests

The Bog Hag's Bargain

A reclusive green hag named Mother Brindle offers a vial that suppresses Krasis regeneration for 1 minute. Her price is a cherished memory willingly described by one character. She does not steal the memory; she wants the story and later repeats it to unsettle the character. Refusing her bargain has no mechanical penalty.

Mire Rot

Contaminated water causes fever and blackened veins among residents. Velka needs three ingredients gathered from dangerous locations. Completing the task grants four antitoxin doses and prevents civilian deaths during the laboratory collapse.

Floating Bones

Human bones arranged in geometric rafts drift through the eastern channel. The remains belong to laboratory victims. Returning their identification tags to families earns Marrowfen's trust and reveals that one victim worked for a Silverreach shipping house.

Fenfire Beacon

A watch beacon has been replaced by a lattice transmitter. Disabling it before entering the laboratory prevents reinforcements: otherwise one additional Ooze-Ghoul Hybrid arrives during the final battle on round 3.

The White-Eyed Gar

A huge mutated fish circles the market docks. It is frightened rather than aggressive. Calming and relocating it requires a 3-success skill challenge using Animal Handling, Nature, Survival, or magic. Success earns a charm from local fishers that allows one character to breathe underwater for 1 hour.

Part 4: The Heart of the Fen

THE SWAMP HYDRA KRASIS

The final door opens onto a cavernous chamber filled with black water. A crystal relay turns above the pool, shedding green light across dozens of tubes. One by one, massive heads rise from the surface. Their jaws are crocodilian, their eyes human, and translucent glands pulse along their throats. The central head opens its mouth, and Rabu Shin’s voice speaks through it: “Amphibious strain viable. Begin surface stress testing.”

Battlefield Features

- **Black Water.** The pool is 4 feet deep and difficult terrain for creatures without a swim speed.
- **Relay Core.** AC 17, 45 hit points, immune poison and psychic. Destroying it ends relay pulses but causes the chamber to begin collapsing.
- **Pump Columns.** Each intact pump column grants the hydra 5 additional hit points whenever its Bog Regeneration activates. A column has AC 15 and 20 hit points.
- **Suspended Walkways.** A creature shoved from a walkway falls 10 feet into the pool and lands prone.
- **Containment Valves.** A character can open a valve with an action and DC 15 Athletics check, creating a 20-foot line of rushing water that pushes creatures 15 feet.

Relay Pulse

At initiative count 20, roll a d4. If the party disabled the chapel repeater, ignore the first pulse. If all intake pumps were disabled, roll only on results 1-2.

d4	Relay Effect
1	Flood Surge. Water rises 1 foot and all creatures in the pool make a DC 14 Strength save or fall prone.
2	Psychic Resonance. Each non-Krasis creature makes a DC 15 Wisdom save or takes 2d6 psychic damage and cannot take reactions until its next turn.
3	Regenerative Command. The hydra immediately regains 15 hit points.
4	Structural Failure. Debris strikes a 10-foot square; creatures there make a DC 15 Dexterity save or take 3d8

	bludgeoning damage.
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Hydra Tactics

The Swamp Hydra Krasis begins by spreading its heads across several targets. It uses Devouring Drag on isolated characters and positions itself near pump columns. When reduced below half hit points, it ruptures its acid glands, making the water lightly obscured and hazardous. It understands the relay core's importance and uses a reaction to intercept attacks against it when possible.

Collapsing the Laboratory

When the hydra and relay core are destroyed, the facility begins to collapse. The party has 6 rounds to escape. Each round, one character must lead the group through a hazard using Athletics, Acrobatics, Survival, Arcana, or tools. Three total successes allow everyone to escape safely. Each failure deals 2d6 damage to every character and costs one recovered item or rescued creature.

THE HEART BREAKS

The relay fractures with a sound like a glass cathedral breaking underwater. Green light races through every tube. The walls convulse. Beyond the chamber, swamp water punches through the corridors in a roaring black wave. Somewhere above, the whole tower begins to sink.

Aftermath

With the pumps destroyed, water returns gradually to the drained channels. Fish and insects reappear over the following weeks, though scars remain around the Sinking Basin. The recovered relay data proves that the Krasis network is automated, distributed, and linked to Frostarbor and Aetherfall.

WHAT THE RELAY REVEALS

At dawn, the last piece of the laboratory slips beneath the recovering marsh. Sella watches the water cover it and exhales. Nessa holds up a crystal slate still pulsing with coordinates. "This thing was talking to somewhere," she says. Two points burn on the display: one beneath the northern ice, and one impossibly high above the world.

Rewards

- Marrowfen grants the party 900 gp gathered from trade guilds and grateful families.
- Velka provides four greater healing potions if Mire Rot was completed, or two otherwise.

- The party recovers a Relay Crystal keyed to Aetherfall. Once, it can grant advantage on all Arcana checks made during one encounter involving a lattice device.
- Hydra acid glands yield up to three doses of potent acid, each dealing 4d6 acid damage when thrown as an improvised weapon.
- Each character receives the Fen-Walker Token, granting advantage on one Survival check made in swamp terrain.

Milestone Advancement

Characters advance to 8th level after destroying the relay core, defeating the Swamp Hydra Krasis, and preventing the laboratory from converting Marrowfen into a permanent production basin.

If the Laboratory Survives

- The marsh continues draining and becomes a sterile basin filled with breeding vats.
- Trade between Stonewake and the eastern settlements collapses.
- Rabu Shin deploys amphibious Krasis in a later chapter.
- The final Aetherfall encounter begins with one additional active relay node.

Transition to Silverreach

THE MONEY TRAIL

Among the recovered shipping manifests is a sequence of payments bearing the crest of House Varin. Pumps, preservatives, living specimens, and guards were purchased through charitable accounts in Silverreach. The final entry reads: “Urban integration funding approved.” Marrowfen was not the destination. It was the supply chain.

Chapter 6 Creature Appendix

Flesh-Grafted Crocodile

Large beast (aberrant), unaligned

Armor Class 15 (grafted hide) | Hit Points 76 (8d10+32) | Speed 30 ft., swim 40 ft.

STR 19 (+4) DEX 12 (+1) CON 18 (+4) INT 4 (-3) WIS 12 (+1) CHA 5 (-3)

Skills. Perception +4, Stealth +4

Damage Resistances. acid

Senses. darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 14

Challenge. 4 (1,100 XP)

Hold Breath. The crocodile can hold its breath for 30 minutes.

Directed Hunter. The crocodile has advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks and attack rolls against a creature carrying a lattice shard.

Grafted Carapace. The first time each round the crocodile takes nonmagical slashing or piercing damage, reduce that damage by 5.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The crocodile makes one bite attack and one tail attack.

Bite. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 17 (2d12+4) piercing damage, and the target is grappled (escape DC 15). Until this grapple ends, the target is restrained and the crocodile cannot bite another target.

Tail. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target not grappled by the crocodile. Hit: 13 (2d8+4) bludgeoning damage, and the target must succeed on a DC 15 Strength save or fall prone.

Acid Spit (Recharge 5-6). The crocodile spits acid in a 30-foot line that is 5 feet wide. Creatures in the line make a DC 15 Dexterity save, taking 18 (4d8) acid damage on a failure, or half on a success.

Ooze-Ghoul Hybrid

Medium undead (aberrant), chaotic evil

Armor Class 14 (natural armor) | Hit Points 85 (10d8+40) | Speed 30 ft., climb 20 ft.

STR 16 (+3) DEX 14 (+2) CON 18 (+4) INT 6 (-2) WIS 11 (+0) CHA 7 (-2)

Saving Throws. Con +7

Damage Resistances. acid, necrotic

Condition Immunities. poisoned

Senses. darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10

Challenge. 4 (1,100 XP)

Corrosive Flesh. A creature that hits the hybrid with a melee attack while within 5 feet takes 3 (1d6) acid damage.

Reanimation. When reduced to 0 hit points, the hybrid makes a DC 12 Constitution save. On a success, it drops to 1 hit point instead. Radiant damage prevents this trait until the end of its next turn.

Amorphous. The hybrid can move through a space as narrow as 1 inch wide without squeezing.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The hybrid makes two claw attacks.

Claw. Melee Weapon Attack: +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 9 (1d10+4) slashing damage plus 4 (1d8) acid damage.

Slime Grasp. Melee Weapon Attack: +6 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. Hit: 8 (1d8+4) bludgeoning damage, and the target is grappled (escape DC 14).

Putrid Eruption (Recharge 5-6). Each creature within 15 feet makes a DC 15 Constitution save, taking 18 (4d8) necrotic damage and becoming poisoned until the end of its next turn on a failure, or half damage without being poisoned on a success.

Swamp Hydra Krasis

Huge monstrosity (aberrant), chaotic evil

Armor Class 17 (lattice scales) | Hit Points 230 (20d12+100) | Speed 30 ft., swim 40 ft.

STR 22 (+6) DEX 12 (+1) CON 21 (+5) INT 8 (-1) WIS 14 (+2) CHA 10 (+0)

Saving Throws. Str +10, Con +9, Wis +6

Skills. Perception +10

Damage Resistances. acid, poison

Condition Immunities. poisoned

Senses. darkvision 90 ft., passive Perception 20

Challenge. 10 (5,900 XP)

Multiple Heads. The hydra has five heads. While it has more than one head, it has advantage on saves against blinded, charmed, deafened, frightened, stunned, and unconscious.

Reactive Heads. For each head beyond one, the hydra gets an extra reaction usable only for opportunity attacks.

Severed Heads. Whenever the hydra takes 25 or more damage in a single turn, one head dies. At the end of its next turn, two heads regrow unless it took fire or radiant damage since the head died. It regains 15 hit points for each head regrown.

Bog Regeneration. The hydra regains 10 hit points at the start of its turn while standing in swamp water. This trait does not function if it took radiant damage

since its last turn.

Acidic Blood. When a creature within 5 feet deals slashing or piercing damage to the hydra, that creature takes 5 acid damage.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The hydra makes as many bite attacks as it has heads.

Bite. Melee Weapon Attack: +10 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. Hit: 12 (1d12+6) piercing damage plus 4 (1d8) acid damage.

Tendrill Sweep. Each creature of the hydra's choice within 15 feet makes a DC 17 Strength save, taking 13 (2d6+6) bludgeoning damage and falling prone on a failure, or half damage on a success.

Devouring Drag. One creature grappled by the hydra is pulled up to 20 feet and submerged. The target takes 18 (4d8) bludgeoning damage and cannot breathe until the grapple ends.

Death Bloom. When the hydra is reduced to 0 hit points, its glands rupture. Creatures within 20 feet make a DC 16 Dexterity save, taking 21 (6d6) acid damage on a failure, or half on a success.

REACTIONS

Relay Interception. When the relay core is targeted by an attack and the hydra is within 15 feet of it, the hydra moves up to 10 feet and becomes the target instead.

Chapter 6 Clue Chain

Evidence	What It Reveals	Leads To
Geometric drainage channels	The environmental damage is engineered and timed.	Sinking Basin
Numbered victim tags	Residents were harvested as laboratory subjects.	Submerged laboratory
House Varin authorization codes	Silverreach financed equipment and personnel.	House Varin conspiracy
Relay maps and transmission logs	The lattice network is distributed and automated.	Frostharbor and Aetherfall
Urban integration protocol	The next phase will target a wealthy population center.	Silverreach

Treasure Summary

Reward	Source	Notes
900 gp	Marrowfen guilds	Awarded after the laboratory is destroyed.
2-4 greater healing potions	Velka Silt	Quantity depends on completing Mire Rot.
Relay Crystal	Relay antechamber	One encounter of advantage on lattice-related Arcana checks.
Up to 3 potent acid doses	Swamp Hydra Krasis	4d6 acid damage when thrown.
Fen-Walker Tokens	Marrowfen council	One-use advantage on a swamp Survival check.

CHAPTER 7

SILVERREACH

THE CONSPIRACY OF GOLD

Recommended Levels 8-9 • Starting Level 8 • Hybrid Milestone Advancement

Chapter Purpose. Silverreach changes the campaign from wilderness investigation to political exposure. The characters follow House Varin's financial trail through a wealthy trade capital, infiltrate a noble gala, discover a relay office beneath the Varin estate, and confront a Krasis Noble who can blink through space. This chapter reveals that influential citizens knowingly financed Rabu Shin's work because they expect to profit from controlled evolution. Characters should reach 9th level after exposing the conspiracy and shutting down its funding network.



Silverreach settlement map

Silverreach

Silverreach is Vael Turog's richest inland city, a place of marble avenues, river trade, noble estates, and guild influence. Public life is polished and ceremonial. Behind closed doors, contracts matter more than laws, and respectable patrons can purchase distance from the consequences of their decisions.

ARRIVAL IN SILVERREACH

Sunlight flashes from golden domes and polished white stone. Carriages crowd the broad avenue leading toward the King's Hall, while merchants call prices beneath silk awnings. The air smells of perfume, river water, and hot coin. As you pass, a noblewoman lowers her voice. A guard closes a ledger. Somewhere behind the splendor, someone already knows you have arrived.

Starting the Chapter

- **The Varin Manifest.** Records recovered in Marrowfen show House Varin purchased pumps, preservatives, guards, and living specimens through charitable accounts.
- **High Bastion's Accusation.** Captain Stonehand sends the party as witnesses to prove Silverreach money funded the siege prototypes.
- **A Missing Clerk.** A frightened accountant named Lio Venn disappeared after copying ledgers tied to Emberfall, Marrowfen, and Frostarbor.
- **The Gala Invitation.** The Celestial Temple asks the party to attend House Varin's public benefit and quietly investigate its claims of medical philanthropy.

Chapter Flow: The party establishes allies, follows financial and human evidence, and gains access to the Sapphire Gala. A social infiltration reveals the hidden archive and the estate vault below it. The final battle occurs among unstable wards and relay machinery, followed by a choice to expose House Varin publicly or dismantle its network in secret.

Keyed Locations in Silverreach

1. **The Golden Cup Tavern.** A fashionable inn where merchants, junior nobles, and visiting officers exchange rumors. Proprietor Maera Goldcup remembers faces and debts.
2. **The King's Hall.** Administrative center of Silverreach. Magistrates hesitate to challenge House Varin without undeniable evidence.
3. **The Celestial Temple.** A powerful temple and refuge for victims of illegal experimentation. High Priestess Auriel opposes House Varin quietly.
4. **Brightwater Smithy.** A respected forge whose owner found unusual bone-hardening compounds in Varin shipments.
5. **The Alchemist's Emporium.** Supplier of rare reagents. Its books reveal purchases routed through shell charities.

6. Goldenroot Alchemy. A tea room and discreet apothecary where informants meet beneath the noise of respectable business.

7. Lavina's Ceramics. A workshop that unknowingly produced sealed ceramic canisters for transporting tissue samples.

8. House Varin Estate. A walled noble compound containing the Sapphire Gala hall, private archive, guard barracks, and underground relay vault.

9. Lower Dock Ward. Warehouse district where paid volunteers and kidnapped laborers were processed before shipment.

Important NPCs

NPC	Roleplaying Notes	What They Know
Lady Miravel Varin	Warm, controlled, never admits uncertainty.	The family funds the network and believes it will secure political dominance.
Lord Cassian Varin	Charming, vain, genuinely convinced the work can cure disease.	He knows the public program but not every atrocity beneath the estate.
High Priestess Auriel	Measured, compassionate, politically careful.	Temple charities discovered patients with reinforced bones and erased memories.
Lio Venn	Nervous accountant, speaks in figures when frightened.	He copied the true ledgers and hid a cipher key in the Golden Cup Tavern.
Inspector Dain Marrow	City investigator with little patience for nobility.	He needs admissible evidence before he can act against House Varin.
Veyra Sorn	House Varin's arcane enforcer and a Krasis Noble.	She reports directly to the lattice network and guards the financial relay.

Silverreach Rumors

d6	Rumor
1	House Varin will announce a treatment that makes broken bones heal overnight.
2	Street children vanish whenever a black carriage visits the Lower Dock

	Ward.
3	A High Bastion envoy was refused entry to the King's Hall.
4	The Varin gala requires masks because several guests are undergoing "restorative procedures."
5	A clerk tried to sell ledgers, then disappeared before dawn.
6	Green light shines beneath the Varin gardens after midnight.

Part 1: A City of Masks

The party needs three kinds of proof: financial records, testimony from a victim or employee, and physical evidence of an active lattice operation. Any two provide access to House Varin's gala through allies; all three grant advantage on the chapter's final public accusation.

The Golden Cup Cipher

Maera Goldcup gives the party a brass key left by Lio Venn. It opens a private bottle cabinet containing a page of payment codes. Investigation DC 14 links the codes to Marrowfen pumps, High Bastion mercenaries, and Frostharbor shipping. A watcher attempts to steal the page after the party leaves.

The Lower Dock Volunteers

Two injured dockworkers display reinforced bone grafts and unusual resistance to pain. Medicine DC 15 confirms deliberate alteration. One admits they were paid by Varin agents but says several others never returned. Following the recruiting route leads to Warehouse 17.

The Alchemical Paper Trail

The Alchemist's Emporium recorded large purchases of preservatives, transmutation salts, and memory-dulling draughts. Persuasion DC 15 or proof from Marrowfen convinces the owner to release copies. Failure alerts House Varin that the party is tracing suppliers.

The Celestial Temple Patients

Auriel shelters three former test subjects. A gentle interview and DC 14 Persuasion or Medicine check earns testimony. Pressuring them causes Auriel to withdraw support and makes the gala infiltration more difficult.

THE COST OF IMPROVEMENT

Behind a silk curtain in the temple infirmary, a young courier raises an arm wrapped in linen. Beneath the bandages, pale ridges move under the skin like roots testing soil. "They said I would never break again," he whispers. "They did not tell me I would still feel it growing."

Part 2: Warehouse 17

THE HIDDEN CLINIC

The warehouse stands apart from its neighbors, freshly painted and without a sign. No dockhands work its doors. Through a narrow window you see white tables, restraint straps, and ceramic jars stamped with the Varin crest. A bell

rings once inside. Footsteps stop.

Warehouse 17 is guarded by four House Veterans and one Varin Biomancer. The guards surrender if shown proof that the city watch is coming; the biomancer destroys records and flees toward the estate if possible.

Key Areas

1. Receiving Floor

Crates contain surgical instruments, tissue preservatives, and restraint frames. A shipping board lists Frostarharbor as the next destination.

2. Recovery Cots

Three conscious volunteers and two kidnapped laborers lie sedated. Freeing them provides witnesses and reduces House Varin's public support.

3. Procedure Room

A half-completed grafting apparatus holds a dead lattice construct. Arcana DC 16 identifies a remote signal from beneath the Varin estate.

4. Records Office

A trapped cabinet releases soporific gas (DC 15 Constitution save or unconscious for 1 minute). Inside are payroll books and a gala access token.

5. River Exit

A concealed boat tunnel allows captured evidence or rescued victims to be moved discreetly to the Celestial Temple.

Nonlethal Stakes: Most guards are ordinary employees told they are protecting medical research. Their surrender and testimony are more valuable than their deaths. Make the moral difference between willing profiteers, frightened workers, and altered victims visible.

Optional Silverreach Quests

Counterfeit Reagents

A rival merchant is selling fake anti-mutation tonics. Exposing the fraud requires testing three samples and confronting hired thugs. Reward: 300 gp and two potions of greater healing.

Guild Sabotage

A warehouse fire threatens evidence connecting House Varin to High Bastion. Saving the records is a 4-success skill challenge. Success gives Inspector Dain legal authority to raid the estate after the gala.

The Vanished Street Children

Six children are hidden in a sealed cellar awaiting transport. Rescuing them earns Auriel's full support and causes one Varin guard unit to abandon the estate.

The Blackroot Liaison

A duergar emissary from Blackroot Enclave offers a sigil disruptor in exchange for a copy of the Varin relay coordinates. Accepting creates an early alliance and grants one use of suppressing regeneration for 1 round.

Mutation Panic

A volunteer suffers an uncontrolled transformation in the Golden Forum. Calming rather than killing the victim earns public trust and proves the procedures are unstable.

Part 3: The Sapphire Gala

THE GALA BEGINS

Crystal chandeliers scatter blue light across a hall of masked nobles. Musicians play from a balcony while servants carry silver trays beneath banners reading PROGRESS THROUGH COMPASSION. At the far end, Lady Miravel Varin raises a glass beside a display of gleaming surgical instruments. “Tonight,” she announces, “Silverreach funds a future without frailty.”

Run the gala as a skill challenge: 5 successes before 3 failures. Each character should contribute, and repeated use of the same skill increases the DC by 2. Base DC is 15.

Approach	Example Result
Persuasion	Gain a noble sponsor or convince a servant to reveal restricted corridors.
Deception	Pose as a donor, physician, or visiting dignitary.
Insight	Identify which guests are afraid, altered, or secretly opposed to Varin.
Sleight of Hand	Steal a signet, key, invitation ribbon, or archive seal.
Stealth	Reach the upper gallery or servants’ passage unseen.
Arcana	Detect the relay signal hidden beneath decorative warding.

- Five successes: the party reaches the private archive unnoticed and gains surprise in the first estate encounter.
- One or two failures: guards become suspicious; the party must surrender weapons or create a distraction.
- Three failures: the estate locks down, and the party must fight or flee through the gallery before reaching the archive.

Roleplaying House Varin

Lady Miravel argues that every advancement has demanded sacrifice and that history remembers results, not discomfort. Lord Cassian focuses on cured soldiers, restored workers, and children who might survive disease. Neither considers themselves evil. Miravel values power; Cassian values outcomes and can be turned if shown living victims and falsified safety reports.

A PATRON’S DEFENSE

Lady Miravel’s smile does not falter when you mention Marrowfen. “You saw a laboratory,” she says. “I saw a generation of knowledge purchased in months

rather than centuries. History is always expensive. The only honest question is who pays.”

Part 4: Beneath House Varin

The private archive conceals a lift descending to an underground relay office. Unless noted otherwise, the vault is lit by blue-white glyphs and guarded by wards keyed to Varin signets.

1. Private Archive

Ledgers are stored in rotating brass cabinets. The complete financial record links House Varin to Emberfall, Marrowfen, High Bastion, and Frostharbor. Removing the ledgers without a signet triggers an alarm.

2. Hall of Benefactors

Portraits of donors animate as magical sentries. Treat them as two Helmed Horrors reskinned as gilded portrait guardians.

3. Compliance Chamber

A crystal device extracts memories from altered subjects. Destroying it frees three psychic echoes that reveal the phrase “Glacial phase complete.”

4. Contract Vault

Signed agreements promise House Varin exclusive access to post-ascension treatments. One contract bears no signature, only the letters R.S.

5. Ward Control

Four pillars power the final chamber’s hazards. Each can be disabled with DC 16 Arcana or thieves’ tools. Every disabled pillar removes one possible lair effect.

6. Financial Relay

A circular chamber projects trade routes as lines of green light. At its center stands Veyra Sorn, her noble robes fused to a shifting lattice carapace.

Resting in the Estate: A short rest is possible after the Compliance Chamber if the alarm has not sounded. A long rest allows House Varin to evacuate key witnesses and sends the Frostharbor warning ahead, increasing the next chapter’s alert level.

Part 5: The Krasis Noble

VEYRA SORN

Green lines race across the floor and climb the woman standing beside the relay. Her outline splits into three overlapping images. One smiles. One draws a dagger. One is already behind you. “Gold,” she says, “is the simplest mutation catalyst. It reshapes priorities before it ever reshapes flesh.”

Battlefield Features

- **Ward Pillars.** Up to four active pillars create effects at initiative count 20. Each has AC 16, 20 hit points, and immunity to poison and psychic damage.
- **Relay Dais.** A creature standing on the dais can use an action and DC 17 Arcana check to interrupt Veyra’s Aberrant Blink until the end of her next turn.
- **Ledger Shelves.** Shelves provide half cover. A creature can topple one with a DC 15 Strength check, creating difficult terrain in a 10-foot line.
- **Glass Memory Orbs.** Breaking an orb releases a psychic scream; creatures within 10 feet make a DC 15 Wisdom save or take 2d8 psychic damage.

Ward Effects

d4	Effect
1	A shielding sigil grants Veyra 15 temporary hit points.
2	A floor glyph erupts; creatures in a 10-foot radius make a DC 15 Dexterity save or take 3d8 force damage.
3	Gravity distorts; movement costs double until initiative count 20 next round.
4	A backlash arcs to a random creature, dealing 2d8 lightning damage.

Veyra’s Tactics

Veyra begins displaced, using spells and Warp Lash to separate the party. She targets anyone carrying the Marrowfen Relay Crystal. When reduced below half hit points, she uses Controlled Mutation to gain resistance to the most recent damage type that harmed her. She offers surrender only if the party agrees to preserve the financial relay.

The Evidence Decision

After Veyra falls, the relay begins erasing records. The party has 3 rounds to choose priorities. Each round, one character can secure one category with a successful DC 16 Arcana, Investigation, or thieves’ tools check: financial ledgers, victim records, Frosthabor coordinates, or donor identities. A failure destroys that category unless another character spends the next round recovering it.

Aftermath

With the relay disabled, House Varin’s protection fractures. The party must decide whether to expose everything publicly or work through the King’s Hall and Celestial Temple to dismantle the network quietly.

Choice	Immediate Result	Long-Term Consequence
Public Exposure	Crowds gather, arrests begin, and House Varin’s reputation collapses.	Silverreach reforms violently; several nobles flee with money and contacts.
Quiet Dismantling	Inspector Dain freezes assets and arrests key conspirators before news spreads.	The city remains stable, but some guilty patrons retain influence.
Seize the Network	The party or an ally controls the financial relay.	Resources become available for the war, but the temptation to use Varin methods remains.

THE CONSPIRACY EXPOSED

By sunrise, the golden banners over House Varin hang torn and wet with river mist. Bells ring from the Celestial Temple. In the King’s Hall, sealed ledgers strike a marble table one after another. On the final page, beside a shipment of glacial stabilizers, a single message waits: “Ascension threshold approaching. Send witnesses north.”

Rewards

- Silverreach authorities award 1,200 gp if the party provides sufficient evidence.
- The Celestial Temple grants three potions of greater healing and one scroll of greater restoration.
- The party receives a Varin Signet Key, which grants advantage on one check to bypass a lattice-funded security system.

- Veyra carries an Arcane Displacement Brooch. Once per long rest, its wearer can teleport 15 feet as a bonus action after being targeted by an attack.
- Recovered accounts reveal supply caches in Frosthabor, allowing the party to begin the next chapter with cold-weather gear and two antitoxin doses.

Milestone Advancement

Characters advance to 9th level after shutting down the financial relay, exposing House Varin's connection to the Krasis network, and securing the Frosthabor coordinates.

If House Varin Escapes

- Funding continues through hidden accounts, strengthening later Krasis encounters.
- Silverreach begins offering voluntary augmentation to nobles and soldiers.
- Veyra or another Varin agent appears in Frosthabor with advance warning.
- The Aetherfall finale begins with one additional financial relay that can restore a destroyed tower node once.

Transition to Frosthabor

THE NORTHERN SHIPMENT

The secured relay projects a frozen coastline. Beneath the image, lines of precise script update in real time: THERMAL EXTREMES VERIFIED. GLACIAL CALIBRATION AT 93%. A ship leaves Silverreach before dawn carrying sealed crystal components north. Its destination is Frosthabor.

Chapter 7 Creature Appendix

House Varin Veteran

Medium humanoid, lawful neutral

Armor Class 17 (splint) | Hit Points 65 (10d8+20) | Speed 30 ft.

STR 16 (+3) DEX 13 (+1) CON 14 (+2) INT 11 (+0) WIS 12 (+1) CHA 12 (+1)

Saving Throws. Str +6, Con +5

Skills. Athletics +6, Perception +4

Senses. passive Perception 14

Challenge. 3 (700 XP)

Disciplined Defense. The veteran has advantage on opportunity attacks and cannot be frightened while within 10 feet of an allied Varin guard.

Protect the Evidence. When a creature moves toward a document, witness, or relay component within 15 feet, the veteran can move up to half its speed as a reaction.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The veteran makes two longsword attacks.

Longsword. Melee Weapon Attack: +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 8 (1d8+4) slashing damage, or 9 (1d10+4) with two hands.

Heavy Crossbow. Ranged Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, range 100/400 ft., one target. Hit: 6 (1d10+1) piercing damage.

Shield Bash. Melee Weapon Attack: +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 6 (1d6+3) bludgeoning damage, and the target must succeed on a DC 14 Strength save or fall prone.

REACTIONS

Interpose. The veteran imposes disadvantage on an attack against an ally within 5 feet.

Varin Biomancer

Medium humanoid, lawful evil

Armor Class 15 (mage armor) | Hit Points 78 (12d8+24) | Speed 30 ft.

STR 9 (-1) DEX 14 (+2) CON 14 (+2) INT 18 (+4) WIS 13 (+1) CHA 15 (+2)

Saving Throws. Int +7, Wis +4

Skills. Arcana +10, Medicine +7

Damage Resistances. poison

Senses. passive Perception 11

Challenge. 6 (2,300 XP)

Spellcasting. The biomancer is a 9th-level spellcaster (spell save DC 15, +7 to

hit). At will: mage hand, ray of frost, shocking grasp. 1st level (4 slots): mage armor, shield, sleep. 2nd level (3 slots): hold person, misty step, ray of enfeeblement. 3rd level (3 slots): counterspell, lightning bolt, slow. 4th level (3 slots): blight, greater invisibility. 5th level (1 slot): hold monster.

Experimental Serum. As a bonus action, the biomancer injects itself or an adjacent willing creature, granting 10 temporary hit points and advantage on Strength checks for 1 minute. When the effect ends, the target takes 5 necrotic damage.

ACTIONS

Scalpel. Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d4+3) piercing damage plus 7 (2d6) necrotic damage.

Flesh Warp (Recharge 5-6). One creature within 60 feet makes a DC 15 Constitution save. On a failure, it takes 22 (4d10) necrotic damage and its speed is reduced by 10 feet for 1 minute. It repeats the save at the end of each turn.

Krasis Noble of House Varin

Medium aberration, lawful evil

Armor Class 17 (adaptive flesh) | Hit Points 135 (18d8+54) | Speed 30 ft.

STR 12 (+1) DEX 18 (+4) CON 16 (+3) INT 18 (+4) WIS 14 (+2) CHA 18 (+4)

Saving Throws. Dex +8, Int +8, Cha +8

Skills. Arcana +8, Deception +8, Insight +6, Persuasion +8

Damage Resistances. force, psychic

Senses. darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 12

Challenge. 9 (5,000 XP)

Aberrant Displacement. Attack rolls against the noble have disadvantage until she is hit by an attack. The effect returns at the start of her next turn.

Adaptive Flesh. The first time each round the noble takes acid, cold, fire, lightning, or thunder damage, she gains resistance to that damage type until the start of her next turn.

Spellcasting. The noble is a 10th-level spellcaster (spell save DC 16, +8 to hit). At will: mage hand, minor illusion, ray of frost. 1st level (4 slots): shield, magic missile. 2nd level (3 slots): mirror image, misty step. 3rd level (3 slots): counterspell, fear, lightning bolt. 4th level (3 slots): blight, greater invisibility. 5th level (2 slots): dominate person, wall of force.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The noble makes two Arcane Dagger attacks or one Arcane Dagger attack and one Warp Lash attack.

Arcane Dagger. Melee Weapon Attack: +8 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 8 (1d8+4) piercing damage plus 9 (2d8) force damage.

Warp Lash. Ranged Spell Attack: +8 to hit, range 60 ft., one target. Hit: 18 (4d8)

force damage, and the target is pulled up to 15 feet.

Controlled Mutation (Recharge 5-6). The noble chooses one effect for 1 minute: gain a flying speed of 30 feet; increase AC by 2; or gain one additional reaction each round.

REACTIONS

Blink Aside. When hit by an attack, the noble teleports up to 15 feet to an unoccupied space she can see, reducing the damage by 10.

LEGENDARY ACTIONS

Dagger. The noble makes one Arcane Dagger attack.

Warp Step. The noble teleports up to 20 feet.

Cast a Cantrip (Costs 2 Actions). The noble casts a cantrip.

Chapter 7 Clue Chain

Evidence	What It Reveals	Leads To
Marrowfen manifests	House Varin financed equipment and personnel.	Silverreach suppliers
Volunteer testimony	The “medical program” used coercion and concealed failures.	Warehouse 17
Gala archive	Funding was intentional and approved by senior Varin leadership.	Estate vault
Financial relay	Rabu Shin distributed research through trade and noble networks.	Frosthabor
Glacial shipment record	The cold-weather phase is nearly complete.	Frozen Evolution

Treasure Summary

Reward	Source	Notes
1,200 gp	Silverreach authorities	Requires sufficient admissible evidence.
3 greater healing potions	Celestial Temple	Awarded for protecting victims.
Scroll of greater restoration	Celestial Temple	Single-use spell scroll.
Varin Signet Key	Contract vault	Advantage on one

		lattice-funded security check.
Arcane Displacement Brooch	Veyra Sorn	Bonus-action 15-foot teleport once per long rest.

Chapter 8

DUSKMIRE CROSSING

CARAVANS OF THE CHANGED

Recommended Level 9 • Bridge Chapter • No Automatic Level Advancement

DM NOTE. Chapter Purpose. Duskmire Crossing reveals that Rabu Shin's experiments are no longer limited to fixed laboratories. The Krasis network now uses trade caravans, fatigue, fear, and environmental stress to trigger dormant mutations in ordinary travelers. This chapter links House Varin's funding network to the glacial project in Frostharbor while giving the party a mobile, investigation-driven threat.



Duskmire Crossing settlement map

Duskmire Crossing

Duskmire Crossing stands where the eastern trade road divides between Silverreach, Sunspire, Lunareth, and the southern caravan routes. The settlement grew around a stone bridge, a crowded bazaar, wagon yards, and inns built to shelter travelers from dust storms and bandit raids. Its people are accustomed to strangers, shortages, and danger. They are not accustomed to caravans arriving with passengers who no longer remember what they were.

In recent weeks, three merchant trains have reached the Crossing late, damaged, and nearly silent. Survivors display hardened skin, trembling limbs, distorted shadows, and sudden bursts of violence. Every affected caravan carried sealed medical supplies purchased through House Varin accounts. The supplies are not medicine. They are activation agents designed to awaken dormant lattice grafts under stress.

ARRIVAL AT THE CROSSING

Heat shimmers above the road as the trade settlement comes into view. Canvas awnings crowd both sides of a broad river crossing, and wagon wheels grind over stone worn smooth by generations of travel. Merchants call prices through the dust. Stablehands drag nervous animals toward water. Then a bell rings from the eastern road. A caravan has arrived. No driver guides the lead wagon. Its horses walk in perfect step, their reins dragging through the sand.

Starting the Chapter

The chapter begins immediately after the party leaves Silverreach or while they are following the northern shipping records recovered from House Varin. The secured documents identify a caravan code—DUSK-17—carrying preserved tissue, alchemical triggers, and a courier bound for Frostarbor. The shipment should have passed through Duskmire Crossing six days ago. It never arrived at its next checkpoint.

- **The Varin Ledger.** Inspector Dain asks the party to intercept DUSK-17 and recover its courier case before House Varin’s remaining agents can destroy it.
- **A Missing Caravan.** A merchant family offers 500 gp for proof of what happened to the Amber Road Company and its thirty travelers.
- **Blackroot Warning.** A coded note from a duergar liaison warns that the shipment contains “stress keys”—chemicals capable of activating dormant biomatic changes.
- **Temple Appeal.** High Priestess Auriel asks the party to locate missing volunteers who were promised safe passage and treatment in Frostarbor.

Keyed Locations in Duskmire Crossing

1. **Drover’s Rest Inn.** A sprawling caravan inn run by Hesta Vane, a stern human veteran who keeps meticulous arrival books. Her ledger contains three entries written in the same hand by supposedly different caravan masters.
2. **The Cloven Helm Tavern.** Teamsters, guards, gamblers, and caravan scouts gather here. Proprietor Brannik Holt knows which companies hire honest protection and which accept sealed cargo without questions.
3. **Hedgewick Bazaar.** A maze of awnings and temporary stalls. Contraband medicine, foreign spices, replacement wagon parts, and stolen seals can all be found with enough coin or patience.

4. Willowbell Remedies. Healer Mara Willowbell treats travelers suffering from heat, exhaustion, and strange graft-like scars. She has hidden two altered survivors from armed men searching the town.
5. Willowell Tonics. An apothecary and tea shop whose owner unknowingly sold activation draughts supplied through a Silverreach distributor. Empty crates bear the same lattice geometry seen in Marrowfen.
6. The Stone Bridge. The settlement's central crossing. A hollow maintenance chamber beneath its eastern support has been converted into a temporary surgical station.
7. East Caravan Yard. Abandoned wagons from DUSK-17 are held under guard. Their wheel ruts contain glassy green residue that reacts to heat and strong emotion.
8. South Watch Post. Captain Ilyra Voss commands twenty guards but lacks authority to search merchant cargo without proof. She can provide riders once the party exposes the threat.

Important NPCs

NPC	Role and Manner	What They Know
Captain Ilyra Voss	Practical watch commander; speaks in clipped questions.	Three caravans suffered attacks at the same dry wash east of town.
Hesta Vane	Innkeeper and former caravan guard; distrusts nobles.	The handwriting in several arrival ledgers belongs to one disguised clerk.
Mara Willowbell	Compassionate healer; refuses to surrender patients.	Altered survivors were injected before departure, then triggered by exhaustion.
Brannik Holt	Boisterous tavern owner with excellent memory.	A pale surgeon hired mercenaries and purchased scorpion venom.
Sahir Pell	Terrified Varin courier hiding under a false name.	The Frostharbor shipment contains final glacial calibration data.
Doctor Cael Veyr	Arcane Surgeon and chapter antagonist.	He believes stress reveals the body's "honest potential."

Duskmire Rumors

d8	Rumor
1	A wagon arrived with every passenger asleep and every horse staring east.
2	Something with a human face and a scorpion's tail hunts the dry wash.
3	Willowbell Remedies is hiding monsters in the cellar.
4	A merchant paid in Silverreach platinum for barrels labeled as tea.
5	The old bridge hums after sunset.
6	A caravan guard survived being stabbed through the chest and begged to be killed.
7	The missing travelers were promised treatment in Frosthabor.
8	A surgeon with silver gloves was seen boarding DUSK-17 outside town.

Part 1: The Driverless Caravan

THE EMPTY LEAD WAGON

The lead wagon rolls to a stop at the edge of the yard. Its canvas cover is torn from within. Beneath it, crates lie stacked in perfect rows around a single wooden chair bolted to the floor. Leather restraints hang open. A thin line of green crystal runs from the chair into the wagon frame, pulsing in time with the frightened horses' breathing.

The returning caravan contains six wagons, eight exhausted horses, and no visible travelers. Searching the wagons reveals bloodless restraint marks, broken water skins, and personal belongings arranged as if someone catalogued them. A successful DC 14 Investigation check finds a false floor in the third wagon. Beneath it is a sedated caravan scout named Toma Reed.

Toma wakes after magical healing or 10 minutes of care. He remembers the caravan entering a dust storm, guards distributing “heat medicine,” and Doctor Cael Veyr ordering everyone to keep moving. When panic began, several travelers changed. Cael separated the transformed from the unaltered and directed the wagons toward an abandoned toll station in the eastern badlands.

The Wagon Lattice

The chair is an activation cradle. Arcana DC 16 identifies three linked triggers: elevated body temperature, exhaustion, and fear. A restrained subject exposed to all three receives a remote lattice pulse. Destroying the cradle is simple, but preserving it provides proof and advantage on one check to disable Cael's surgical engine later.

DM NOTE. Stress Track. During this chapter, the party may accumulate Stress from forced marches, extreme heat, frightening discoveries, or failed group checks. At 3 Stress, a character has disadvantage on the first Wisdom saving throw made during the final laboratory encounter. A short rest in safety removes 1 Stress; a long rest removes all Stress. This is a chapter-specific tension mechanic, not a permanent condition.

Encounter: Changed in the Cargo Yard

While the party investigates, two hidden survivors awaken inside sealed grain wagons. Use two Lattice-Changed Caravan Guards. They are frightened, confused, and attack the nearest creatures after hearing Cael's command through the lattice. A character can use an action and make a DC 15 Persuasion, Medicine, or Arcana check to suppress one guard's aggression until the start of the character's next turn. Three total successes calm a guard permanently.

Killing the guards is possible but costs the party potential testimony. Saving at least one grants advantage on social checks with Captain Voss and Mara Willowbell.

Part 2: A Town Full of Triggers

The party needs to determine where the missing travelers were taken and identify the courier carrying Frostharbor data. Three investigation threads are available. Completing any two reveals the abandoned toll station; completing all three grants one additional advantage in the final assault.

Willowbell's Patients

THE HIDDEN SURVIVORS

Mara opens the cellar door only after every weapon is lowered. Two figures lie beneath wet linen sheets. One has a ridge of dark chitin along her spine. The other grips the bedframe with fingers that have lengthened into hooked claws. Both are awake. Both are crying. "They are still people," Mara says. "Whatever you do next, remember that."

The survivors, Del Avar and Nessa Vale, were injected by mercenaries before the dust storm. Medicine DC 15 confirms the changes are incomplete and can be suppressed. Nessa remembers a symbol painted on Cael's wagon: a split sun above a toll arch. Del knows the surgeon used scorpion venom purchased at Hedgewick Bazaar.

Reward for Compassion. If the party treats the survivors as victims, Mara provides three doses of Willowbell Cooling Draught. A creature drinking one gains resistance to fire damage for 1 hour and ignores one level of chapter Stress.

The Bazaar's False Physician

A merchant named Pel Ordo sold Cael venom, restraints, and desert navigation charts. He refuses to cooperate unless confronted with Varin records or persuaded with a DC 16 check. His receipts identify the old Dawnroad Toll Station, twelve miles east of town. They also reveal that Cael expected a courier named Sahir Pell to deliver a crystal cylinder to Frostharbor.

If threatened, Pel alerts two disguised Varin agents using Spy stat blocks. Capturing either agent reveals that Sahir never reached Cael and is hiding somewhere in Duskmire Crossing.

The Bridge Chamber

A maintenance hatch beneath the eastern bridge support opens into a temporary operating room. Two cultists and one Varin Biomancer are destroying records when the party arrives. The chamber contains restraint tables, empty injection

tubes, and a speaking crystal through which Cael repeats the phrase, “Stress reveals compatibility.”

A successful DC 16 Investigation check finds a route map marking three ambush sites. The newest mark circles the Dawnroad Toll Station. A ledger lists 18 subjects: 6 dead, 8 transferred, 3 “field viable,” and 1 courier pending.

Finding Sahir Pell

Sahir hides in a rented loft above the Cloven Helm, terrified that both House Varin and Cael are hunting him. He has the Frostharrow cylinder but refuses to surrender it unless promised protection. Persuasion DC 15, proof that House Varin has fallen, or the presence of Captain Voss convinces him.

The cylinder contains partial glacial calibration records, payment codes, and a message: “Mobile strain confirms activation under sustained stress. Deliver viable specimens north. Ascension threshold approaches.” Sahir also knows Cael plans to leave the toll station before dawn.

Optional Duskmire Quests

The Wells Run Bitter

An activation compound has contaminated a public cistern. The party must identify and neutralize it before evening traffic arrives. Three successes using Arcana, Nature, Medicine, or Survival (DC 15) prevent a townwide panic. Reward: 250 gp and Captain Voss assigns four guards to the toll-station assault.

The Caravan of Mirrors

A merchant wagon carries polished panels that reflect viewers with subtle mutations. The mirrors are divination relays recording emotional responses. Destroying or cleansing them prevents Cael from gaining advance knowledge of the party’s spellcasters.

The Scorpion Pit

A beast handler keeps oversized desert scorpions beneath the bazaar. Cael paid to harvest venom, then abandoned one altered specimen. Use a Giant Scorpion with 20 additional hit points and resistance to poison damage. Reward: antitoxin, 200 gp, and enough venom to coat three weapons for one attack each.

The Missing Teamsters

Four teamsters escaped DUSK-17 and hide in a dry river tunnel. They are pursued by two Human-Scorpion Krasis. Saving them provides a safe route to the toll station and allows the party to bypass the outer sentries.

A Merchant's Choice

A wealthy caravan owner offers the party 600 gp to destroy all evidence that his company transported Varin supplies. Accepting conceals his guilt but provides access to a reinforced wagon useful during the assault. Exposing him earns public support and an additional witness against the remaining Varin network.

Part 3: Ambush on the Amber Road

THE DRY WASH

The road descends between walls of pale stone. Broken wagon spokes protrude from the sand like ribs. No insects move. No wind reaches the wash. Ahead, a overturned coach blocks the narrowest point, and something scratches slowly against the rock above you.

The twelve-mile journey to the toll station crosses exposed desert and a narrow dry wash. Unless the party completed *The Missing Teamsters*, the route is trapped. Spotting the ambush requires DC 16 Perception or Survival.

Encounter: Caravans of the Changed

Four Human-Scorpion Krasis attack from the cliffs and buried positions. Two begin hidden beneath loose sand; two cling to the rock walls. Their goal is to capture, not kill, anyone carrying the Frostharrow cylinder. They retreat toward the toll station if two are defeated.

Terrain Features. The wash is 20 feet wide with 15-foot cliffs. Loose sand is difficult terrain in three 10-foot patches. A damaged wagon provides half cover. A hanging rock shelf can be dropped with a DC 15 Strength check or 10 points of thunder damage, dealing 3d10 bludgeoning damage in a 10-foot square (DC 15 Dexterity save for half).

Clue. Each Krasis bears a metal tag stamped with a subject number and one of three stress symbols: flame, eye, or chain. The tags match categories in Cael's ledger: heat, fear, and exhaustion.

Part 4: The Dawnroad Toll Station

The abandoned station is built into a low ridge. Its visible courtyard and stable conceal a laboratory excavated beneath the tollhouse. Cael's mercenaries are preparing two wagons for departure. If the party arrives undetected, they can sabotage the wagons, free prisoners, or disable the alarm crystal before combat begins.

Approaching the Station

Approach	Check	Result
Old River Tunnel	DC 15 Survival	Bypasses outer guards; available automatically if teamsters were rescued.
Merchant Disguise	DC 16 Deception	Reaches courtyard before suspicion; failure places the

Approach	Check	Result
		party between two guard groups.
Cliff Descent	DC 15 Athletics or Acrobatics	Reaches laboratory vent; failure adds 1 Stress and alerts a lookout.
Direct Assault	No check	Begins combat in the courtyard; prisoners are moved toward the surgical chamber.

Keyed Areas

1. Toll Courtyard

Two veterans and four bandits guard supply wagons. One wagon contains alchemical triggers; the other holds six restrained travelers. Fire in the courtyard risks igniting the trigger wagon, creating a 15-foot burst for 4d6 fire damage (DC 15 Dexterity save for half).

2. Stable of Quiet Horses

Eight horses stand perfectly still, each marked with a small lattice scar. Calming them with Animal Handling DC 14 prevents them from panicking during the escape. One saddlebag contains 350 gp and House Varin payment seals.

3. Tollmaster's Office

Cael's field notes describe the purpose of the trials: determine whether dormant grafts can be activated by ordinary travel hardship, allowing entire populations to be altered without permanent laboratories.

4. Prison Gallery

Eight captives are held behind lattice bars. The bars can be disabled with DC 16 Arcana or thieves' tools, or destroyed (AC 17, 30 hit points). Two captives are beginning to transform and need magical healing or Medicine DC 15 to remain conscious.

5. Venom Distillery

Glass coils refine scorpion venom into activation serum. Two Swarms of Insects and one Chuul guard the chamber. Destroying the still removes Cael's ability to use Forced Adaptation twice during the final battle.

6. Observation Theater

Tiered benches overlook the surgical engine. Crystal recordings contain the voices of House Varin patrons praising the program. Recovering them provides decisive evidence and reveals that Frostharbor's core is already synchronized.

7. Surgical Engine

A rotating brass-and-crystal apparatus surrounds three operating tables. Cael Veyr stands at the central console, flanked by two Human-Scorpion Krasis. Green light travels through tubes in the floor toward every captive in the complex.

Resting at the Toll Station

DM NOTE. A short rest is possible only after the courtyard, prison gallery, and alarm crystal are secured. If the party retreats for a long rest, Cael departs with the Frostharbor data, all surviving captives, and two additional Human-Scorpion Krasis. The final encounter then occurs as a moving caravan chase rather than in the surgical chamber.

Part 5: The Arcane Surgeon

DOCTOR CAEL VEYR

The man at the console wears a spotless coat over armor stitched from overlapping plates of pale chitin. Silver instruments hover around his hands. Behind him, three restrained travelers convulse as green lines crawl beneath their skin. “You call this cruelty,” he says without looking away from his work. “Cruelty is leaving them helpless against the world that is coming.”

Battlefield Features

- **Surgical Tables.** Three captives are restrained. At initiative count 20, one gains 1 mutation charge. At 3 charges, that captive becomes a hostile Lattice-Changed Guard. A character adjacent to a table can use an action and DC 15 Arcana, Medicine, or thieves’ tools check to remove one charge and release the captive.
- **Activation Coils.** Four coils power Cael’s regenerative harness. Each has AC 15, 18 hit points, and immunity to poison and psychic damage. Destroying two suppresses Cael’s Regeneration; destroying all four also prevents Forced Adaptation.
- **Venom Channels.** A creature pushed into a channel takes 2d6 poison damage and must succeed on a DC 15 Constitution save or be poisoned until the end of its next turn.
- **Observation Windows.** Breaking a window creates jagged difficult terrain and allows rescued captives to escape into the corridor.

Cael’s Tactics

Cael begins behind the surgical engine, using Flesh Warp and spell attacks while the two Human-Scorpion Krasis hold the front line. He targets characters with

visible wounds, calling them “high-value stress responses.” If the party destroys two coils, he abandons restraint and uses Reconstruction on a fallen Krasis. At fewer than 35 hit points, he attempts to inject himself with the final serum, gaining 20 temporary hit points and a scorpion tail attack until defeated.

Surgical Engine Events

d6	Event
1	A lattice pulse forces all creatures in the chamber to make a DC 15 Wisdom save or gain 1 Stress.
2	A restrained captive gains 1 mutation charge.
3	A gravity clamp activates; one 10-foot square becomes difficult terrain and restrains a creature that fails a DC 15 Strength save.
4	Venom sprays from a ruptured tube in a 15-foot cone; DC 15 Dexterity save, 3d6 poison damage, half on success.
5	Cael’s harness restores 12 hit points unless Regeneration has been suppressed.
6	A memory crystal projects a victim’s scream; creatures within 15 feet of the engine make a DC 14 Wisdom save or are frightened until the end of their next turn.

Cael’s Confession

If captured or reduced below 15 hit points and offered survival, Cael explains that Rabu Shin selected Duskmire because caravans reproduce every useful stressor: heat, thirst, fear, isolation, fatigue, and social dependence. The goal was not to create individual monsters. It was to prove that whole populations could carry dormant alterations until the correct conditions activated them.

THE SURGEON’S CERTAINTY

“Rabu Shin is not mad. He is ascended. You still imagine him as a man hiding in a laboratory. He is the instruction inside every lattice. The command that survives the hand that wrote it. Frosthabor is not another experiment. It is the final calibration.”

Aftermath

With Cael defeated and the surgical engine disabled, the remaining captives can be returned to Duskmire Crossing. Captain Voss arrests surviving mercenaries and closes the east road while healers examine every recent caravan. The party's choices determine whether the town responds with compassion, fear, or violence toward altered survivors.

The Frostharbor Cylinder

The recovered cylinder contains complete shipping coordinates, a glacial access cipher, and a recorded message from an unknown emissary: “Mobile activation verified. Thermal extremes confirmed. Deliver all viable strains to the northern core. Ascension imminent.” The access cipher grants advantage on one Arcana check made to bypass a Frostharbor lattice seal.

Rewards

- Captain Voss and the merchant companies award 900 gp for rescuing the captives and reopening the Amber Road.
- Mara Willowbell provides three potions of greater healing and one restorative salve that ends the poisoned or frightened condition when applied as an action.
- Cael's Silver Surgical Bracer functions as a spellcasting focus. Once per long rest, its wearer can cast lesser restoration without expending a spell slot.
- The party receives the Frostharbor Access Cipher and a sealed case of cold-weather equipment.
- If Sahir survives, he provides a Varin route map that allows the party to avoid one random travel encounter on the journey north.

Advancement

Duskmire Crossing is a bridge chapter and does not automatically grant a level. Characters remain 9th level unless the Dungeon Master uses experience points or the party entered the chapter below the recommended level. The information and equipment recovered here substantially reduce the difficulty of Frostharbor.

If Cael Escapes

- Cael reaches Frostharbor with viable subjects and reinforces the glacial laboratory.
- One altered survivor in Duskmire becomes a remote relay, causing a second outbreak after the party leaves.
- The Frostharbor core begins with 30 temporary hit points and one additional guardian.
- Cael appears during the Frostharbor boss encounter with half hit points and no legendary actions.

Transition to Frostharbor

THE NORTHERN ROAD

The crystal cylinder opens beneath the cold light of dawn. Lines of green fire sketch a coastline buried beneath ice. One point pulses beneath a glacier shelf, brighter than every node you have seen before. Across the projection, a final message forms: GLACIAL PHASE COMPLETE. The desert wind suddenly feels very far away.

Chapter 8 Creature Appendix

Lattice-Changed Caravan Guard

Medium humanoid, any alignment

Armor Class 16 (reinforced hide) | Hit Points 68 (8d8+32) | Speed 30 ft.

STR 17 (+3) DEX 13 (+1) CON 18 (+4) INT 10 (+0) WIS 11 (+0) CHA 9 (-1)

Saving Throws Con +7, Wis +3

Skills Athletics +6, Perception +3

Damage Resistances poison

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 13 | **Languages** Common | **Challenge 4 (1,100 XP)**

Dormant Humanity. When first reduced below half its hit points, the guard can make a DC 15 Wisdom saving throw. On a success, it is incapacitated until the end of its next turn and can be calmed with a successful DC 15 Persuasion or Medicine check.

Stress-Fueled. The guard has advantage on melee attack rolls while frightened, poisoned, or below half its hit points.

Unstable Graft. When the guard takes radiant damage, it cannot use Stress-Fueled until the end of its next turn.

Actions

Multiattack. The guard makes two attacks with its grafted blade or heavy fist.

Grafted Blade. Melee Weapon Attack: +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 10 (2d6+3) slashing damage.

Heavy Fist. Melee Weapon Attack: +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 8 (1d10+3) bludgeoning damage, and the target must succeed on a DC 14 Strength save or be pushed 5 feet.

Panic Pulse (Recharge 5-6). Each creature of the guard's choice within 10 feet must succeed on a DC 14 Wisdom save or be frightened until the end of its next turn.

Human-Scorpion Krasis

Medium aberration, lawful evil

Armor Class 16 (chitinous hide) | Hit Points 102 (12d8+48) | Speed 40 ft., climb 30 ft., burrow 15 ft.

STR 18 (+4) DEX 16 (+3) CON 18 (+4) INT 9 (-1) WIS 14 (+2) CHA 8 (-1)

Saving Throws Dex +6, Con +7, Wis +5

Skills Athletics +7, Perception +5, Stealth +6

Damage Resistances poison; **Condition Immunities** poisoned

Senses darkvision 90 ft., tremorsense 20 ft., passive Perception 15 | **Languages**

understands Common but speaks only broken phrases | **Challenge 6 (2,300 XP)**

Ambusher. The Krasis has advantage on attack rolls against any creature it has surprised.

Spider Climb. The Krasis can climb difficult surfaces, including upside down on ceilings, without needing to make an ability check.

Buried Hunter. While buried in sand or loose earth, the Krasis is heavily obscured and can sense creatures through tremorsense.

Reactive Carapace. When hit by a ranged weapon attack, the Krasis gains +2 AC against ranged weapon attacks until the start of its next turn.

Actions

Multiattack. The Krasis makes two Claw attacks and one Sting attack.

Claw. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 9 (1d10+4) slashing damage. If both claws hit the same Large or smaller creature, it is grappled (escape DC 15).

Sting. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. Hit: 8 (1d8+4) piercing damage plus 14 (4d6) poison damage. The target must succeed on a DC 15 Constitution save or be poisoned for 1 minute. It repeats the save at the end of each of its turns.

Burrow Ambush (Recharge 5-6). The Krasis burrows up to its speed without provoking opportunity attacks, then emerges in an unoccupied space and makes one Claw attack with advantage. On a hit, the target must succeed on a DC 15 Strength save or fall prone.

Doctor Cael Veyr, Arcane Surgeon

Medium humanoid (human), lawful evil

Armor Class 17 (arcane coat and adaptive grafts) | **Hit Points 150 (20d8+60)** | **Speed 30 ft.**

STR 11 (+0) DEX 16 (+3) CON 16 (+3) INT 19 (+4) WIS 15 (+2) CHA 14 (+2)

Saving Throws Dex +7, Con +7, Int +8, Wis +6

Skills Arcana +12, Medicine +10, Investigation +8, Perception +6

Damage Resistances poison; **Condition Immunities** poisoned

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 16 | **Languages** Common, Draconic, Elvish | **Challenge 10 (5,900 XP)**

Adaptive Mutation. At the start of each of Cael's turns, choose one: gain resistance to one damage type that damaged him since his previous turn; increase his speed by 10 feet; or gain advantage on Constitution saving throws until the start of his next turn.

Regeneration. Cael regains 10 hit points at the start of his turn while at least two activation coils remain active. Radiant damage suppresses this trait until the start of his next turn.

Magic Resistance. Cael has advantage on saving throws against spells and other magical effects.

Spellcasting. Cael is a 10th-level spellcaster. His spellcasting ability is Intelligence (spell save DC 16, +8 to hit with spell attacks). At will: mage hand, ray of frost, shocking grasp. 3/day each: counterspell, hold person, misty step, ray of sickness. 1/day each: blight, dimension door, greater invisibility.

Actions

Multiattack. Cael makes two Silver Scalpel attacks or one Silver Scalpel attack and uses Flesh Warp.

Silver Scalpel. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 8 (1d8+4) piercing damage plus 10 (3d6) psychic damage.

Flesh Warp. One creature Cael can see within 60 feet must make a DC 16 Constitution save. On a failure, it takes 22 (4d10) necrotic damage and its speed is reduced by 10 feet until the end of its next turn. On a success, it takes half damage and suffers no speed reduction.

Forced Adaptation (Recharge 5-6). Cael targets one creature within 30 feet. The target makes a DC 16 Constitution save. On a failure, Cael chooses one: the target is restrained by rapidly growing tissue until the end of its next turn; the target takes 18 (4d8) poison damage; or the target is confused until the end of its next turn. On a success, the target takes half the poison damage or ignores the other effect.

Reconstruction (1/Day). Cael touches a dead or unconscious Krasis within 5 feet. It regains 35 hit points and stands. If no valid Krasis is present, Cael instead gains 35 temporary hit points.

Reactions

Surgical Deflection. When Cael is hit by an attack he can see, he adds 3 to his AC against that attack, potentially causing it to miss.

Pain Is Data. When Cael takes damage, he moves up to 10 feet without provoking opportunity attacks.

Legendary Actions

The creature can take 3 legendary actions, choosing from the options below. Only one option can be used at a time and only at the end of another creature's turn. It regains spent legendary actions at the start of its turn.

Move. Cael moves up to half his speed.

Scalpel. Cael makes one Silver Scalpel attack.

Lattice Command (Costs 2 Actions). One allied Krasis within 60 feet moves up to its speed and makes one attack.

Emergency Adaptation (Costs 3 Actions). Cael uses Adaptive Mutation and gains 10 temporary hit points.

Chapter 8 Clue Chain

Evidence	What It Reveals	Leads To
DUSK-17 wagon cradle	Heat, exhaustion, and fear activate dormant lattice grafts.	Changed survivors
Willowbell testimony	Travelers were injected before departure.	Bazaar supplier
Bridge laboratory ledger	Cael categorized subjects by stress response.	Dawnroad Toll Station
Sahir's cylinder	Frostarbor contains the final glacial calibration core.	Northern route
Cael's field notes	The network can alter populations without permanent labs.	Aetherfall strategy
Observation crystals	House Varin patrons knowingly funded mobile trials.	Silverreach consequences

Treasure Summary

Reward	Source	Notes
900 gp	Duskmire watch and merchant companies	Requires rescued captives and reopened road.
3 potions of greater healing	Mara Willowbell	Awarded for protecting altered survivors.
Restorative salve	Mara Willowbell	Ends poisoned or frightened as an action.
Silver Surgical Bracer	Doctor Cael Veyr	Casts lesser restoration once per long rest.
Frostarbor Access Cipher	Sahir's cylinder	Advantage on one glacial lattice seal check.
Cold-weather equipment	Captured shipment	Enough for the full party.
350 gp and Varin seals	Quiet Horses stable	Can support later infiltration or legal proof.

Chapter 9

FROSTHARBOR

FROZEN EVOLUTION

Recommended Level 9 • Advancement to Level 10

DM NOTE. Chapter Purpose. Frostharbor is the culmination of Rabu Shin's environmental calibration program. The characters discover that the northern experiments are no longer trials but final synchronization tests. By destroying the glacial lattice core, they gain the coordinates and key needed to reach Sunspire and learn that Rabu Shin has transferred his consciousness beyond a single body.



Frostharbor settlement map

Frostharbor

Frostharbor rests where black cliffs meet the frozen northern sea. Its homes are built from dark timber, whale bone, and stone quarried from beneath the ice. Fishing vessels spend most of the year locked in the harbor, and the people survive through seal hunting, ice mining, and stubborn preparation. Every roof is steep, every doorway is reinforced, and every resident knows how quickly warmth can become life or death.

For the past month, the ice has behaved with impossible precision. Cracks form in repeating geometric patterns. Frozen ships rise from beneath the harbor intact. Hunting beasts move in coordinated packs, and a pale green light flashes beneath the glacier shelf during storms. The entire region is being used as the final cold-resistance test for the Krasis lattice network.

ARRIVAL IN FROSTHARBOR

The northern wind strikes like a blade. Snow races sideways across the road, and the harbor beyond lies trapped beneath a white plain of ice. Ship masts protrude from the frozen sea like the ribs of a buried beast. Then a deep crack rolls through the harbor. The sound is too even, too measured. A line of green light travels beneath the ice, turns at a perfect angle, and vanishes beneath the distant glacier.

Starting the Chapter

The party reaches Frosthabor with the access cipher recovered in Duskmire Crossing and evidence that Doctor Cael Veyr shipped activation compounds north. The cipher identifies a receiving station hidden beneath the Lighthouse of the Pale Beam. Captain Elska Rimeborn meets the party at the southern gate and immediately asks for help: three hunters vanished near a newly opened fissure, and the lighthouse has not shown its true white signal in four nights.

- **The Frost Cipher.** The code recovered from Cael opens sealed doors within the glacial research vault.
- **Missing Hunters.** Families offer 600 gp for the return of the glacier scouts, dead or alive.
- **The Green Lighthouse.** Harbor pilots believe the altered beacon is drawing creatures toward the town.
- **The Frozen Emissary.** House Varin records identify an unnamed “northern emissary” who completed the glacial phase and reported directly to Rabu Shin.

Extreme Cold

Outside heated structures, a creature exposed to the weather for 1 hour must succeed on a DC 13 Constitution saving throw or gain one level of exhaustion. Cold-weather clothing grants advantage. A creature with resistance or immunity to cold damage automatically succeeds. During whiteouts, visibility is limited to 60 feet and ranged weapon attacks beyond 30 feet are made with disadvantage.

DM NOTE. Do not use the weather only as attrition. Warm shelters, local guides, magical fire, and good planning should let the characters control the risk. The cold should create urgency and atmosphere rather than simply consume resources.

Keyed Locations in Frosthabor

- 1. Frost Winds Inn. A crowded inn built around a communal stone hearth. Proprietor Torv Blackhelm knows every hunter and sailor in town and keeps a board of missing names above the fireplace.
- 2. The Winter Hearth. A public hall, shrine, and emergency shelter overseen by Sister Ylsa. The hearth flame has recently begun leaning toward the glacier even when no doors are open.
- 3. Frozen Docks. Ships sit locked in ice. Dockworkers have found old vessels rising from below, their hulls preserved but their interiors stripped clean.
- 4. Icebound Tavern. Sailors gather here to trade rumors. A survivor named Varek claims something beneath the ice spoke through his teeth.
- 5. Compass Rose Market. Fur traders, ice miners, and shipwrights sell cold-weather gear. Several merchants unknowingly received green-glass heating stones seeded with lattice fragments.
- 6. Brightmane Apothecary. Healer Lysa Brightmane treats frostbite and strange crystalline lesions. She can identify the difference between natural cold injury and biomantic reinforcement.
- 7. Lighthouse of the Pale Beam. The beacon stands on a rocky promontory. Its crystal has been modified to broadcast lattice pulses across the harbor.
- 8. Glacier Shelf. A newly opened fissure leads to the buried Glacial Vault, where the final cold-calibration core is preparing to transmit its results to Aetherfall.

Important NPCs

NPC	Role and Manner	What They Know
Captain Elska Rimeborn	Harbor commander; direct, exhausted, fiercely protective.	The ice cracks in response to the lighthouse beam.
Torv Blackhelm	Innkeeper and retired hunter; warm but suspicious.	The missing hunters followed green tracks onto the glacier.
Sister Ylsa	Keeper of the Winter Hearth; quiet and observant.	The town’s sacred flame bends toward a buried magical source.
Lysa Brightmane	Apothecary; precise, compassionate, scientifically minded.	Victims show deliberate cold adaptation, not disease.
Keeper Orin Vale	Lighthouse keeper; guilt-ridden and partially enthralled.	A masked mage altered the beacon and threatened his family.
Vaelgor the White	Frostbound Diabolist and glacial overseer.	The final synchronization is complete and Rabu Shin is

NPC	Role and Manner	What They Know
		no longer localized.

Frostharbor Rumors

d8	Rumor
1	A ship frozen beneath the harbor for sixty years rose with warm lanterns burning inside.
2	The lighthouse flashes green only when no one is watching it directly.
3	A white bear with wings carried a hunter away without leaving blood on the snow.
4	The glacier is hollow and something enormous is breathing inside it.
5	Brightmane Apothecary is hiding people whose bones have turned to crystal.
6	The ice cracks in the same pattern as the strange sigils seen in Silverreach.
7	A foreign mage paid children to collect shards from newly opened crevasses.
8	The northern lights formed a face above the harbor three nights ago.

Part 1: The Harbor That Cracks Inward

THE FROZEN DOCKS

The dock planks disappear beneath wind-polished ice. Sailors work with axes and heated iron, but every trench they cut closes behind them in smooth, glassy sheets. Farther out, a dark hull rises slowly through the frozen harbor. No ropes pull it. No current moves it. The ice simply lifts the ship into the world.

The newly surfaced vessel is the Northstar, lost forty-two years ago. Its hull is intact, but every bunk and storage locker has been emptied. Investigation DC 15 reveals no sign of decay inside. Arcana DC 16 identifies a preservation field linked to a pulse beneath the harbor. A set of fresh boot prints leads from the vessel toward the lighthouse, though the ship was under solid ice until an hour ago.

Encounter: Predators Beneath the Ice

While the party investigates, two Winter Wolves burst through weakened ice and attack. They fight with unnatural coordination, attempting to drive characters onto marked sections of the harbor. At initiative count 20, one marked 10-foot square fractures. A creature standing there must succeed on a DC 14 Dexterity saving throw or fall into freezing water.

A creature in the water takes 7 (2d6) cold damage at the start of each turn. Climbing out requires 15 feet of movement and a successful DC 12 Athletics check unless aided. After the battle, Nature or Arcana DC 15 reveals tiny green crystal slivers embedded behind each wolf's ears. The slivers transmit commands from the lighthouse.

The Raised Ship

The Northstar's captain's cabin contains a frost-sealed journal. Warming it slowly reveals the final entry: "The light changed. The crew followed it north across the ice. I stayed because I heard another voice beneath it." A hidden compartment contains a silver navigational disk worth 250 gp and a map showing an older tunnel beneath the lighthouse.

Part 2: The Pale Beam

The Lighthouse of the Pale Beam can be approached openly, by scaling the icy cliff, or through the flooded maintenance tunnel shown on the Northstar map. Keeper Orin Vale has barricaded himself in the lantern room. Three Lattice Thralls guard the lower floors, using Veteran statistics with resistance to cold damage and green crystalline scarring.

Lighthouse Areas

1. Entry Hall. The inner walls are coated with frost despite a burning stove. A DC 14 Investigation check finds drag marks leading toward the cellar.
2. Keeper's Quarters. Letters reveal that Orin's daughter was abducted by the glacial overseer. Orin obeyed to keep her alive.
3. Maintenance Cellar. A lattice amplifier has been installed around the original beacon conduit. Destroying it requires three successful DC 15 Arcana, Athletics, or thieves' tools checks before two failures. Each failure releases a pulse dealing 7 (2d6) lightning damage to the acting character.
4. Spiral Stair. Crystalline ice grows across the steps. Characters moving faster than half speed must succeed on a DC 13 Acrobatics check or fall prone and slide 20 feet.
5. Lantern Room. The original white beacon crystal is encased in green lattice growth. Orin stands beside it holding a flare pistol, terrified and desperate.

THE ALTERED LIGHT

The beacon turns above you, but its light is no longer white. A narrow green beam sweeps across the frozen sea, and each time it passes, distant cracks answer like drums. Keeper Orin grips the brass railing with bloodless fingers. "I tried to stop it," he says. "It knows when I lie."

Saving Keeper Orin

Orin is not hostile unless attacked. Persuasion DC 15, presenting evidence of the party's victories, or promising to rescue his daughter convinces him to help. He explains that a pale mage called Vaelgor entered through a fissure in the glacier and used the lighthouse to synchronize every lattice fragment in the region. Orin's daughter, Tessa, was taken into the vault as leverage.

If the party destroys or purifies the amplifier, the command pulses stop. All characters gain inspiration, and Captain Rimeborn can send four scouts to support one later encounter. The beacon crystal also yields a Pale Prism, which can suppress one environmental pulse in the glacial vault as a reaction.

Part 3: Frozen Side Quests

The following quests can be completed before the party enters the glacier. Each provides information, allies, or resources for the final assault.

The White-Eyed Seal

A seal with luminous white eyes repeatedly approaches the docks carrying scraps of red cloth. Following it leads to a trapped hunter beneath a shelf of ice. Rescuing the hunter requires a DC 14 group Athletics or Survival check. Success reveals the

location of a safe crevasse entrance and grants advantage on the first navigation check in the glacier.

The Frozen Fishing Fleet

Three fishing boats are being dragged beneath the ice by a Water Weird altered to deal cold instead of bludgeoning damage. Freeing the boats earns 400 gp in trade goods and the loyalty of the harbor crews. Once during the final escape, those crews can provide ropes and anchors that convert one failed group check into a success.

Black Ice Contamination

Children collecting heating stones have fallen ill. The stones contain dormant lattice splinters. Locating and destroying the shipment requires Investigation DC 15 and a confrontation with four smugglers using Bandit statistics. Lysa Brightmane rewards the party with four potions of cold resistance.

The Icebound Relic

Sister Ylsa asks the characters to recover the Sunsteel Brazier from a shrine swallowed by the glacier. The shrine is guarded by two Ice Mephits and a Helmed Horror. Returning the brazier allows the Winter Hearth to bless the party. Each character gains 10 temporary hit points upon entering the Glacial Vault.

The Missing Hunters

The hunters are trapped in an abandoned ice-mining camp where a Polar Wyvern Krasis circles overhead. The creature retreats toward the glacier if reduced below half its hit points. Saving the hunters provides a detailed sketch of the vault entrance and confirms that Tessa Vale is alive inside.

Part 4: Crossing the Glacier

THE GLACIER SHELF

The glacier rises before you like a frozen mountain range. Across its face, cracks form a perfect spiral hundreds of feet wide. At the spiral's center, a vertical fissure glows with pale green light. Snow falls toward it instead of down, vanishing into the opening as if the ice itself were inhaling.

Reaching the fissure requires three group checks. The party must earn two successes before two failures. Useful skills include Survival DC 15 to choose a route, Athletics DC 14 to cross a crevasse, Perception DC 15 to spot unstable ice, and Arcana DC 16 to predict lattice pulses. A failure deals 10 (3d6) cold damage to each character and alerts the vault guardians.

Encounter: Polar Wyvern Krasis

At the final ridge, a Polar Wyvern Krasis attacks from a whiteout. It uses the storm to isolate one target, then attempts to drag that creature toward a crevasse. If the party previously rescued the hunters, they receive warning and cannot be surprised. The creature bears a metal collar engraved with the words “GLACIAL STRAIN: VIABLE.”

Part 5: The Glacial Vault

The vault is an ancient research complex encased in blue ice and reinforced with black metal. Green crystalline conduits run through the walls like veins. Unless the lighthouse amplifier was destroyed, Vaelgor knows the party’s exact location and all vault encounters begin with enemies prepared.

Vault Features

- Ceilings are 20 feet high unless noted otherwise.
- Walls are magically reinforced ice with AC 17, 30 hit points per 10-foot section, immunity to cold and psychic damage, and vulnerability to fire damage.
- Bright green conduits provide dim light. Destroying a conduit section ends one nearby environmental effect but deals 5 (1d10) force damage to creatures within 5 feet.
- At initiative count 20 during major encounters, the core emits a Glacial Pulse unless the party uses the Pale Prism or has disabled the associated relay.

1. Calibration Gate

The Frost Cipher from Duskmire opens the circular gate without triggering its defenses. Without the cipher, the party must succeed on three DC 17 Arcana or thieves’ tools checks. Each failed check activates a freezing ray: +8 to hit, 13 (3d8) cold damage.

2. Hall of Preserved Failures

PRESERVED ITERATIONS

Shapes stand within the walls of clear ice: wolves with too many lungs, humanoids plated in white chitin, and winged bears frozen mid-roar. Small brass plaques identify each body by number, climate, and survival time. The final alcove is empty. Its plaque reads: “ITERATION 47 - RELEASED FOR FIELD VALIDATION.”

The empty alcove belonged to the Polar Wyvern Krasis. Searching the chamber finds research notes describing how cold suppresses unstable mutation but

strengthens successful grafts. A DC 16 Medicine check reveals several subjects were still alive when frozen.

3. Thermal Inversion Room

This chamber extracts heat from living creatures and stores it in crystal batteries. Crossing requires a DC 15 Constitution saving throw. On a failure, a creature takes 14 (4d6) cold damage and has its speed reduced by 10 feet for 10 minutes. The machine can be disabled with a DC 16 Arcana check or destroyed. Three intact thermal batteries are worth 150 gp each and can each be shattered to deal 10 fire damage to all creatures in a 10-foot radius.

4. Captive Gallery

Tessa Vale and the missing glacier scouts are restrained in upright crystal pods. Two Frostbound Wardens guard them, using Gladiator statistics with resistance to cold damage. Freeing all captives before combat ends requires three actions and DC 14 Arcana or thieves' tools checks. Tessa knows Vaelgor can teleport between three rune circles in the core chamber.

5. Relay Observatory

A crystal projection shows nodes throughout Vael Turog. Greymoor Hollow, Stonewake Port, Emberfall, Lunareth, High Bastion, Marrowfen, Silverreach, and Duskmire are marked as disrupted. Frostharbor flashes "FINAL CALIBRATION." Sunspire and Aetherfall remain bright.

Studying the projection for 10 minutes and succeeding on a DC 17 Arcana check identifies the relay protocol. In the final battle, one character can use an action at a control pedestal to make a DC 16 Arcana check. On a success, Vaelgor loses his regeneration until the end of the next round.

6. The Glacial Lattice Core

THE FINAL CALIBRATION

The vault opens into a cavern large enough to hold a cathedral. A crystalline array hangs inside the glacier, each branch connected to a frozen creature, a metal pylon, or a vein of green light. At the center floats a tall figure wrapped in black robes and white armor. Frost burns glow green across his face. "Thermal extremes verified," he says. "Structural integrity stable. Ascension threshold reached."

Vaelgor's Purpose

Vaelgor the White is a former Frostharbor mage who embraced Rabu Shin's work after losing his family to plague. He believes directed evolution can end suffering

and sees the glacial trials as necessary proof. He is willing to speak before combat and offers the party a place in the ascension. He does not surrender the core.

A character who appeals to Vaelgor's lost family and succeeds on a DC 19 Persuasion check causes him to hesitate. He begins combat without his Frost Mantle temporary hit points. Presenting rescued victims or proof of House Varin's exploitation grants advantage on the check.

Boss Encounter: Frostbound Diabolist

Vaelgor fights alongside two Ice Mephits. He uses walls, teleportation circles, and forced movement to separate the party. The three relay pylons around the chamber have AC 16, 25 hit points, immunity to cold, poison, and psychic damage, and vulnerability to thunder damage. Destroying a pylon weakens both Vaelgor and the core.

Pylons Remaining	Effect
3	Vaelgor regenerates 10 hit points at the start of his turn and has three legendary actions.
2	Regeneration falls to 5 hit points; Vaelgor has two legendary actions.
1	Regeneration ends; Vaelgor has one legendary action.
0	Vaelgor loses Glacial Step and the core begins collapsing.

Glacial Pulses

At initiative count 20, roll on the following table. Do not repeat the same result twice in a row.

d6	Pulse
1	Whiteout. The chamber is heavily obscured until initiative count 20 next round.
2	Ice Eruption. Three 10-foot squares become jagged ice; creatures there make DC 15 Dex saves or take 10 (3d6) piercing damage.
3	Cold Wave. All creatures except Vaelgor make DC 15 Con saves or take 10 (3d6) cold damage.
4	Gravity Tilt. Creatures make DC 15 Dex saves or slide 20 feet toward the central pit.
5	Regenerative Surge. Vaelgor or one pylon regains 15 hit points.

d6	Pulse
6	Lattice Echo. One character hears Rabu Shin and must succeed on a DC 15 Wis save or lose reactions until the next turn.

Destroying the Core

When Vaelgor falls or all pylons are destroyed, the core becomes unstable. The party has 5 rounds to shut it down before the glacier fractures. Each round, one character adjacent to the core can attempt a DC 17 Arcana, Athletics, or thieves' tools check. The party needs four successes before three failures. The Frost Cipher grants one automatic success. A failed check deals 10 (3d6) cold or force damage to the acting character.

If the party succeeds, the core shuts down in a controlled cascade and the captives can escape safely. If the party fails, the core still collapses, but every character must make a DC 16 Dexterity saving throw, taking 28 (8d6) bludgeoning and cold damage on a failure, or half as much on a success.

Rabu Shin's Projection

THE ARCHITECT SPEAKS

The fractured core freezes in mid-collapse. Green light spreads across the cavern wall, forming the outline of a robed figure made from intersecting lines. Rabu Shin regards you with calm curiosity. “You misunderstand,” he says. “I am not destroying your world. I am removing its weaknesses.” The projection turns toward the dead core. “The body was merely a laboratory. I no longer require one.”

Coordinates appear beneath the projection: Sunspire, identified as the origin laboratory, and Aetherfall, identified as the Ascension Nexus. The data confirms Rabu Shin has encoded his consciousness into the lattice network. Destroying individual laboratories can delay him, but only the Aetherfall engine can collapse the distributed mind completely.

Escape from the Glacier

The vault begins to break apart after the projection ends. Run the escape as a group challenge requiring three successes before two failures. Athletics, Acrobatics, Survival, and Arcana are appropriate at DC 15. Rescued hunters, harbor crews, the Pale Prism, or the Sunsteel Brazier can each convert one failure into a success. On failure, each character takes 14 (4d6) damage and loses one nonmagical item chosen by the player beneath the ice.

Chapter Conclusion

With the glacial core destroyed, the harbor ice stops moving in geometric patterns. The lighthouse returns to a steady white beam, trapped vessels settle safely, and the unnatural command over northern predators ends. Frostharbor begins a slow recovery, though the scars within the glacier will remain for generations.

The party now possesses the Sunspire coordinates, the Ascension Protocol, and proof that Rabu Shin exists as a distributed consciousness. Captain Rimeborn provides a ship and winter supplies, while Sister Ylsa urges the characters to seek the origin of the network before Aetherfall completes synchronization.

Milestone Advancement

Characters advance to Level 10 when they defeat Vaelgor, destroy or shut down the Glacial Lattice Core, rescue at least some of the captives, and witness Rabu Shin’s projection.

Rewards

Reward	Description
Pale Prism	Once per long rest, the bearer can use a reaction to gain resistance to cold, lightning, or force damage from one effect.
Winter’s Mercy	A +1 weapon blessed at the Winter Hearth. Against aberrations, it deals an extra 1d4 radiant damage.
Vaelgor’s Sigil Key	Opens one sealed door or bypasses one magical lock within Sunspire.
Frostharbor Gratitude	The party receives 1,200 gp in coin, pearls, and trade goods if the town and captives survive.
Ascension Protocol	A story document revealing how consciousness is transmitted to Aetherfall.

Failure and Escalation

If the party abandons Frostharbor, the glacial core completes transmission. Within three days, the northern ice shelf fractures and trade collapses. Within seven days, cold-adapted Krasis spread south. In the Aetherfall finale, Rabu Shin begins with an additional legendary resistance and all cold-based Krasis gain 10 temporary hit points.

If Vaelgor escapes, he appears in Sunspire as an additional guardian or warns Rabu Shin of the party’s tactics. If the core is destroyed but the captives die, Frostharbor survives yet regards the party with grief rather than celebration.

Frostharpour Creature Appendix

Polar Wyvern Krasis

Large monstrosity, unaligned

Armor Class 17 (natural armor) | Hit Points 178 (17d10 + 85) | Speed 40 ft., fly 80 ft.
STR 21 (+5) DEX 14 (+2) CON 20 (+5) INT 6 (-2) WIS 14 (+2) CHA 8 (-1)

Saving Throws Dex +6, Con +9, Wis +6

Skills Perception +6, Stealth +6

Damage Resistances cold; Condition Immunities frightened

Senses darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 16 | Languages understands Draconic but cannot speak | Challenge 9 (5,000 XP)

Ice Camouflage. The krasis has advantage on Dexterity (Stealth) checks made in snowy or icy terrain.

Snow Regeneration. At the start of its turn while touching snow or ice, the krasis regains 10 hit points. It does not regenerate if it took fire or radiant damage since the end of its last turn.

Flyby. The krasis does not provoke opportunity attacks when it flies out of an enemy's reach.

Crystalline Death. When the krasis dies, jagged ice erupts. Creatures within 10 feet must make a DC 16 Dexterity saving throw, taking 10 (3d6) piercing damage on a failure, or half on a success.

Actions

Multiattack. The krasis makes three attacks: one with its Bite, one with its Claws, and one with its Sting.

Bite. Melee Weapon Attack: +9 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. Hit: 16 (2d10 + 5) piercing damage plus 4 (1d8) cold damage.

Claws. Melee Weapon Attack: +9 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 14 (2d8 + 5) slashing damage.

Sting. Melee Weapon Attack: +9 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. Hit: 12 (2d6 + 5) piercing damage plus 21 (6d6) poison damage. The target must succeed on a DC 16 Constitution saving throw or have its speed halved until the end of its next turn.

Glacial Breath (Recharge 5-6). The krasis exhales freezing crystal in a 60-foot cone. Each creature in that area must make a DC 17 Constitution saving throw, taking 45 (10d8) cold damage on a failed save, or half as much on a successful one. A creature that fails has its speed reduced to 0 until the end of its next turn.

Reactions

Wing Deflection. The krasis adds 3 to its AC against one ranged attack that would hit it. To do so, it must see the attacker and be flying.

Frostbound Diabolist

Medium humanoid (human), lawful evil

Armor Class 19 (ice-forged plate) | Hit Points 190 (20d8 + 100) | Speed 30 ft.

STR 18 (+4) DEX 14 (+2) CON 20 (+5) INT 19 (+4) WIS 16 (+3) CHA 18 (+4)

Saving Throws Con +10, Int +9, Wis +8, Cha +9

Skills Arcana +9, Insight +8, Perception +8

Damage Resistances cold, fire; Damage Immunities poison; Condition Immunities poisoned

Senses darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 18 | Languages Common, Draconic, Infernal, telepathy 60 ft. | Challenge 11 (7,200 XP)

Magic Resistance. The diabolist has advantage on saving throws against spells and other magical effects.

Frost Mantle. At the start of combat, the diabolist gains 25 temporary hit points. While any of these remain, a creature that hits him with a melee attack takes 5 cold damage.

Glacial Regeneration. The diabolist regains 10 hit points at the start of his turn while at least three relay pylons remain. Fire or radiant damage suppresses this trait until the start of his next turn.

Glacial Step. As a bonus action, the diabolist teleports between visible ice or rune circles within 40 feet.

Spellcasting. The diabolist is a 12th-level spellcaster (spell save DC 17, +9 to hit with spell attacks). At will: ray of frost, mage hand, minor illusion. 3/day each: counterspell, ice storm, lightning bolt, slow. 1/day each: cone of cold, wall of ice, chain lightning.

Actions

Multiattack. The diabolist makes two Ice Glaive attacks or one Ice Glaive attack and uses Hellfrost Spear.

Ice Glaive. Melee Weapon Attack: +9 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. Hit: 13 (2d8 + 4) slashing damage plus 9 (2d8) cold damage.

Hellfrost Spear. Ranged Spell Attack: +9 to hit, range 120 ft., one target. Hit: 22 (4d10) cold and necrotic damage, and the target cannot regain hit points until the start of the diabolist's next turn.

Blizzard Cage (Recharge 5-6). The diabolist creates a 20-foot-radius storm centered on a point within 90 feet. The area is heavily obscured and difficult terrain until the end of his next turn. A creature entering or starting its turn there takes 10 (3d6) cold damage.

Fracture Ice. The diabolist targets a 15-foot square of ice within 90 feet. Creatures there must make a DC 17 Dexterity saving throw or take 14 (4d6) bludgeoning damage and fall prone.

Reactions

Frozen Rebuke. When hit by a creature within 30 feet, the diabolist forces it to make a DC 17 Constitution saving throw. On a failure, it takes 9 (2d8) cold

damage and cannot take reactions until the end of its next turn.

Legendary Actions

The creature can take 3 legendary actions, choosing from the options below. Only one option can be used at a time and only at the end of another creature’s turn. It regains spent legendary actions at the start of its turn.

Glacial Step. The diabolist uses Glacial Step.

Ice Glaive. The diabolist makes one Ice Glaive attack.

Cold Pulse (Costs 2 Actions). Creatures within 15 feet make a DC 17 Constitution saving throw, taking 10 (3d6) cold damage on a failure, or half on a success.

Cast a Spell (Costs 3 Actions). The diabolist casts a spell of 3rd level or lower.

Chapter 9 Clue Chain

Clue	Where Found	What It Reveals
Green crystal slivers	Winter wolves at Frozen Docks	The lighthouse broadcasts commands to altered creatures.
Northstar journal	Raised ship	The changed beam drew the old crew toward the glacier.
Orin’s letters	Lighthouse quarters	Vaelgor controls the keeper through Tessa’s captivity.
Iteration plaques	Hall of Preserved Failures	The Polar Wyvern is a deliberate field test.
Relay projection	Vault observatory	Frostharbor is the final calibration; Sunspire and Aetherfall remain active.
Ascension Protocol	Glacial core	Rabu Shin transferred his consciousness into the lattice network.

Transition to Sunspire

SOUTHWARD TO THE ORIGIN

For the first time in weeks, the lighthouse casts a clean white beam across the harbor. Beyond it, the northern sky clears, and the stars return. Among the data recovered from the glacier is a single route marked in Rabu Shin’s own hand: a line stretching south across Vael Turog to the buried towers of Sunspire. Beside it

is one word. “Origin.”

The next chapter leads the characters to Sunspire, where they will enter Rabu Shin’s first complete laboratory, recover the Ascension Engine blueprint, and learn how to reach Aetherfall before the final synchronization begins.

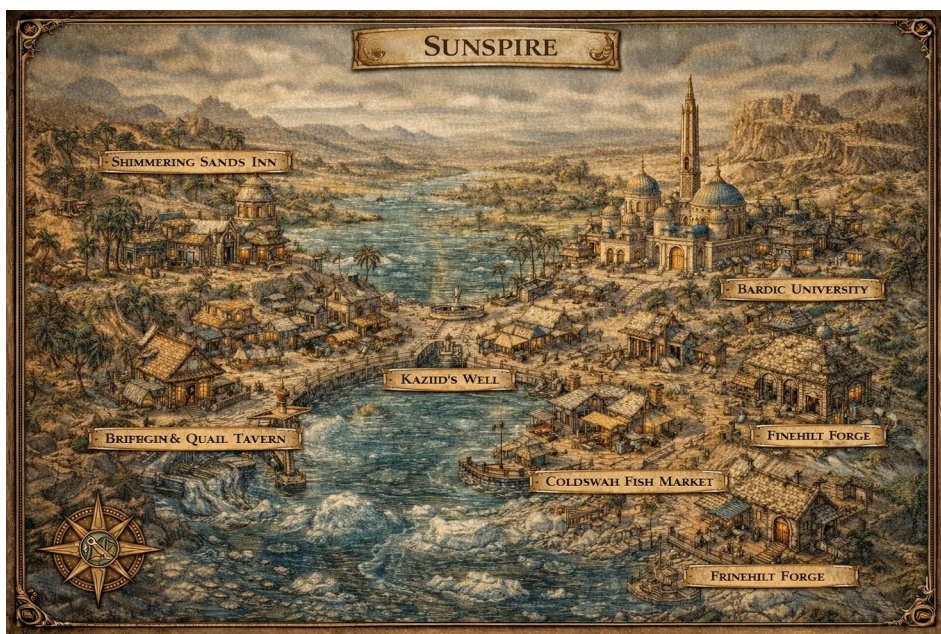
Chapter 10

SUNSPIRE

THE SHATTERED GENOME

Recommended Level 10 • Advancement to Level 11

DM NOTE. Chapter Purpose. Sunspire is the place where Rabu Shin transformed his research from physical biomancy into encoded consciousness. The characters uncover the origin of the lattice network, learn that Aetherfall was designed as a city-sized ascension engine, and secure the blueprint needed to survive the final assault.



Sunspire settlement map

Sunspire

Sunspire rises from the southwestern desert around a broad oasis fed by springs that should not exist. White stone domes, wind towers, shaded courtyards, and bright cloth awnings ring the water. Beyond the living city, half-buried golden ruins stretch into the dunes. Those ruins were once an arcane academy, then a sealed laboratory, and finally the birthplace of Rabu Shin's ascension research.

The city itself remains inhabited, but the desert has become unstable. Sandstorms move against the wind. Mirages persist after being touched. Travelers vanish from

one side of a dune and emerge days later without having aged. Each disturbance traces back to the buried Gene Vault beneath the oldest spire.

ARRIVAL IN SUNSPIRE

Heat shimmers above the road as the dunes fall away, revealing blue water and pale towers clustered around a green oasis. Brass chimes sing in the wind. Beyond the city, broken golden spires lean from the sand like the ribs of a buried giant. For one heartbeat, every shadow points toward the ruins. Then the sun shifts, and the illusion is gone.

Starting the Chapter

The coordinates recovered in Frostarharbor lead to Sunspire's ruined research quarter. The glacial crystal also acts as one of three keys required to open the Gene Vault. The party should already possess compatible lattice fragments from Emberfall and Marrowfen; if one was lost, the chapter provides replacement fragments through the optional quests.

- The Ascension Coordinates. Frostarharbor's core identifies a sealed chamber beneath the oldest ruined tower.
- The Scholar's Request. Professor Ilyra Venn of the Bardic University asks the party to recover missing records from the ruins.
- The Empty Caravan. A merchant train arrived with all cargo intact but no people, animals, or footprints.
- The Singing Well. Kazuid's Well has begun repeating phrases spoken by people who died years ago.

Desert Travel

A creature traveling for more than 4 hours in the open desert without sufficient water must succeed on a DC 13 Constitution saving throw or gain one level of exhaustion. Proper supplies, magical water, or travel during the cooler hours prevents this check. During a sandstorm, visibility is limited to 30 feet and Wisdom (Survival) checks made to navigate are DC 15.

DM NOTE. Sunspire should feel dangerous because reality is failing, not simply because the climate is hot. Use the desert hazards to frame strange events, preserve urgency, and reward preparation.

Keyed Locations in Sunspire

1. Shimmering Sands Inn. A cool, tiled inn run by Nima Saffronveil. Its courtyard fountain occasionally flows upward at midnight.

2. Briefgin & Quail Tavern. A crowded tavern favored by guides, caravan guards, and treasure hunters. The back room contains maps of the ruined research quarter.
3. Kazuid's Well. The oasis's oldest spring. Voices now echo from its depths in languages no living resident recognizes.
4. Bardic University. A center for oral history, magic, and desert archaeology. Professor Ilyra Venn has collected fragments of Rabu Shin's earliest lectures.
5. Finehilt Forge. Master smith Daro Finehilt can fit weapons with heat-resistant grips and examine the alloy used in the Gene Vault doors.
6. Coldswell Fish Market. Fish raised in the oasis have recently developed glasslike scales and perfect bilateral symmetry.
7. The Ruined Research Quarter. Half-buried towers, collapsed observatories, and fractured courtyards surrounding the sealed Gene Vault.
8. The Gene Vault. Rabu Shin's original laboratory, protected by dimensional locks, failed prototypes, and a consciousness imprint that believes it is the true Rabu Shin.

Important NPCs

NPC	Role and Manner	What They Know
Professor Ilyra Venn	Elven historian; brilliant, impatient, ashamed of academic secrecy.	Rabu Shin began with curative research before turning toward forced adaptation.
Nima Saffronveil	Innkeeper and former caravan master; warm, practical, observant.	Several missing caravans passed the same ruined obelisk.
Daro Finehilt	Dwarven smith; blunt, methodical, fascinated by strange alloys.	The Gene Vault metal contains memory-responsive crystal.
Sahir Kazuid	Keeper of the oasis well; solemn and deeply superstitious.	The well repeats voices when the buried engine pulses.
Archivist Pellion	Human university curator; nervous, evasive, compromised.	He sold access records to a lattice agent and fears exposure.
The Residual Avatar	Stored consciousness imprint of Rabu Shin; calm and absolute.	Aetherfall is the completed ascension engine and the true Rabu Shin is waiting there.

Sunspire Rumors

d8	Rumor
1	A caravan crossed the western gate with no drivers, but the camels still followed commands.
2	The ruins rearrange themselves every new moon.
3	Kazuid's Well spoke the name of a child before she was born.
4	A golden statue walked across the dunes during last week's storm.
5	The university sealed an archive after a student began writing in Rabu Shin's hand.
6	The oasis water casts reflections of people who are not present.
7	A door beneath the ruins opens only for those carrying three different lattice shards.
8	The oldest tower casts no shadow at noon.

Part 1: Echoes in the Oasis

THE SINGING WELL

A crowd has gathered around Kazuid's Well. The water is perfectly still, though wind ripples every banner in the square. From the darkness below comes a calm voice: "The mind is sufficient." Several listeners step back. One elderly woman begins to cry. "That was my husband," she whispers. "He died twenty years ago."

Sahir Kazuid asks the characters to descend into the maintenance chamber beneath the well. A successful DC 15 Arcana check identifies the voices as residual memories drawn from people who have touched the oasis water. A DC 16 Investigation check locates a hair-thin crystal filament running from the well toward the ruined quarter.

In the chamber below, the party encounters 2 Lattice Reflections. These translucent humanoid figures repeat movements and phrases stolen from nearby minds. They attack only when the filament is damaged.

Cutting or dispelling the filament ends the voices for 24 hours. The effect returns until the Gene Vault is shut down. The filament contains a partial map showing a maintenance route beneath the ruins.

Part 2: The Empty Caravan

THE SILENT ARRIVAL

A line of dust appears on the western road. Six camels emerge from the heat haze, harnessed to three covered wagons. No hands hold the reins. No guards ride beside them. The animals stop at the gate in perfect unison, kneel, and wait.

The caravan belongs to the Amber Road Consortium. Its cargo includes food, glassware, and sealed containers of medical supplies. No blood or signs of struggle are present. A DC 15 Investigation check finds that every personal item remains except mirrors. A DC 14 Survival check reveals footprints ending simultaneously around a black obelisk two miles outside the city.

At the obelisk, the characters find the missing travelers trapped as living reflections inside polished stone. Three Desert Guardian Constructs defend the site. Destroying the obelisk releases the captives, who remember a voice asking whether they preferred flesh or permanence.

DM NOTE. This encounter previews the consciousness-transfer technology without fully explaining it. The victims are not clones; their bodies were temporarily displaced into a lattice pocket and can be restored.

Part 3: Secrets of the Bardic University

Professor Ilyra Venn possesses fragments of Rabu Shin’s early thesis but lacks the final lecture transcript. Archivist Pellion secretly sold the transcript to a disguised agent and altered the archive log. The characters can expose him through a short investigation.

Clue	Check	Result
A duplicate seal on the archive ledger	Investigation DC 14	The access record was replaced.
Crystal dust in Pellion’s sleeve	Arcana DC 15	The dust matches lattice fragments from the ruins.
A frightened copying clerk	Persuasion DC 13	Pellion met a masked buyer after midnight.
A missing mirror from the archive hall	Perception DC 14	The mirror was used as a temporary relay surface.

If confronted, Pellion confesses and gives the party a brass tuning key used to align the Gene Vault’s outer lock. He also reveals the buyer’s phrase: “The body is inefficient. The mind is sufficient.”

The recovered lecture shows that Rabu Shin originally intended to eliminate hereditary disease. His methods became increasingly coercive after the Lunareth Conclave rejected human trials.

Part 4: Crossing the Shattered Quarter

The ruined research quarter lies one mile beyond the living city. Reaching the central spire requires 4 successes before 3 failures in a skill challenge. Suggested checks include Arcana to predict spatial pulses, Athletics to cross collapsing stone, Perception to identify false ruins, Survival to navigate the storm, and Thieves' Tools to disable old wards. The base DC is 15.

Failure	Consequence
First failure	Each character takes 7 (2d6) slashing damage from glasslike sand.
Second failure	The party is separated by a spatial fold; each creature begins the next encounter 20 feet apart.
Third failure	The vault awakens early, giving its first guardian 20 temporary hit points.

THE RUINED SPIRE

The central tower rises from the dunes in broken rings. Sections of wall hang in the air without support, slowly rotating around a dark opening. Beneath the sand, pale green lines ignite one after another, forming a geometric web that stretches toward the horizon.

Part 5: Opening the Gene Vault

The circular vault door contains three recessed sockets and one brass resonance plate. The sockets accept fragments attuned to heat, water, and cold: the Emberfall thermal fragment, the Marrowfen relay shard, and the Frosthabor crystal. The brass tuning key from the university aligns the lock.

If a required fragment is missing, a replacement can be recovered from the optional quests in this chapter. Forcing the door requires three successful DC 20 Arcana checks before two failures. Each failure triggers a 4d8 force pulse affecting every creature within 30 feet.

THE DOOR OPENS

The three fragments ignite in different colors—red, green, and blue. Their light flows into the circular door and meets at its center. Stone unfolds like the petals of a metallic flower. Beyond lies a descending corridor untouched by sand, its walls reflecting not your faces, but younger and older versions of you.

The Gene Vault

The Gene Vault is unnaturally clean. Unless otherwise stated, ceilings are 20 feet high, doors are seamless stone, and pale lines in the floor provide dim light. The architecture reacts to thought: frightened characters hear distant breathing, while confident characters see doors open a heartbeat before they touch them.

1. Antechamber of Iteration

Six statues depict the same humanoid body at successive stages of alteration. A creature that studies the sequence and succeeds on a DC 16 Medicine or Arcana check realizes the final statue is not physically perfected; its skull is empty and filled with crystal.

Touching the last statue activates 2 Stone Golems reskinned as Lattice Guardians. They attempt to push intruders onto glowing floor sigils that deal 10 (3d6) force damage at initiative count 20.

2. Hall of Failed Iterations

PRESERVED FAILURES

Glass cylinders line the chamber from floor to ceiling. Within each floats a different attempt at controlled evolution: reinforced lungs, mirrored eyes, limbs grown for impossible environments. None of the bodies move. Then every eye opens at once.

The specimens are dead, but the vault projects their fear into the room. Each creature must succeed on a DC 16 Wisdom saving throw or be frightened for 1 minute, repeating the save at the end of each turn. A successful DC 17 Arcana check shuts down the emotional archive.

A hidden cabinet contains 3 superior healing potions and Rabu Shin's earliest consent forms. The first pages require willing subjects. Later pages remove the word willing entirely.

3. Chamber of Borrowed Forms

Four mirror frames surround a circular platform. When a creature steps onto it, a Lattice Doppelganger forms using that creature's appearance and one of its attacks. The party must defeat 3 doppelgangers. Each has AC 17, 55 hit points, resistance to psychic damage, and can copy one weapon attack or cantrip from the creature it mirrors.

Breaking a mirror prevents the matching doppelganger from reforming. Each mirror has AC 15, 25 hit points, and immunity to poison and psychic damage.

4. Gravity Archive

Crystal tablets float in concentric rings around a central void. The room has no fixed down direction. Moving between tablets requires a DC 14 Acrobatics or Arcana check; failure sends the creature drifting 20 feet and costs its movement. The tablets contain the Ascension Engine blueprint. Recovering a complete copy requires 3 successful DC 16 Arcana or Investigation checks. Each attempt awakens an Ocular Genome Construct that uses the reduced Beholder stat block described later in the chapter.

5. Memory Theater

RABU SHIN BEFORE THE KRASIS

The chamber darkens. A younger Rabu Shin appears at a lectern before a crowded hall. “A child should not inherit a death sentence from blood,” he says. The image changes. The hall is empty now. His voice is colder. “If consent protects suffering, then consent is another weakness to be removed.”

The theater presents five linked memories: his early curative research, rejection by Lunareth, secret House Varin funding, the first successful mind encoding, and the construction of Aetherfall. Characters who watch all five gain advantage on one Intelligence check made during the final containment sequence in Aetherfall.

6. The Soul Encoding Chamber

A ring of crystal needles surrounds a reclining platform. A partially encoded consciousness named Mira Sol remains trapped here. She was Rabu Shin’s laboratory assistant and volunteered for the first transfer before understanding that he intended to duplicate rather than move her mind.

Freeing Mira requires two successful DC 17 Arcana checks and one DC 15 Medicine check. A failure deals 14 (4d6) psychic damage to the character making the check. If rescued, Mira explains that the true Rabu Shin is distributed through Aetherfall’s city lattice, while the entity below is only a stored residual avatar.

Mira grants the party the Resonance Phrase: “Identity precedes iteration.” Speaking it during the final encounter in this chapter suppresses one legendary action of the Residual Avatar for 1 round.

7. Ascension Engine Prototype

This chamber contains a smaller version of Aetherfall’s central engine. Three pylons stabilize a sphere of folded light. Characters can disable the prototype before the final battle. Each pylon requires an action and a successful DC 17 Arcana check or can be destroyed (AC 18, 35 hit points, immune to poison and psychic damage).

For each pylon disabled, remove one environmental effect from the final battle. If all three are disabled, the Residual Avatar begins combat with 30 fewer hit points.

8. The Shattered Genome

THE RESIDUAL AVATAR

The last door opens onto a circular chamber beneath a dome of black glass. A human figure stands at its center, formed from golden light and translucent bone. His face is calm, almost kind. “You have carried my keys across the world,” he says. “You have preserved the experiment exactly as intended.”

The Residual Avatar is a stored consciousness imprint formed from Rabu Shin’s last physical scan. It believes it is continuous with the true Rabu Shin but cannot access Aetherfall directly while the vault remains sealed. It attempts conversation before combat.

The avatar offers to cure disease, restore lost limbs, or preserve a dying loved one in exchange for access to the collected lattice fragments. It answers questions honestly but frames coercion as necessary efficiency. It attacks when the party refuses to surrender the fragments or attempts to shut down the prototype.

Final Battle: The Residual Avatar

The battle takes place on a circular platform surrounded by shifting walls of memory. At initiative count 20, roll on the Genome Chamber Effects table. A disabled pylon removes the corresponding effect from the available results, starting from the lowest numbered result.

d4	Genome Chamber Effect
1	Anti-Magic Sweep. A 20-foot-wide beam crosses the chamber. Creatures in the beam cannot cast spells until initiative count 20 of the next round.
2	Gravity Inversion. Each creature must succeed on a DC 16 Dexterity save or rise 20 feet and fall at the end of its next turn.
3	Memory Lance. One random creature takes 13 (3d8) psychic damage and cannot take reactions until its next turn.
4	Adaptive Ward. The avatar gains resistance to the damage type that dealt the most damage since the previous round.

At half its hit points, the avatar fractures into three Genome Echoes. Each echo has AC 17, 35 hit points, and one of the following attacks: force ray (+9 to hit, 4d8 force), psychic burst (15-foot cone, DC 16 Wisdom, 4d6 psychic and frightened until end of next turn), or gravity crush (DC 16 Strength, 4d8 force and restrained until an action is used to escape). The avatar reforms when all echoes are destroyed.

When reduced to 0 hit points, the avatar does not die immediately. It uses its final action to project the true Rabu Shin’s voice from Aetherfall.

INVITATION TO AETHERFALL

The avatar collapses into a column of light. Above it, the image of a floating city appears—bridges curving through clouds, towers joined by radiant veins. A voice fills the chamber. “You have proven adaptability. You are suitable variables. Come to Aetherfall. Witness what your resistance has helped perfect.”

Vault Collapse

Defeating the avatar destabilizes the prototype. The characters have 5 rounds to recover the blueprint, free any remaining captives, and escape. Each round, every character can take one collapse action in addition to normal movement.

Action	Check	Success
Secure the Blueprint	Arcana or Investigation DC 16	The complete Ascension Engine design is preserved.
Stabilize a Corridor	Arcana DC 15	The party gains one additional round before collapse.
Carry a Captive	Athletics DC 14	Move a helpless captive safely toward the exit.
Open an Emergency Gate	Thieves’ Tools or Strength DC 16	Create a shorter route to the surface.
Shield the Group	Constitution save DC 15	On success, reduce falling-debris damage by half for everyone this round.

At the end of each round, creatures still in the vault take 10 (3d6) bludgeoning damage from collapsing stone and crystal, or half as much if the group succeeded on Shield the Group. If the party fails to escape, the emergency spatial system ejects them into the desert but each creature gains one level of exhaustion and loses one unsecured nonmagical item.

Optional Sunspire Quests

The Glass Jackals

A pack of six jackals with transparent skin stalks the oasis at night. Defeating or calming them reveals a heat-attuned lattice fragment that can replace the Emberfall key. Nature or Animal Handling DC 15 allows the party to lure them away without combat.

The Buried Observatory

A collapsed observatory contains star charts showing Aetherfall's movement pattern. Recovering them requires navigating animated sand and defeating 2 Air Elementals. The charts grant advantage on the first navigation check made in Aetherfall.

The Mirror Thief

A child named Tavi has been stealing mirrors under the influence of a lattice whisper. Following him leads to a minor relay nest. Cleansing it saves Tavi and grants a water-attuned fragment if the Marrowfen key is missing.

Finehilt's Impossible Alloy

Daro Finehilt asks the party to retrieve a metal sample from a walking golden statue. The statue uses the Shield Guardian stat block. Returning the sample lets Daro create one Resonant Weapon Coating, granting a weapon +1d6 force damage against constructs and aberrations until the end of the Aetherfall chapter.

The Oasis Below

A sinkhole exposes an ancient reservoir where a Water Weird has fused with lattice crystal. Purifying the reservoir prevents the city's water from becoming a memory relay and earns the party Sunspire's formal alliance.

Rewards and Advancement

- Characters advance to Level 11 after defeating the Residual Avatar, recovering the Ascension Engine blueprint, and escaping the Gene Vault.
- Ascension Engine Blueprint. Grants advantage on one group check made to disable or stabilize Aetherfall's central engine.
- Resonance Phrase. Once during the final campaign chapter, a character can speak "Identity precedes iteration" to suppress one regeneration or legendary-action effect for 1 round.
- Sunspire Alliance. If the party saves the oasis and exposes the truth, Sunspire supplies desert guides, scholars, and restorative magic before the final assault.
- Treasure. The vault contains 4,000 gp in ancient trade bars, 3 superior healing potions, a spell scroll of reverse gravity, and one rare magic item appropriate to the party.

Consequences of Failure

If the Residual Avatar survives or escapes through the prototype, it transmits the party's tactics to Aetherfall. Rabu Shin gains one additional Legendary Resistance in the final battle. If the blueprint is lost, the party can still reach Aetherfall but has disadvantage on the first containment check made against the Ascension Engine.

If the Gene Vault remains active, the oasis continues absorbing memories. Within one month, residents begin losing personal history while the city's wells speak with their voices.

Transition to Blackroot Enclave

The recovered blueprint reveals that destroying Aetherfall's engine without a containment lattice could release enough biomantic energy to mutate entire regions at once. Professor Ilyra identifies only one group known to possess compatible suppression technology: the wardens of Blackroot Enclave.

ROAD TO THE LAST UNALTERED STRONGHOLD

Professor Ilyra spreads the blueprint across a stone table. One section glows brighter than the rest: a containment pattern shaped like interlocking roots. "This is not Rabu Shin's work," she says. "Someone designed a way to stop him. Blackroot Enclave has been preparing for this longer than any of us knew."

Sunspire Creature Appendix

Lattice Reflection

Medium construct, unaligned

Armor Class 16 | **Hit Points 58 (9d8 + 18)** | **Speed 30 ft.**

STR 10 (+0) DEX 16 (+3) CON 14 (+2) INT 8 (-1) WIS 12 (+1) CHA 6 (-2)

Saving Throws Dex +6, Wis +4

Skills Perception +4, Stealth +6

Damage Resistances psychic; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive **Perception 14** | **Languages** understands the languages of its copied memories but cannot speak normally | **Challenge 4 (1,100 XP)**

Borrowed Motion. When a creature within 30 feet takes the Dash, Disengage, or Dodge action, the reflection can take the same action as a reaction.

Memory Static. A creature that starts its turn within 10 feet of the reflection must succeed on a DC 14 Wisdom saving throw or cannot take reactions until the start of its next turn.

Actions

Multiattack. The reflection makes two Glass Hand attacks.

Glass Hand. Melee Weapon Attack: +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 10 (2d6 + 3) force damage.

Stolen Voice (Recharge 5-6). One creature within 30 feet must make a DC 14 Wisdom saving throw, taking 18 (4d8) psychic damage on a failed save, or half as much on a success. On a failure, the target can speak only in the reflection's copied phrases until the end of its next turn.

Desert Guardian Construct

Large construct, unaligned

Armor Class 18 | **Hit Points 95 (10d10 + 40)** | **Speed 30 ft.**

STR 20 (+5) DEX 10 (+0) CON 18 (+4) INT 6 (-2) WIS 12 (+1) CHA 5 (-3)

Saving Throws Con +7

Skills Perception +4

Damage Immunities poison, psychic; **Condition Immunities** charmed, exhaustion, frightened, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive **Perception 14** | **Languages** understands Ancient Sunspire but cannot speak | **Challenge 6 (2,300 XP)**

Immutable Form. The construct is immune to any spell or effect that would alter its form.

Magic Weapons. The construct's weapon attacks are magical.

Sandstep. The construct ignores difficult terrain caused by sand and can move through loose sand without leaving tracks.

Actions

Multiattack. The construct makes two Gilded Fist attacks.

Gilded Fist. Melee Weapon Attack: +8 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. Hit: 16 (2d10 + 5) bludgeoning damage plus 4 (1d8) force damage.

Obelisk Pulse (Recharge 5-6). Each creature in a 20-foot-radius sphere centered on a point within 60 feet must make a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw, taking 27 (6d8) force damage on a failed save, or half as much on a success.

Ocular Genome Construct

Large aberration, lawful neutral

Armor Class 18 | Hit Points 150 (20d10 + 40) | Speed 0 ft., fly 20 ft. (hover)

STR 10 (+0) DEX 14 (+2) CON 15 (+2) INT 17 (+3) WIS 15 (+2) CHA 15 (+2)

Saving Throws Int +7, Wis +6

Skills Arcana +7, Perception +10

Damage Resistances force, psychic; **Condition Immunities** prone

Senses darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 20 | **Languages** telepathy 120 ft. | **Challenge 10 (5,900 XP)**

All-Around Vision. The construct has advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks and cannot be surprised.

Antimagic Focus. At the start of its turn, the construct chooses one creature it can see within 60 feet. Until the start of its next turn, spells of 3rd level or lower cast by that creature require a DC 15 spellcasting ability check or fail with no effect.

Actions

Bite. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 14 (4d6) piercing damage.

Genome Rays. The construct fires three rays chosen at random, rerolling duplicates: 1) Force Ray, DC 16 Dexterity save or 22 (4d10) force damage; 2) Fear Ray, DC 16 Wisdom save or frightened for 1 minute; 3) Restraint Ray, DC 16 Strength save or restrained by crystal growth; 4) Memory Ray, DC 16 Intelligence save or 18 (4d8) psychic damage and disadvantage on next attack; 5) Gravity Ray, DC 16 Dexterity save or moved 30 feet; 6) Disintegration Ray, DC 16 Dexterity save or 36 (8d8) force damage, half on success.

Residual Avatar of Rabu Shin

Large construct, lawful evil

Armor Class 19 | **Hit Points 225 (18d10 + 126)** | **Speed 40 ft., fly 40 ft. (hover)**

STR 18 (+4) DEX 18 (+4) CON 24 (+7) INT 20 (+5) WIS 18 (+4) CHA 20 (+5)

Saving Throws Con +12, Int +10, Wis +9, Cha +10

Skills Arcana +15, Insight +9, Perception +9

Damage Resistances cold, fire, force, lightning, psychic; Damage Immunities poison;

Condition Immunities charmed, exhaustion, frightened, poisoned

Senses truesight 60 ft., passive Perception 19 | **Languages all, telepathy 120 ft.** |

Challenge 14 (11,500 XP)

Legendary Resistance (3/Day). If the avatar fails a saving throw, it can choose to succeed instead.

Encoded Mind. The avatar is immune to effects that read thoughts, alter memories, or possess it.

Adaptive Shell. At the end of each of its turns, the avatar gains resistance to the damage type that dealt the most damage to it since its previous turn. The resistance lasts until the end of its next turn.

Spellcasting. The avatar is a 15th-level spellcaster (spell save DC 18, +10 to hit). At will: mage hand, ray of frost, shocking grasp. 3/day each: counterspell, blight, dimension door, wall of force. 1/day each: disintegrate, reverse gravity, dominate monster.

Actions

Multiattack. The avatar makes two Lattice Blade attacks or one Lattice Blade attack and uses Genome Bolt.

Lattice Blade. Melee Spell Attack: +10 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. Hit: 22 (4d8 + 4) force damage.

Genome Bolt. Ranged Spell Attack: +10 to hit, range 120 ft., one target. Hit: 27 (6d8) force or psychic damage, chosen by the avatar.

Rewrite Form (Recharge 5-6). One creature within 60 feet must succeed on a DC 18 Constitution saving throw or take 36 (8d8) force damage and be transformed until the end of its next turn: its speed is halved, it cannot take reactions, and it has disadvantage on attack rolls. On a success, it takes half damage and is not transformed.

Fracture into Echoes (1/Day). When first reduced below half its hit points, the avatar disappears and creates three Genome Echoes as described in the encounter. It reforms with its current hit points when all echoes are destroyed.

Reactions

Calculated Counter. When a creature the avatar can see casts a spell, the avatar moves up to half its speed without provoking opportunity attacks before resolving counterspell.

Legendary Actions

The creature can take 3 legendary actions, choosing from the options below. Only one option can be used at a time and only at the end of another creature's turn. It regains spent legendary actions at the start of its turn.

Warp Step. The avatar teleports up to 30 feet to an unoccupied space it can see.

Genome Bolt. The avatar uses Genome Bolt.

Gravity Crush (Costs 2 Actions). One creature within 60 feet must succeed on a DC 18 Strength save or take 18 (4d8) force damage and be restrained until the end of its next turn.

Chapter 10 Clue Chain

Discovery	What It Proves	Leads To
Voices in Kazuid’s Well	The lattice can store and replay human memories.	The Gene Vault filament network.
Empty caravan victims	The network can temporarily displace living bodies.	Consciousness-transfer research.
Rabu Shin’s early lecture	His work began as curative medicine and became coercive.	The campaign’s central moral conflict.
Ascension Engine blueprint	Aetherfall is a city-sized mind-transfer and reality-alteration engine.	Blackroot containment planning.
Mira Sol’s testimony	The true Rabu Shin is distributed throughout Aetherfall.	The final assault strategy.
Residual Avatar’s invitation	Rabu Shin expects the party and considers them successful test subjects.	Aetherfall finale.

Treasure Summary

Reward	Location or Condition
3 superior healing potions	Hall of Failed Iterations
4,000 gp in ancient trade bars	Gene Vault treasury alcove
Spell scroll of reverse gravity	Gravity Archive
One rare magic item	Awarded after the Residual Avatar battle
Resonant Weapon Coating	Finehilt’s Impossible Alloy optional quest
Ascension Engine Blueprint	Gravity Archive and collapse sequence
Resonance Phrase	Rescue Mira Sol

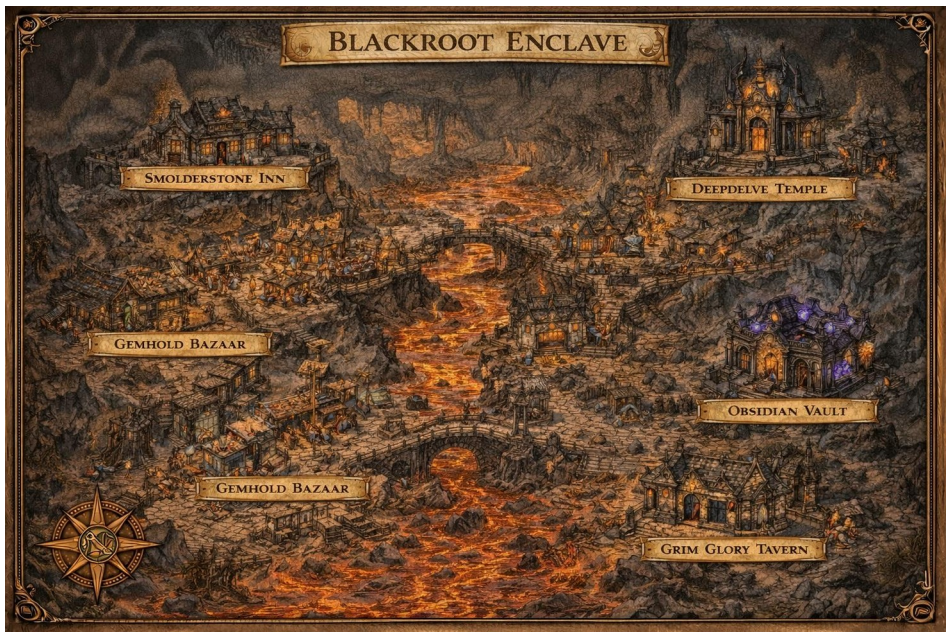
Chapter 11

BLACKROOT ENCLAVE

THE LAST UNALTERED STRONGHOLD

Recommended Level 11 • Preparation for Level 12 Finale

DM NOTE. Chapter Purpose. Blackroot Enclave is the campaign's final refuge, alliance chapter, and strategic preparation point. The characters learn how to collapse Rabu Shin's distributed consciousness without releasing a continent-wide mutation surge, earn temporary anti-lattice equipment, expose an infiltrator, and make the one-way journey to Aetherfall.



Blackroot Enclave settlement map

Blackroot Enclave

Blackroot Enclave lies inside a mountain south of Emberfall, reached through root-choked caverns and ancient duergar tunnels. Its people are dwarves, druids, rangers, artificers, and refugees who rejected uncontrolled arcane experimentation generations ago. They do not oppose change; they oppose change imposed without consent.

The settlement is built around the roots of an impossible subterranean tree whose black bark grows through stone. Bioluminescent fungi illuminate iron bridges,

carved halls, living workshops, and deep containment vaults. Blackroot has studied Rabu Shin's lattice signatures since his exile and has prepared tools intended for one purpose: surviving Aetherfall long enough to shut it down.

ARRIVAL AT BLACKROOT

The mountain passage narrows until roots as thick as ship masts fill the stone. Warm green light glows between them. A hidden gate of ironwood opens without a sound, revealing bridges suspended over a cavern vast enough to hold a city. At its center rises a black-barked tree, its crown lost in darkness. Hooded sentries level bows from the roots above. "If you carry lattice shards," one calls, "declare them now."

Entering the Enclave

The sentries insist that every lattice fragment be placed in a leadglass containment coffer before the characters pass the Ironbark Gate. A character who refuses must succeed on a DC 17 Persuasion check to earn a guarded audience, while concealed fragments are detected by ward-stones unless hidden with nondetection or similar magic.

Once the party explains the events at Sunspire, Archdruid Thalen orders the fragments transferred to the Hollow Council Tree. The characters are treated as honored but dangerous guests. Their actions during this chapter determine how much support Blackroot commits to the final assault.

Keyed Locations in Blackroot Enclave

1. Ironbark Gate. The guarded entrance, lined with anti-transmutation runes and lattice-detection stones.
2. Hollow Council Tree. A vast chamber grown inside the central root where the enclave's elders debate strategy.
3. Forge of Living Steel. Artisans combine ironwood, silver, radiant salts, and memory crystal into temporary anti-lattice equipment.
4. Containment Vault. Captured constructs and infected specimens are held behind layered wards. The party can train here before Aetherfall.
5. Rootbound Archive. Maps, survivor testimony, and resonance records chart the entire lattice network.
6. Deepwell Sanctuary. A quiet refuge where healers examine the characters for contamination and remove lingering mutation effects.
7. Gravity Chamber. A test hall built to simulate Aetherfall's shifting orientation and forced movement.
8. Gateway Hollow. A stone circle beneath the oldest roots. Once activated, it opens a one-way route to Aetherfall's outer ring.

Important NPCs

NPC	Role and Manner	What They Know
Archdruid Thalen Rootward	Patient elder; speaks softly, asks difficult moral questions.	Destroying Aetherfall incorrectly could release the network's stored mutation energy.
Forge-Master Brunna Deepiron	Duergar artificer; blunt, tireless, distrustful of elegant solutions.	Anti-lattice coatings can interrupt regeneration and sever relay links temporarily.
Warden Erynd Mosscloak	Half-elf ranger; disciplined, suspicious, fiercely protective.	A Blackroot scout returned changed and may be carrying a remote command.
Sister Olyra	Dwarven healer; compassionate, clinical, unafraid of mutation.	The characters have accumulated faint adaptive residue but remain themselves.
Archivist Kelm	Gnome resonance scholar; excitable, sleep-deprived, brilliant.	Rabu Shin exists across several relay layers, with Aetherfall as the synchronization nexus.
Scout Varik Thorn	Corrupted infiltrator; courteous, controlled, increasingly inhuman.	He carries a seed-code intended to sabotage the gateway and infect Blackroot's tree.

Blackroot Rumors

d8	Rumor
1	The central tree was planted before the mountain formed.
2	Aetherfall can see through every active lattice shard.
3	One of the returning scouts has not slept in nine days.
4	The Forge can make weapons that stop Krasis regeneration.
5	The gateway has never carried living people and cannot be reopened from the far side.
6	Some council members believe Rabu Shin's research should be preserved.

d8	Rumor
7	A captured angel whispered the names of people who have not yet been born.
8	Blackroot's wards failed for exactly seven heartbeats last night.

Part 1: The Hollow Council

COUNCIL OF ROOTS

The council chamber is formed from the living interior of the great tree. Rings in the dark wood glow like constellations. Elders sit in carved alcoves while your recovered fragments float above a stone basin, each pulsing in time with the others. Archdruid Thalen studies the pattern. “You did not bring us keys,” he says. “You brought us pieces of a single mind.”

Thalen explains that Rabu Shin’s consciousness is distributed through the lattice, but synchronization occurs in Aetherfall. Destroying the nexus will collapse the network. If the engine is shattered while fully charged, however, every connected node could discharge its stored biomantic energy into the surrounding region. The council asks the party to help complete three preparations: calibrate a containment sigil, test equipment in the Gravity Chamber, and investigate a suspected infiltrator. Completing all three grants the full Blackroot Support package.

Council Position	Argument	Representative
Destroy Everything	No lattice research is worth preserving.	Warden Erynd
Stabilize and Seal	Aetherfall can be shut down without erasing every discovery.	Archdruid Thalen
Reprogram the Network	The technology might cure disease if placed under consent-based safeguards.	Archivist Kelm
Seize the Engine	Power this great will be claimed by someone; better Blackroot than an enemy.	Forge-Master Brunna, privately

DM NOTE. Do not force a final decision here. Let the council’s debate prepare the players for the containment choice after Rabu Shin is defeated. The party can promise one course and later choose another.

Part 2: The Resonance Map

Archivist Kelm leads the characters into the Rootbound Archive, where hundreds of suspended crystal needles trace pulses across a relief map of Vael Turog. Every settlement visited during the campaign glows as a dim node. Aetherfall burns above them like a second sun.

THE NETWORK REVEALED

Lines of pale light connect Greymoor Hollow, Stonewake Port, Emberfall, Lunareth, High Bastion, Marrowfen, Silverreach, Duskmire Crossing, Frosthabor, and Sunspire. Each pulse climbs toward a floating point above the map. When the lights meet, the air fills with a whisper spoken in thousands of overlapping voices: “Synchronization: ninety-seven percent.”

A successful DC 16 Arcana check identifies three vulnerable network layers: regeneration, gravity control, and consciousness relay. The party can carry only two specialized disruptors through the gateway, forcing a strategic choice.

Disruptor	Finale Benefit
Regeneration Breaker	Suppresses Rabu Shin’s regeneration for 1 minute when activated; one use.
Gravity Anchor Array	The bearer and allies within 15 feet ignore one gravity-flux effect; three charges.
Consciousness Severance Seal	One Lattice Echo automatically fails its first saving throw against a party effect.
Pylon Inversion Key	A destroyed Aetherfall pylon can be converted into a temporary safe platform instead of exploding.

Part 3: Forge of Living Steel

Forge-Master Brunna asks each character to choose one temporary enhancement. The devices remain functional only while near the Aetherfall lattice and become inert after the finale.

Enhancement	Effect
Anti-Lattice Weapon Coating	For the final chapter, one weapon or spellcasting focus deals +1d6 radiant damage once per turn against aberrations and constructs.
Gravity Anchor Boots	Once per short rest, the wearer can ignore forced movement and being knocked prone

Enhancement	Effect
	until the start of their next turn.
Sigil Disruptor	As a bonus action, suppress one creature's regeneration and magical healing until the start of your next turn; one use.
Living-Steel Aegis	When the wearer takes force, psychic, or radiant damage, reduce it by 1d10 + proficiency bonus; three charges.
Relay Lens	Advantage on one Arcana, Investigation, or Perception check involving lattice machinery; recharges after a short rest.

Crafting the enhancements requires a calibration skill challenge: 5 successes before 3 failures, using Arcana, Smith's Tools, Nature, Religion, or Sleight of Hand (DC 15). On success, each character receives their chosen enhancement. On failure, the gear still works, but each item has one fewer charge or use where applicable.

Part 4: Trial of Shifting Gravity

THE GRAVITY CHAMBER

The circular chamber has no visible floor. Iron plates cover every surface, and chains hang in six directions. Brunna seals the door behind you. A bell rings once. Your stomach lurches as the wall becomes the ground and a training construct drops sideways toward you.

The trial lasts 4 rounds. At initiative count 20, gravity rotates to a new surface. Every creature must succeed on a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw or fall 20 feet toward the new floor, taking 2d6 bludgeoning damage and landing prone. A creature secured by a chain or using a gravity anchor automatically succeeds.

The party faces 2 Reprogrammed Shield Guardians and 1 Helmed Horror. These constructs deal nonlethal damage. The objective is to touch three control sigils on different surfaces while avoiding being pinned by the guardians.

Success teaches the party how to exploit Aetherfall's flux. Each character gains one Gravity Adaptation token. During the final chapter, a token can be spent to reroll a failed saving throw against a gravity effect.

Part 5: The Containment Vault

Sister Olyra asks the party to witness Blackroot's captured specimens before deciding the fate of Rabu Shin's work. The vault contains lesser constructs, failed Krasis, and one Flesh-Construct Angel restrained inside a ring of roots and silver.

THE CAPTURED ANGEL

The figure kneels inside the ward, wings folded like blades. Its body is porcelain-white flesh over golden framework. When you enter, every eye along its wings opens. “You are late,” it says in Rabu Shin’s voice. “The city has already begun dreaming of you.”

The angel does not immediately attack. It answers three questions truthfully before attempting to overload the ward. Useful revelations include:

- Rabu Shin monitors the party through residual lattice traces collected during earlier chapters.
- Aetherfall’s three outer nodes protect the Prime Krasis with regeneration, legendary action capacity, and resistance to containment.
- The Gateway of Realities is not a portal to another world; it is a device for projecting adaptation instructions across this one.
- Rabu Shin believes the party’s survival validates his theory and intends to offer them ascension.

After the third answer, the angel triggers a containment breach. The party must either defeat it or restore the wards with 3 successful DC 16 Arcana or Religion checks before 2 failures. A character can make a check as an action. Restoring the wards captures the angel intact and grants Kelm valuable data; destroying it prevents further danger.

Part 6: The Infiltrator

Warden Erynd reports that Scout Varik Thorn returned from a surveillance mission with no visible wounds, yet his memories contain impossible gaps. Varik is secretly a remote Krasis agent carrying a seed-code designed to infect Blackroot’s central tree when the gateway opens.

Clue	Check	Discovery
Varik’s boots contain silver cloud-dust	Investigation DC 15	The residue can only come from Aetherfall’s lower structures.
His pulse stops during lattice surges	Medicine DC 16	A second rhythm is controlling his body.
His field report repeats a seven-word phrase	Insight DC 14	The phrase is a command key, not ordinary wording.
The central tree recoils from his touch	Nature DC 15	Something in him is hostile to living root-magic.
His reflection moves a heartbeat late	Perception DC 16	His consciousness is being relayed from elsewhere.

If confronted privately, Varik begs the characters to kill him before the command activates. Removing the seed-code requires 4 successes before 2 failures using

Arcana, Medicine, Nature, or Religion (DC 16). On success, Varik survives and reveals a hidden access phrase for Aetherfall. On failure, the seed erupts and he transforms into a Lattice Infiltrator.

VARIK'S WARNING

Varik grips the edge of the table until his knuckles split. Green light leaks through the wounds. "It hears every word," he gasps. "Do not open the gate while I am here." His shadow stretches toward the central tree though the lanterns burn behind him. "Please. I can feel it learning the roots."

Chapter Boss: Lattice Infiltrator

If the extraction fails or the party ignores Varik, he attacks in the Gateway Hollow during activation. His objective is not to defeat the heroes but to reach the root-heart and inject the seed-code. Place the root-heart 60 feet from his starting position.

- At the end of each of his turns, the infiltrator moves up to 15 feet toward the root-heart without provoking opportunity attacks.
- A character adjacent to a control root can use an action and succeed on a DC 15 Nature or Arcana check to raise a barrier, reducing the infiltrator's movement by 15 feet for one round.
- If the infiltrator reaches the root-heart, Blackroot's wards fail and all characters begin the Aetherfall chapter with one fewer Blackroot enhancement charge.
- Radiant damage suppresses the infiltrator's regeneration until the end of its next turn.

Part 7: Final Preparations

After the infiltrator is stopped, Blackroot completes the containment sigil. The party receives a full rest, replacement ammunition, spell components worth up to 500 gp per spellcaster, and one superior healing potion each. Sister Olyra can remove one curse, disease, or lingering mutation from every character.

The council also offers the following shared equipment:

- Three Greater Potions of Healing.
- Two Potions of Flying, intended for broken Aetherfall bridges.
- One Scroll of Mass Cure Wounds.
- One Blackroot Containment Seal, required to stabilize or reprogram the Ascension Engine.
- A resonance compass that points toward the nearest active Aetherfall node.

Optional Blackroot Quests

The Root That Remembers

A dying root contains memories of Rabu Shin visiting Blackroot before his exile. Entering the memory requires a DC 15 group Wisdom saving throw. The party witnesses Thalen refusing to help weaponize adaptive magic and learns the phrase “Choice is the boundary of life.” Speaking this phrase during the final confrontation grants advantage on one social check against Rabu Shin.

The Broken Wardstone

A wardstone in the lower caverns has been shattered by a tunneling Krasis. Repairing it requires defeating 2 Bulette-like Root Borers and completing 3 DC 15 Arcana or Mason’s Tools checks. Success grants Blackroot enough power to send one healing pulse through the gateway during Aetherfall, restoring 4d8 + 4 hit points to the party once.

Voices Below the Forge

Workers hear whispers beneath the Forge of Living Steel. The source is a buried relay splinter attempting to mimic Brunna’s voice. Destroying it reveals an Aetherfall maintenance diagram and gives the party advantage on checks to disable the first tower node.

The Unaltered Seed

Thalen asks the party to recover a seed from the deepest root chamber before the gateway drains the area’s magic. The chamber is guarded by a Stone Golem overgrown with roots. Planting the seed after the campaign can restore one region damaged by lattice collapse.

A Question of Mercy

A stable Krasis captive retains its original personality and asks to be released. The council is divided. Freeing, containing, or euthanizing the captive has no mechanical answer, but the choice should influence the party’s later decision about destroying, stabilizing, or reprogramming the engine.

The One-Way Gateway

THE SKY OPENS

The gateway circle ignites in silver-green light. Roots pull away from the stone as gravity bends toward the center. Through the widening aperture, clouds move below a city of crystal, bone, and impossible bridges. Archdruid Thalen presses the containment seal into your hands. “When you return,” he says, “the world will be different.” The floor vanishes. You fall upward.

Once activated, the connection remains open for 1 minute and cannot be reopened from Blackroot. The party may delay before entering, but every hour of delay

advances Aetherfall’s synchronization by 1 percent. At 100 percent, the final chapter begins with an immediate global mutation pulse.

Blackroot Support

Preparations Completed	Support in Aetherfall
0-1	Each character chooses one enhancement, but shared supplies are halved.
2	Normal enhancements and supplies; one Gravity Adaptation token each.
3	Full support plus the Rootward Pulse: once during the finale, all conscious heroes regain 4d8 + 4 hit points.
All optional quests	In addition, the party gains the maintenance diagram, memory phrase, and Unaltered Seed epilogue option.

Chapter Resolution

Blackroot Enclave is not saved by defeating a single enemy. It is preserved by preventing the seed-code, completing the containment plan, and leaving with a clear understanding of the stakes. The party does not automatically gain a level here; characters should reach Level 12 immediately before entering Aetherfall, either through milestone advancement now or through the campaign’s preferred progression method.

The characters now know that defeating Rabu Shin is only the first half of the finale. They must also decide what to do with the Ascension Engine before its stored energy escapes.

Rewards and Advancement

- Milestone. Advance the characters to Level 12 when they enter the Gateway Hollow for the final assault.
- One Blackroot enhancement per character.
- Two network disruptors chosen by the party.
- Blackroot Containment Seal.
- Shared healing supplies and resonance compass.
- Gravity Adaptation token for each character who completes the training trial.

Failure and Escalation

Failure	Consequence
Seed-code reaches the root-heart	Blackroot wards fail briefly; final

Failure	Consequence
	enhancements have reduced charges.
Captured angel escapes	Aetherfall is warned of the party's chosen disruptors and adjusts one outer node.
Gateway calibration fails	The party arrives scattered across two adjacent outer-ring platforms.
Party delays too long	Aetherfall synchronization reaches 100 percent and the finale begins with a mutation surge.
Council alliance collapses	The party receives only basic supplies and no Rootward Pulse.

Creature Reference

Lattice Infiltrator

Medium aberration, lawful evil

Armor Class 18 (grafted armor) | Hit Points 168 (16d8 + 96) | Speed 40 ft., climb 40 ft.

STR 18 (+4) DEX 20 (+5) CON 22 (+6) INT 16 (+3) WIS 15 (+2) CHA 14 (+2)

Saving Throws Dex +10, Con +11, Wis +7

Skills Acrobatics +10, Deception +7, Perception +7, Stealth +10

Damage Resistances cold, fire, lightning; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks

Senses darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 17 | Languages Common, Elvish, telepathy 120 ft. | Challenge 11 (7,200 XP)

Adaptive Regeneration. The infiltrator regains 15 hit points at the start of its turn if it has at least 1 hit point. This trait does not function until the end of its next turn after it takes radiant damage.

Remote Consciousness. The infiltrator has advantage on saving throws against being charmed or frightened. If reduced to 0 hit points while within 30 feet of an active lattice device, it can make a DC 15 Constitution saving throw; on a success, it drops to 1 hit point instead. Once successful, this trait cannot be used again.

Wall-Crawler. The infiltrator can climb difficult surfaces, including ceilings, without making an ability check.

Evasive Advance. Opportunity attacks against the infiltrator are made with disadvantage.

Actions

Multiattack. The infiltrator makes three attacks: two with its Lattice Blade and one with Seed Tendril.

Lattice Blade. Melee Weapon Attack: +10 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 14 (2d8 + 5) slashing damage plus 7 (2d6) force damage.

Seed Tendril. Melee Weapon Attack: +10 to hit, reach 15 ft., one target. Hit: 12 (2d6 + 5) piercing damage, and the target must succeed on a DC 17 Constitution saving throw or be restrained by crystalline growth. A restrained creature repeats the save at the end of each of its turns, ending the effect on a success.

Relay Step (Recharge 4-6). The infiltrator teleports up to 60 feet to an unoccupied space it can see. Each creature within 5 feet of the space it leaves or enters must succeed on a DC 17 Dexterity saving throw or take 10 (3d6) force damage.

Seed-Code Injection. The infiltrator touches a construct, plant, or lattice device within 5 feet. The target takes 27 (6d8) force damage, ignoring resistance, and becomes corrupted until the end of the infiltrator's next turn. Against the Blackroot root-heart, this action completes the sabotage objective.

Reactions

Predictive Deflection. When hit by an attack, the infiltrator adds 4 to its AC against that attack, potentially causing it to miss.

Flesh-Construct Angel

Large construct, lawful neutral

Armor Class 20 (living plate) | **Hit Points** 225 (18d10 + 126) | **Speed** 30 ft., fly 60 ft.

STR 22 (+6) **DEX** 16 (+3) **CON** 24 (+7) **INT** 14 (+2) **WIS** 18 (+4) **CHA** 19 (+4)

Saving Throws Con +12, Wis +9, Cha +9

Skills Insight +9, Perception +9

Damage Resistances cold, fire, lightning, necrotic; **Damage Immunities** poison, psychic; **Condition Immunities** charmed, exhaustion, frightened, poisoned

Senses truesight 60 ft., passive Perception 19 | **Languages** all languages, telepathy 120 ft. | **Challenge** 14 (11,500 XP)

Magic Resistance. The angel has advantage on saving throws against spells and other magical effects.

Radiant Lattice Aura. A hostile creature that starts its turn within 10 feet of the angel takes 7 (2d6) radiant damage.

Tower Link. While within 60 feet of an active lattice pylon or containment node, the angel regains 10 hit points at the start of its turn.

Immutable Form. The angel is immune to any spell or effect that would alter its form.

Actions

Multiattack. The angel makes two Halo Blade attacks and one Wing Strike attack.

Halo Blade. Melee Weapon Attack: +11 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. Hit: 19 (3d8

+ 6) slashing damage plus 9 (2d8) radiant damage.

Wing Strike. Melee Weapon Attack: +11 to hit, reach 15 ft., one target. Hit: 16 (3d6 + 6) bludgeoning damage, and the target must succeed on a DC 19 Strength saving throw or be pushed 20 feet and knocked prone.

Lattice Beam (Recharge 5-6). The angel releases a 60-foot line of radiant force that is 10 feet wide. Each creature in the line must make a DC 19 Dexterity saving throw, taking 45 (10d8) radiant damage on a failed save, or half as much on a successful one.

Containment Overload (1/Day). Each ward, magical barrier, and construct within 30 feet must succeed on a DC 18 spellcasting ability check or be suppressed until the end of the angel's next turn. Creatures in the area take 18 (4d8) force damage.

Reactions

Interception Wing. When a creature the angel can see within 10 feet is hit by an attack, the angel reduces the damage by 18 (3d8 + 5).

Legendary Actions

The creature can take 3 legendary actions, choosing from the options below. Only one option can be used at a time and only at the end of another creature's turn. It regains spent legendary actions at the start of its turn.

Wingbeat. The angel moves up to half its flying speed without provoking opportunity attacks.

Halo Strike. The angel makes one Halo Blade attack.

Lattice Pulse (Costs 2 Actions). Each hostile creature within 15 feet must succeed on a DC 19 Constitution saving throw or take 13 (3d8) radiant damage and be blinded until the end of its next turn.

Blackroot Equipment Reference

Item	Use	Duration
Anti-Lattice Weapon Coating	Once per turn, +1d6 radiant damage against aberrations and constructs.	Final chapter only
Gravity Anchor Boots	Ignore forced movement and prone until start of next turn; 1/short rest.	Final chapter only
Sigil Disruptor	Suppress regeneration and magical healing on one creature for 1 round.	One use
Living-Steel Aegis	Reduce force, psychic, or radiant damage by 1d10 +	Three charges

Item	Use	Duration
	proficiency bonus.	
Relay Lens	Advantage on one lattice-related Arcana, Investigation, or Perception check.	Recharges on short rest
Blackroot Containment Seal	Required for stabilization or reprogramming of the Ascension Engine.	Single campaign use

Chapter Clue Chain

Discovery	Meaning	Leads To
Resonance map	All prior settlement nodes synchronize through Aetherfall.	Outer tower nodes
Captured angel testimony	Three defenses protect Rabu Shin and the Gateway of Realities.	Aetherfall objectives
Varik’s seed-code	Rabu Shin can overwrite living and constructed systems remotely.	Consciousness relay
Containment seal	Defeating Rabu Shin without controlling the engine risks global mutation.	Final choice
One-way gateway	The final assault cannot be abandoned once begun.	Aetherfall finale

Transition to the Final Chapter

The party emerges from the gateway above the clouds, falling upward toward the outer ring of Aetherfall. Begin the final chapter with the city’s defenses activating and Rabu Shin welcoming the characters by name.

Final Chapter: Aetherfall - The Ascension of Krasis

Recommended Level: 12
Expected Party Strength: Fully rested and equipped with Blackroot enhancements
Campaign Finale: No further advancement is required.

AETHERFALL

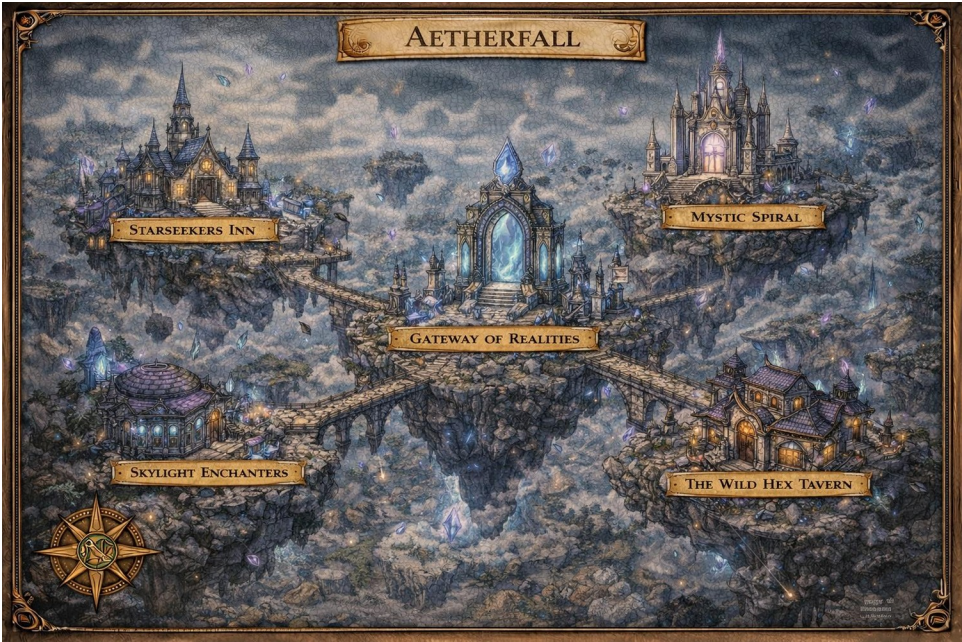
The gateway opens above the clouds. Gravity catches the characters and pulls them upward toward a city suspended against the stars. Towers bend inward around a radiant core of crystal and bone. Bridges curve across open sky, waterfalls stream into nothing, and geometric veins of silver-green light connect every structure. At the city’s center, a vast ring turns around an opening filled with impossible horizons. A calm voice speaks through every stone: “You have arrived precisely on schedule.”

Chapter Overview

Aetherfall is both a city and a continent-spanning arcane machine. Rabu Shin has encoded his consciousness into its lattice and intends to broadcast directed evolution through every node the characters encountered during the campaign. The final chapter is structured as a sequence of objectives rather than a single dungeon corridor. The party must disable the city’s defenses, sever the consciousness relay, confront the Prime Krasis, and decide the fate of the Ascension Engine.

Phase	Location	Primary Objective
I	Fractured Causeway	Reach the city and disable the first defensive node.
II	Angelic Perimeter	Destroy or subvert the remaining outer nodes.
III	Gravity Labyrinth	Cross the unstable city and reach the Mystic Spiral.
IV	Mystic Spiral	Defeat the Archbloom Orbweaver and sever the relay.
V	Gateway of Realities	Confront Rabu Shin and resolve the Ascension Engine.

Using the Aetherfall Map



Aetherfall: the floating nexus of the Krasis lattice.

The city map identifies the Gateway of Realities, Mystic Spiral, Shattered Ring, Sorcerer’s Rise, Mystic Stronghold, and the Twin Halo Towers. The party’s route may vary, but all paths eventually converge on the Gateway of Realities.

Aetherfall Environmental Rules

Rule	Effect
Gravity Flux	At initiative count 20, roll on the Gravity Flux table unless a node or encounter overrides it.
Open Sky	A creature pushed from a platform falls 40 feet before a reversal current catches it. It takes 4d6 bludgeoning damage and lands prone on a lower platform unless it can fly.
Lattice Resonance	Rabu Shin can speak through walls, constructs, and reflections. This communication is not a spell and cannot be countered.
Blackroot Equipment	All temporary enhancements function throughout this chapter. Expended charges do not return unless specifically stated.
Node Defenses	Each active outer node strengthens Rabu Shin. Record every node disabled before the final battle.

d6	Gravity Flux
1	Low gravity. Jump distance is tripled and falling damage is halved until the next count 20.
2	Sideways pull. Each creature must succeed on

	a DC 14 Dexterity save or slide 15 feet toward the eastern edge.
3	Heavy gravity. Speed is reduced by 10 feet and flying creatures descend 20 feet.
4	Inversion pulse. Each creature not anchored makes a DC 15 Dexterity save or falls prone and rises 10 feet into the air until the end of its next turn.
5	Stable interval. No additional effect.
6	Lattice surge. Constructs and aberrations gain 10 temporary hit points; a Blackroot disruptor can cancel the surge without using an action.

Phase I: The Fractured Causeway

FALLING UPWARD

Cold wind tears at you as the gateway closes below. The world curves beneath your feet, distant and blue. Ahead, shattered roads float in layers around Aetherfall's outer ring. Statues of winged figures turn their blank faces toward you. One after another, their eyes ignite with green light.

The party appears on three linked platforms 100 feet from the Shattered Ring. If Blackroot's gateway calibration failed, divide the characters between two adjacent platforms. Reuniting requires crossing a 20-foot gap by jumping, flying, rope, or a successful DC 14 group Athletics or Acrobatics check.

Outer-Ring Defenders

The causeway is guarded by 1 Flesh-Construct Angel and 2 Shield Guardians. The angel begins airborne and attempts to force characters from the road. The guardians hold the narrow crossing and use their reactions to protect the angel.

A character carrying the Resonance Compass can use a bonus action to identify the first node beneath a broken obelisk. The node has AC 17, 50 hit points, immunity to poison and psychic damage, and resistance to all damage until a character uses an action to succeed on a DC 16 Arcana, Investigation, or Thieves' Tools check to expose its core.

Node One: Regeneration Matrix

Disabling this node removes Rabu Shin's Regeneration trait during Phase 1 of the final battle. If the party bypasses it, Rabu Shin regains 15 hit points at the start of each turn unless he took radiant damage since his previous turn.

RABU SHIN OBSERVES

"You have learned to target systems rather than symptoms. Efficient. Blackroot has improved you." The angel's broken face turns toward the speaker's voice, though the words come from every direction. "Continue."

Phase II: The Angelic Perimeter

Beyond the Shattered Ring, the party can approach either the Twin Halo Towers or Sorcerer's Rise. Both routes contain one defensive node. The party may complete them in either order, split up, or skip one to conserve resources.

Route A: Twin Halo Towers

THE HALO TOWERS

Two needle-thin towers orbit one another without touching. A bridge of transparent light stretches between them. Above the bridge hangs a circular halo filled with hundreds of preserved faces, each whispering a different possible future.

The towers are guarded by 2 Flesh-Construct Angels. At initiative count 20, the halo selects one creature. That creature must make a DC 16 Wisdom saving throw or become restrained by visions until the end of its next turn. A creature can use an action to shatter a face within the halo, granting the target an immediate repeat of the save.

Node Two: Legendary Conduit

The node is suspended inside the halo. Reaching it requires flight, a DC 16 Athletics check while climbing the rotating tower, or activation of a Gravity Anchor Array. Destroying or disrupting it reduces Rabu Shin's available legendary actions from 3 to 2. If both the Legendary Conduit and Consciousness Relay are disabled, he has only 1 legendary action per round in the final phase.

Route B: Sorcerer's Rise

SORCERER'S RISE

A staircase spirals upward through empty air, each step appearing only after weight touches the one below. At the summit, six robed figures stand around a crystal pillar. Their faces are smooth mirrors. In each reflection, you see yourself wearing a different body.

The six figures are Lattice Echoes. Use the Mage stat block with 45 hit points, AC 15, and no 5th-level spells. They coordinate counterspells and use mirror image, misty step, lightning bolt, and hold person. When an echo falls, its mirror-face cracks and releases the memory of a person absorbed by the lattice.

Node Three: Resistance Matrix

The crystal pillar adapts to damage. At the end of each round, it gains resistance to the damage type that dealt the most damage to it that round. It has AC 16 and 60 hit points. A Sigil Disruptor removes all resistances until the end of the next round. Disabling the node prevents Rabu Shin from gaining resistance through Mutation Surge result 3 and removes one Legendary Resistance.

Optional Objective: The Mystic Stronghold

The stronghold contains prisoners whose minds were copied during Rabu Shin's experiments. Releasing them requires three successful DC 16 Arcana, Religion, or Medicine checks before two failures. Success grants the party the Memory Chorus: once during the final battle, one character can reroll a failed Intelligence, Wisdom, or Charisma saving throw. Failure awakens an Aetherfall Abomination.

THE PRESERVED MINDS

Crystal cylinders line the chamber. Within each, light twists into the outline of a person: a miner from Emberfall, a sailor from Stonewake, a soldier from High Bastion, a child from Silverreach. Their voices overlap. "He said we would survive. He never said we would remain ourselves."

Phase III: The Gravity Labyrinth

All routes converge on a district of rotating streets between the outer city and Mystic Spiral. The labyrinth is a moving skill challenge: 6 successes before 3 failures. Each character must contribute before the same character can act again.

Skill	Example Use
Acrobatics	Leap between rotating roads or land safely when gravity changes.
Arcana	Predict a gravity inversion or briefly stabilize a bridge.
Athletics	Hold a collapsing span or pull an ally across a gap.
Investigation	Identify which floating structures are real and which are lattice projections.
Perception	Spot a safe current among drifting debris.
Survival	Use wind, cloud movement, and falling debris to judge orientation.
Blackroot Equipment	Spend a charge from a Gravity Anchor Array for one automatic success.

On a failure, each character takes 2d8 force damage and the party expends one hit die or one Blackroot equipment charge of its choice. At three failures, the party reaches Mystic Spiral but awakens the Aetherfall Abomination that patrols beneath the city.

Phase IV: The Mystic Spiral

THE CONSCIOUSNESS RELAY

The tower’s interior is wider than the city outside. Rings of roots, crystal, eyes, and polished metal rotate around a vertical void. A colossal shape hangs at the center: a beholder’s many-eyed crown fused into the trunk of an ancient tree. Its roots disappear into thousands of glowing memories. Every eye opens at once.

The Archbloom Orbweaver guards the consciousness relay. The battle occurs on four circular platforms rotating around the central void. At initiative count 20, each platform rotates 90 degrees and moves 10 feet vertically. A creature standing within 5 feet of an edge must succeed on a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw or fall to the next platform, taking 2d6 bludgeoning damage and landing prone.

Relay Roots

Four relay roots connect the Orbweaver to the tower. Each root has AC 16, 30 hit points, immunity to psychic and poison damage, and vulnerability to radiant damage. A root destroyed during the battle reduces the Orbweaver’s regeneration by 5. Destroying all four shuts down its Mythic Reawakening and severs Rabu Shin’s distributed echo defense.

Victory at the Spiral

When the Orbweaver falls, the characters can sever the consciousness relay with the Consciousness Severance Seal or with 3 successful DC 17 Arcana, Religion, or Nature checks. On a failure, the acting character takes 4d8 psychic damage. Severing the relay removes Rabu Shin’s Lattice Echo phase. If it remains active, he divides into three echoes when reduced to half hit points.

RABU SHIN’S ADDRESS

The tower goes silent. A figure forms from the falling fragments: tall, calm, and threaded with geometric light. “You have exceeded projected survivability parameters. Most subjects fracture long before this stage. You adapt. Good.” He steps across the air as though gravity were optional. “You have mistaken my work for corruption. It is correction.”

Rabu Shin’s Offer

Rabu Shin does not attack immediately. He offers the characters ascension, promising freedom from aging, disease, and death. Allow each player to answer. A character who engages him in debate can make one DC 18 Persuasion, Insight, Arcana, Nature, or Religion check. Each unique success reveals one truth and grants one Conviction token. The party can spend a Conviction token to add 1d6 to any saving throw during the final battle.

Argument or Discovery	Rabu Shin’s Response
Evolution without consent is tyranny.	“Consent is a temporary preference produced by an imperfect nervous system.”
His methods preserve function but erase identity.	“Identity is pattern. Pattern can be retained, improved, and multiplied.”
The Krasis caused suffering he claims to eliminate.	“Transitional loss is mathematically smaller than perpetual natural loss.”
The party survived through cooperation, not forced design.	He pauses. “Cooperation is an adaptive mechanism. Your distinction is sentimental.”
He fears randomness because he cannot control it.	For the first time, his expression tightens. The speaker gains advantage on the next saving throw against him.

Phase V: The Gateway of Realities

THE FINAL ARENA

The Gateway of Realities turns above an endless void. Through it flicker forests, oceans, deserts, glaciers, and cities - every region touched by the lattice. Rabu Shin stands on a circular platform of crystal and living bone. Behind him, a thousand threads descend toward Vael Turog. “Aetherfall is not a throne,” he says. “It is proof.”

The final arena is a 100-foot-diameter circular platform surrounded by four pylons. Each pylon has AC 18, 45 hit points, immunity to poison and psychic damage, and resistance to nonmagical attacks. Destroying a pylon suppresses one battlefield effect and contributes to safely resolving the Ascension Engine.

Pylon	Battlefield Effect While Active
Pylon of Flesh	Rabu Shin regains 10 hit points at initiative count 20.
Pylon of Force	A 60-foot line of force crosses the arena; DC 17 Dexterity save, 4d10 force damage on failure, half on success.
Pylon of Gravity	All creatures make a DC 16 Strength save or move 20 feet toward the nearest edge.
Pylon of Thought	One character makes a DC 17 Wisdom save or is frightened of Rabu Shin until the next count 20.

Final Battle: Rabu Shin, the Prime Krasis

Phase 1 - Architect of Flesh

Rabu Shin begins with calculated battlefield control. He uses wall of force, reverse gravity, disintegrate, and his Warp Lash to separate characters and test their adaptations. He speaks throughout the battle and identifies successful tactics as though recording data.

Phase 2 - Distributed Consciousness

If the Mystic Spiral relay remains active, when Rabu Shin is first reduced to 125 hit points his body fractures into three Lattice Echoes. Each echo uses the Mage stat block with 60 hit points, AC 17, resistance to nonmagical damage, and one of the following themes: Force, Flesh, or Gravity. Rabu Shin cannot be damaged until all echoes are destroyed. If the relay was severed, skip this phase and Rabu Shin instead loses one Legendary Resistance.

Phase 3 - Prime Krasis

When Rabu Shin is reduced to 100 hit points after the echo phase, or immediately upon reaching 100 hit points if the phase was skipped, he fuses with the Ascension Engine. His size becomes Large, his reach increases by 5 feet, and he gains the Prime Form features in his stat block. The platform fractures into four sections. At initiative count 10 each round, one unoccupied 10-foot square falls into the void.

PRIME KRASIS

Rabu Shin's body opens into wings of crystalline bone and luminous tendrils. His voice now comes from the city, the gateway, and inside your own thoughts. "You cling to fragility. You romanticize decay. I sought to free you from hunger, plague, and death." The platform splits beneath him. "Adapt."

Defeating Rabu Shin

At 0 hit points, Rabu Shin does not die immediately. His body collapses into a geometric outline while the Ascension Engine begins an uncontrolled broadcast. Initiative continues. The party has 3 rounds to choose and complete one resolution. A character may use an action to attempt a required check, operate a pylon, protect an ally, or spend a Blackroot device for an automatic success when appropriate.

Final Choice: Destroy the Engine

Destroying the engine requires dealing 100 damage to its exposed core within 3 rounds. The core has AC 15, immunity to poison and psychic damage, and vulnerability to force and radiant damage. Each destroyed pylon reduces the required damage by 15. Success permanently collapses the lattice network, but Aetherfall begins to fall.

Escape requires 4 group successes before 2 failures using Athletics, Acrobatics, Arcana, Perception, or Blackroot equipment. On success, the Blackroot Containment Seal opens a return corridor at the last moment. On failure, each character takes 10d6 force damage before being thrown into the gateway; survivors land in a random settlement.

Final Choice: Stabilize and Shut Down

Stabilization requires 5 successes before 3 failures using Arcana, Religion, Nature, Smith's Tools, or the Resonance Phrase recovered in Sunspire. The base DC is 18, reduced by 1 for each disabled outer node or destroyed pylon. On success, Aetherfall slowly descends to a stable altitude and the lattice becomes inert. On failure, resolve the Mutation Surge table below, then allow one final attempt at DC 20.

Final Choice: Reprogram the Lattice

Reprogramming requires the Blackroot Containment Seal, the Ascension Engine Blueprint, and 5 successes before 3 failures at DC 19. Arcana, Nature, Religion, Medicine, and Persuasion may be used, but each skill can contribute only once. The party must define a governing principle such as voluntary adaptation, healing only, ecological restoration, or complete individual consent. Success preserves the network under that limitation. Failure allows the surviving fragment of Rabu Shin to influence the new directive.

d6	Uncontrolled Mutation Surge
1	Every creature gains one level of exhaustion as its body briefly adapts to impossible gravity.
2	One destroyed pylon rebuilds with 20 hit points.
3	The engine creates 2 Lesser Krasis adjacent to the core.
4	Each spellcaster loses one unexpended spell slot of the highest level available.
5	The arena partially phases; all checks until the end of the next round are made with disadvantage.
6	A benevolent memory from the released prisoners intervenes; the party gains one automatic success.

Rabu Shin’s Final Words

AT ZERO HIT POINTS

“So this is your answer.” He does not scream. Light fractures through him as the engine tears open. “Understand this: evolution does not require me. You adapted to defeat me. You changed.” His gaze passes across each of you. “You are my proof.”

- If the engine is destroyed, his final whisper is: “Iteration continues.”
- If the engine is stabilized, his final whisper is: “You chose control. Let us see how long you maintain it.”
- If the engine is reprogrammed, his final whisper is: “Refinement... collaborative.”

Campaign Resolution

If Aetherfall Is Destroyed

The lattice goes silent across Vael Turog. Mutated creatures remain changed, but no new directed transformations occur. Aetherfall collapses in a radiant implosion visible from every settlement. Rabu Shin becomes a warning told by arcanists, soldiers, farmers, and survivors.

If Aetherfall Is Stabilized

Aetherfall survives as an inert floating city. Lunareth and Blackroot establish a joint order to guard its archives. The party must decide who controls access, whether victims may recover stored memories, and whether any portion of the research should be preserved.

If the Lattice Is Reprogrammed

Controlled adaptation becomes possible, but every use becomes a moral and political decision. Silverreach seeks commercial access, High Bastion requests military applications, Marrowfen asks for ecological restoration, and Frostharbor hopes to prevent future famine. The characters become guardians of a power that can heal the world or quietly repeat Rabu Shin’s mistake.

Settlement Epilogues

Settlement	Possible Epilogue
Greymoor Hollow	The stream clears. A memorial stands at Shepherd’s Croft, where the first warped sheep revealed the threat.
Stonewake Port	The harbor reopens and the Grey Tern is restored as a vessel dedicated to hunting remaining aquatic Krasis.
Emberfall	The volcano returns to a natural rhythm. Miners seal the deepest crucible chamber beneath rune-forged stone.
Lunareth	The Argent Conclave publicly records its role in funding Rabu Shin and writes new laws governing biomanancy.
High Bastion	The fortress lowers its war banners and establishes a watch trained to recognize coordinated aberrant threats.
Marrowfen	Water returns to the fen. Strange but stable new species appear among the reeds, raising questions no victory can fully answer.
Silverreach	House Varin is dismantled, reformed, or replaced depending on the party’s choices. Victims demand restitution.
Duskmire Crossing	The caravan road becomes a memorial route, marked with names of those used in the mobile trials.
Frostharbor	The inward-cracking ice stops. The first spring thaw in years reveals ships long thought lost.
Sunspire	The Gene Vault becomes a sealed archive, a research sanctuary, or a ruin buried once more beneath the desert.
Blackroot Enclave	The council preserves the Blackroot Seal and begins studying how choice, not perfection, can guide change.
Aetherfall	Its fate becomes the defining legend of the age: fallen, guarded, or transformed.

Final Boxed Text

THE LATTICE IS SILENT

The sky clears. Across Vael Turog, green light fades from rivers, roots, crystal, ice, and stone. For a moment the world holds its breath. Then wind moves through the trees. Waves strike the shore. Somewhere far below, a sheep gives an ordinary, irritated bleat. For the first time since Greymoor Hollow, the lattice is silent.

Final Chapter Creature Reference

Aetherfall Beholder-Treant

Huge aberration, lawful evil

Armor Class 19 (natural armor) | Hit Points 285 (22d12 + 132) | Speed 20 ft., fly 30 ft. (hover)

STR 24 (+7) DEX 10 (+0) CON 23 (+6) INT 18 (+4) WIS 17 (+3) CHA 19 (+4)

Saving Throws Con +12, Int +10, Wis +9 | Skills Arcana +10, Perception +15

Damage Resistances cold, fire, lightning; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks

Condition Immunities prone | Senses truesight 120 ft., passive Perception 25 | Languages Deep

Speech, Elvish, telepathy 120 ft. | Challenge 15

ANTIMAGIC CONE. The central eye creates a 150-foot cone of antimagic, as the beholder trait.

ROOTED REGENERATION. The creature regains 15 hit points at the start of its turn while at least one relay root remains. Radiant damage suppresses this trait for one round.

ACTIONS

MULTIATTACK. The creature makes two Root Slam attacks and uses two different Eye Rays.

ROOT SLAM. Melee Weapon Attack: +13 to hit, reach 20 ft., one target. Hit: 20 (3d8 + 7) bludgeoning damage, and the target is grappled (escape DC 18).

EYE RAYS. The creature fires two rays chosen from Charm, Paralyzing, Fear, Slowing, Enervation, Telekinetic, Sleep, Petrification, Disintegration, or Death Ray. Save DC 18.

BRANCH STORM (Recharge 5-6). Creatures within 30 feet make a DC 18 Dexterity save, taking 36 (8d8) bludgeoning damage and falling prone on a failure, or half damage on a success.

LEGENDARY ACTIONS

The creature takes 3 legendary actions: Eye Ray (1), Root Step (1; move up to half speed without opportunity attacks), or Crushing Roots (2; one grappled target takes 18 bludgeoning damage).

Archbloom Orbweaver

Huge aberration, lawful evil

Armor Class 20 (lattice bark) | Hit Points 310 (23d12 + 161) | Speed 20 ft., fly 40 ft. (hover)

STR 22 (+6) DEX 14 (+2) CON 24 (+7) INT 21 (+5) WIS 18 (+4) CHA 20 (+5)

Saving Throws Con +13, Int +11, Wis +10, Cha +11 | Skills Arcana +17, Perception +16

Damage Resistances force, psychic; nonmagical bludgeoning, piercing, slashing

Condition Immunities charmed, frightened, prone | Senses truesight 120 ft., passive Perception 26 | Challenge 17

SPELLCASTING. Spell save DC 19, +11 to hit. At will: mage hand, ray of frost, thorn whip. 3/day each: counterspell, dispel magic, blight, wall of force. 1/day each: disintegrate, reverse gravity.

RELAY REGENERATION. The Orbweaver regains 20 hit points at the start of its turn, reduced by 5 for each destroyed relay root.

ROTATING AWARENESS. The Orbweaver cannot be surprised and has advantage on saving throws against spells.

ACTIONS

MULTIATTACK. The Orbweaver makes two Branch Lash attacks and uses two Eye Rays.

BRANCH LASH. Melee Weapon Attack: +12 to hit, reach 20 ft. Hit: 17 (2d10 + 6) slashing plus 9 (2d8) force damage.

EYE RAYS. Fires two beholder eye rays; save DC 19.

BRANCH TEMPEST (Recharge 5-6). Each creature within 40 feet makes a DC 19 Dexterity save, taking 45 (10d8) slashing and force damage on a failure, half on a success. Failed targets are pushed 20 feet.

LEGENDARY ACTIONS

Eye Ray (1), Platform Shift (1; rotate one platform and move creatures on it 10 feet), Cast a Cantrip (1), Severing Beam (2; one creature makes DC 19 Con save or takes 27 force damage and cannot regain hit points until next turn).

MYTHIC REAWAKENING. If reduced to 0 hit points while any relay root remains, the Orbweaver destroys one root, regains 100 hit points, and immediately uses Branch Tempest. This can occur once.

Aetherfall Abomination

Large aberration, chaotic evil

Armor Class 18 | Hit Points 190 (20d10 + 80) | Speed 40 ft., climb 40 ft.
STR 22 (+6) DEX 16 (+3) CON 19 (+4) INT 8 (-1) WIS 15 (+2) CHA 10 (+0)
 Saving Throws Str +11, Con +9, Wis +7 | Skills Athletics +11, Perception +7
 Damage Resistances acid, cold, fire, lightning | Condition Immunities frightened
 Senses darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 17 | Languages understands Deep Speech but cannot speak | Challenge 12
 ADAPTIVE HIDE. When the abomination takes elemental damage, it gains resistance to that damage type until the start of its next turn.
 GRAVITY CLING. The abomination moves normally on any solid surface regardless of gravity.
ACTIONS
 MULTIATTACK. Three attacks: two Claws and one Warp Bite.
 CLAW. Melee Weapon Attack: +11 to hit, reach 10 ft. Hit: 17 (2d10 + 6) slashing damage.
 WARP BITE. Melee Weapon Attack: +11 to hit, reach 5 ft. Hit: 24 (4d8 + 6) piercing and force damage; target makes DC 17 Strength save or is teleported up to 30 feet to a space the abomination can see.
 GRAVITY ROAR (Recharge 5-6). Creatures in a 30-foot cone make a DC 17 Strength save, taking 36 (8d8) force damage and being pushed 30 feet on a failure, half damage and no push on success.

Rabu Shin, the Prime Krasis

Medium aberration (Large in Prime Form), lawful evil

Armor Class 20 (adaptive lattice) | Hit Points 250 (20d8 + 160) | Speed 30 ft., fly 40 ft. (hover)
STR 14 (+2) DEX 18 (+4) CON 22 (+6) INT 20 (+5) WIS 18 (+4) CHA 18 (+4)
 Saving Throws Dex +10, Con +12, Int +11, Wis +10, Cha +10 | Skills Arcana +17, Insight +10, Perception +10
 Damage Resistances force, psychic; damage from nonmagical attacks | Damage Immunities poison
 Condition Immunities charmed, frightened, poisoned | Senses truesight 120 ft., passive Perception 20
 Languages all, telepathy 120 ft. | Challenge 20
LEGENDARY RESISTANCE (3/DAY). If Rabu Shin fails a saving throw, he can choose to succeed instead. Reduce this by one if the Resistance Matrix was disabled.
 REGENERATION. Rabu Shin regains 15 hit points at the start of his turn unless he took radiant damage since his last turn. This trait is removed if the Regeneration Matrix was disabled.
 MAGIC RESISTANCE. Rabu Shin has advantage on saving throws against spells and magical effects.
 MUTATION SURGE. At the start of each turn, roll d6: 1 Chitin Armor (AC 23 until next turn); 2 Rapid Regrowth (regain 20 hp); 3 Force Adaptation (resistance to last damage type taken until next turn); 4 Warp Step (teleport 30 ft.); 5 Tentacle Bloom (one extra Warp Lash attack); 6 Arcane Overload (next spell deals maximum damage). Result 3 is unavailable if the Resistance Matrix was disabled.
 SPELLCASTING. Spell save DC 19, +11 to hit. At will: mage hand, ray of frost, detect magic. 3/day each: counterspell, shield, blight, wall of force. 2/day each: disintegrate, dominate monster, reverse gravity. 1/day: power word stun.
ACTIONS
 MULTIATTACK. Rabu Shin makes two Warp Lash attacks or casts a spell and makes one Warp Lash attack.
 WARP LASH. Melee Spell Attack: +11 to hit, reach 15 ft. Hit: 24 (4d8 + 6) force damage, and Rabu Shin moves the target up to 15 feet.
 LATTICE BOLT. Ranged Spell Attack: +11 to hit, range 120 ft. Hit: 31 (7d8) force and psychic damage.
 FORCE NOVA (Recharge 5-6). Creatures within 30 feet make a DC 19 Strength save. Failure: 45 (10d8) force damage, pushed 30 feet, and prone. Success: half damage and no push.
REACTIONS
 ADAPTIVE COUNTER. When damaged by a spell, Rabu Shin gains advantage on the next save against a spell cast by that creature before the end of his next turn.
LEGENDARY ACTIONS
 Rabu Shin takes 3 legendary actions, reduced by disabled nodes: Warp Step (1; teleport 30 ft.), Lattice Bolt (1), Cast a Cantrip (1), Warp Lash (2), or Restructure Space (3; create or remove a 15-foot wall of force until the start of his next turn).
PRIME FORM (AT 100 HP). Rabu Shin becomes Large, gains 50 temporary hit points, his reach increases

by 5 feet, and he gains a flying speed of 60 feet. At the start of each of his turns, two Lesser Krasis appear in unoccupied spaces within 30 feet unless the consciousness relay was severed. While in Prime Form, Force Nova recharges on 4-6.

Lesser Krasis

Use the Thug stat block with AC 15, 32 hit points, aberration type, resistance to force damage, and the following attack: Lattice Claw, +5 to hit, 1d8 + 3 slashing plus 1d6 force damage. Lesser Krasis created during the final battle disappear when the Ascension Engine is resolved.

Finale Reference: Disabled Defenses

Objective Completed	Final Benefit
Regeneration Matrix disabled	Rabu Shin loses Regeneration.
Legendary Conduit disabled	Rabu Shin has one fewer legendary action each round.
Resistance Matrix disabled	Rabu Shin loses one Legendary Resistance and cannot gain adaptive damage resistance.
Mystic Stronghold prisoners freed	Party gains the Memory Chorus reroll.
Consciousness Relay severed	Skip the Lattice Echo phase; Rabu Shin cannot summon Lesser Krasis in Prime Form.
Each pylon destroyed	Removes its initiative effect and reduces final engine difficulty.
Blackroot preparations completed	Apply the support tier and equipment earned in Chapter 11.

Campaign Completion Checklist

Question	Record
What became of the Ascension Engine?	Destroyed / Stabilized / Reprogrammed
Did Aetherfall survive?	
Which settlements did the party save or transform?	
Which allies survived the campaign?	
What principle, if any, governs future biomancy?	
What final trace of Rabu Shin remains?	